

THE CAGES BUILT BY LOVING HANDS

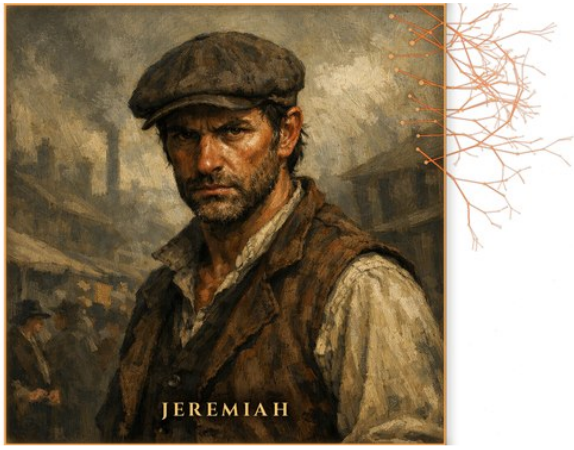
NEO LUDDITES · BOOK ONE

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BOOK ONE

Prologue



A flock of dirty pigeons rose in unison, streaming towards the faint glow of the midday sun. Its light barely pierced the haze of coal smoke that hung over the town. Jeremiah, a weathered man in his late thirties with calloused hands and a face lined from years at the loom, was propped casually against a pillar, looking out across the market square. The bright coloured stalls were all draped in the same brownish-grey canvas—a dull sea of fabric that flowed to all corners of the square.

The clock on the Exchange struck noon as stockingers from the workshops and back streets poured into the square, merging with the heavy crowd of shoppers. They muttered angrily to each other, bringing a dark mood that spread through the crowds like wildfire. The discontent caught quickly, voices rising with heat. Something was about to happen.

That was why Jeremiah was there. From the mouth of an alley, a man caught his eye and tipped his flat cap. It was time—everyone was in place. Jeremiah pulled his hands from his waistcoat pockets, tipped his cap in return, and slipped into the crowd as angry shouts broke out around the square.

"Down with those devilish machines!" and "We won't starve so the hosiers can grow fat!" The crowd roared in response. His men were whipping them into a frenzy. Jeremiah pushed his way to the steps of the Exchange and turned to face them. He spread his arms wide and projected his voice to carry over the noise. The rabble fell silent.

"Stockingers! Framework knitters! Fair, hardworking people of Nottingham! Hear me now! Enough is enough!" The shouting died to a murmur as they turned to face him. "Our employers have conspired against us, and unless we act soon, we'll all be on the street begging while our children starve!" This was met with a roar of agreement. "They don't care about us—only profits! They cut our wages to the bone, put untrained boys on our frames, and churn out shoddy cut-ups on those infernal wide frames!"

At the mention of the wide frames, the crowd went wild. It was quickly turning into an angry mob. Jeremiah would have said more, but he could see they were past the point of listening. Instead, he melted back into the sea of waving fists.

A young lad with dirt on his cheeks squeezed through the mob and ran up the steps. His eyes were wide with excitement as he grabbed Jeremiah's sleeve.

"The bloody soldiers are here, Jere!" he whispered frantically. "Time to go!"

Jeremiah spotted a troop of Dragoons forming up on the other side of the square. Rigid on horseback, sabres at their sides and carbines slung. He hurried down the steps and threw himself into the crowd. People slapped him on the back and shook his hand as he tried to squeeze through.

"Tonight at Arnold," he told them as he passed. "We'll show them we mean business."

As darkness fell on the village of Arnold, so did the crowds of angry workers. The young lad scampered up to Jeremiah, who was waiting in a shadowed alley.

"They're coming, Jere! Thousands of them!" he panted, breathless with enthusiasm.

"Are you ready?" Jeremiah asked. The lad nodded but looked nervous, sniffing and rubbing his nose.

"What if they find out it was us behind it all?"

Jeremiah smiled and patted the lad on the shoulder. "We'll tell them Lud did it."

He nodded and strolled out to stand outside the first of the houses where old Bolton's frames were kept. He shifted the axe in his hands and waited for the mob to arrive. They came with torches, sledgehammers, and fury. Thousands strong, they forced their way into the houses and smashed the frames within. They raged until dawn. By the time a troop of Dragoons rode in the next morning to clear the village, sixty frames lay in pieces.

Chapter 1

Al'thea



The neural immersion field always left her slightly disoriented, the jolt of surfacing from someone else's two-thousand-year-old memory into her own body again. Around her, other students aboard the Teacher's Vessel were already activating their workstations, blue light coalescing from their neural interfaces into floating screens. But Al'thea sat still, blinking away the phantom sensations of soot and grime that the quantum memory download —Jeremiah's own memory of that riot in Nottingham, replayed for the whole class as their history lesson—had imprinted on her consciousness.

"At the turn of the 19th century, the industrial revolution was in full swing." The Elder's voice cut through her lingering immersion as he began the lecture. "The new machines threatened to replace skilled workers with cheaper, unskilled labour, leaving the artisans without work."

Al'thea hated ancient history. *It's just so... ancient,* she thought, smirking at her own childish reaction. She finally activated her workspace, and the shimmering blue interface materialised at waist height, responding to her neural patterns. Teachers were always scolding her for her flippant attitude. *I should know better,* she thought, trying to clear the lingering sensory echoes from the quantum memory download.

As the Elder droned on, his voice seemed to blend with the steady hum of the ship's engines.

"In 1779, a young factory worker named Ned Ludd smashed two machines in a fit of rage. The story spread across England. Whenever a machine broke down, people would joke that 'Ned Ludd did it.' This eventually evolved into the mythical leader of the Luddite movement: General Ludd. As we just witnessed, on March 11th, 1811, in Nottingham, England, the Luddite movement truly began..."

Al'thea's mind began to drift. *Who cares about this?* she thought. *We were barely out of the caves back then, stuck on one little planet, choking on our own pollution.* Two thousand years ago, humans hadn't even known how to produce clean energy. They'd actually

dug up old waste from the planet's crust and burned it for fuel. The pollution had nearly destroyed the only ecosystem they had. *Idiots.*

Al'thea tried to pay enough attention to cover the basics—ignorance annoyed her more than anything. But when it came to ancient human history, she found it hard to care about specific details. *It's all so primitive, so depressing,* she thought. She understood it from an evolutionary psychology perspective, but couldn't see the point of memorising names and dates from that era. *If we had to memorise every caveman's name, would they make us do that too?* She sighed quietly. *Probably.*

The classroom's domed ceiling stretched around them, its support beams gleaming as they wove across the transparent surface in giant swirling patterns. *Artisans,* Al'thea rolled her eyes. *Such show-offs.* The decorative beams were completely unnecessary—even the glass dome itself was pointless. The ship's force fields were more than sufficient protection, and the dome wouldn't stop anything if they failed.

I definitely don't want to be an Artisan. They were ranked by how many times their designs got used. Certain projects, like the specs for a ship like this one, were worth more prestige than others. Even the Artisans who just designed practical equipment couldn't resist burying it under layers of decoration. If you stripped away all the fancy details, it would still be beautiful underneath. *It's all about*

showing off to beat the competition, Al'thea mused. *Still, it is pretty.* If she were honest, she'd be the first to complain if everything looked ugly and poorly designed. *It's just not for me.*

Al'thea stirred from her daydream to find herself staring out through the dome. The stars hung motionless against the deep black of space, the ship holding steady at sublight. Some of the light washing over the dome had left its stars before Ned Ludd was born. *Now that's ancient history,* she thought. *Funny how nobody makes us memorise that.* The Elder's voice came sharply back into focus along with her forgotten irritation.

"...the war's technological arms race coincided with our first real understanding of the human mind. Combined with the development of interconnected networks—what they called the 'Internet'—and the first artificial intelligences, this led to a devastating cyber-psychological war that became the foundation of the modern Luddite movement..."

Al'thea looked down at her workspace to see if she'd taken any notes while her mind wandered. She often did it unconsciously. Inside the glowing borders, however, was a messy scrawl of strange symbols and doodles. Al'thea frowned, biting her lip. *Not again. This really isn't helping my grades.*

Her unconscious note-taking had let her coast through her training years. She'd memorise her notes quickly before exams and fill in the gaps with educated guesses. She didn't get the best marks, but she scored better than most other Trainees. Plus, she never had to pay attention—leaving her mind free to wander.

But lately, her notes were becoming increasingly messy. *I don't care enough,* she thought grimly. *I'm getting too cocky, too lazy.* Al'thea was thirty-two by Earth Standard Time. She had eight years of training left, but would soon have enough credits to secure a decent position in any guild she chose, once she passed her Ascension trials.

A soft chime echoed through the classroom. The gentle sound reverberated through the vast space, seeming to ripple the swirling patterns on the dome. *Lunch time.* Al'thea smiled.

She stood and flicked her wrist, making her workspace disappear. Around her, the complex arrangement of seats, screens, and control panels blinked out of existence as other students did the same. The Teacher continued at a rushed pace, trying to cram in last-minute information before they all scattered for food.

"Next session we'll cover the aftermath of the Third World War—the Dark Age. Please review the material on Luddite Guerrillas and the Technocrats in the database." *He always runs past the bell,* Al'thea thought. *Rambling old fool.* She immediately felt bad for the harsh thought.

Al'thea guessed he must be close to three hundred years old, judging by his slightly sagging skin and the small wrinkles around his eyes. In the Teachers Guild, the highest honour was instructing the young. However, Al'thea doubted he spent much time outside his lectures actually teaching. Teachers were the keepers of knowledge, the record-holders. They looked both forward and backward through time, and as the old saying went, knowledge was power.

Her stomach growled, and she hurried towards the door with the other trainees, wondering if the rumour about the food hall serving Raeloth pie was true.

Students clustered around the exit, creating a bottleneck. The doorway was wide enough for smooth flow, but only if people actually wanted to move quickly. Instead, they formed little groups, leaning close to exchange whispered gossip. *Slowing everyone down,* Al'thea thought with frustration.

It reminded her of bacteria multiplying—no apparent direction or purpose. She understood the politics, of course. When this many Trainees were forced together, the opportunity to spread useful rumours or spy on rivals was too tempting to resist. *But for crying out loud, it's lunch time!*

Someone stepped close to her. "Thea, do you have some free time before next class?"

Al'thea sighed and definitely didn't feel any flutter when she met those crystal blue eyes. "De'to, it's lunch time," she said simply, as if that explained everything. She turned and pushed through the crowd, leaving him staring after her.

Out in the corridor, sunlight streamed from a deep blue sky dotted with puffy white clouds. A flock of birds swirled overhead, their songs mixing with the rustle of leaves in the breeze. Fields of wheat and pasture stretched across rolling hills, and a stream wound through the landscape, glittering in the light.

The corridors on Teacher's Ships could display any environment the crew chose—computer-generated worlds that looked and felt completely real, the ship's own hum dampened out of the corridors to complete the illusion. This rotation's theme was apparently Earth countryside. *Such a boring choice,* Al'thea thought. *Where's the imagination?*

Since this was a Teacher's Vessel, the environments were created by Trainees who volunteered for the projects. The ship's community voted on which designs to use. *Show-offs with too much free time and not enough self-awareness,* Al'thea decided.

She took one of the smaller paths winding down the hill, away from the crowds and towards the stream. Al'thea spotted her friend Za'ra leaning against a tree, sunlight gleaming off her auburn hair as she twisted strands through her fingers, watching fish in the water. Al'thea's own hair was doing what it always did—escaping its tie in a halo of unruly gold curls she'd long since

stopped trying to control. Za'ra had positioned herself so the breeze fluttered her skirts just enough to occasionally reveal glimpses of her slender legs. She seemed completely unaware of this, though a couple of younger male students across the river were staring at her in amazement.

Al'thea chuckled as she walked down to meet her. *Such a tease.* She knew she was jealous of her beautiful friend, but it was mixed with genuine admiration.

"Hey Zar, stop posing—it's lunch time!" Al'thea called, just loud enough for the boys to hear. Their eyes went wide and they hurried away. Za'ra turned with a dramatic pout.

"Oh Thea, why do you always have to ruin my fun?" she complained, though her eyes sparkled with humour.

"Because you're a terrible tease, that's why!" Al'thea replied, grinning. Za'ra laughed—a musical sound—and gracefully linked arms with Al'thea, guiding them towards the food hall.

"My dear, serious friend," Za'ra said playfully, "how are things with your one true love?"

"De'to is *not* my one true love!" Al'thea said, exasperated.

"Then why is he the only one you sleep with? Surely you must get bored. There are so many delightful people to choose from." Her eyes lingered on a group of young men playfully shoving each other as they headed towards the recreational areas. "Everyone

thinks you're a prude, you know. Who ever heard of having just one lover at a time? It's almost selfish—think of all the poor souls you're denying. I know there's real passion hiding under those practical clothes!"

Al'thea wasn't exactly fashionable, and she was painfully aware of how plain she looked next to Za'ra's flowing elegance. But her pride wouldn't let her indulge in such frivolous concerns.

"Have you ever been with another woman?" Za'ra's tone was innocent, but Al'thea saw the invitation in her eyes and couldn't deny the heat that rose in response. A few people claimed to be interested in only one gender, but they were rare and generally viewed with scepticism.

"I'm not a prude," Al'thea defended herself. "It's just less complicated this way." She hoped the topic would drop. Fortunately, Fal'le and Me'dan appeared, saving her from further questioning.

"Hey there, ladies!" Fal'le greeted them cheerfully. He was tall and striking, with pale skin and golden hair that flopped to one side of his face. His grin always made his eyes sparkle. Me'dan was his opposite—small and dark, but powerfully built. His intense dark eyes locked onto Al'thea as the two men flanked the women. Fal'le and Za'ra immediately began chattering to each other, while Me'dan gave Al'thea a friendly smile.

"I have a Razor match this afternoon, and I want you there to support me. No excuses." He wagged his finger at her with a mock frown.

"You know exactly what I think of that testosterone-fuelled glorification of violence, Me'dan," Al'thea glared at him. "I'm not going to support it, and you only ask me because you like getting me worked up!"

"Well, it works, doesn't it?" Me'dan laughed. "Come on, Thea, I really do want you there. I know you hate it, but it would mean a lot to me. It's the semi-final, and I'm up against some really tough opponents." Seeing she wasn't convinced, he continued, "You're wrong about Razor. It's not glorifying violence—it's an outlet for drives and emotions that might otherwise come out as real violence. It's an advanced tool for controlling the violent impulses we still carry as humans." His voice grew more passionate. "Razor is actually the height of civilisation!" He glared at her triumphantly.

Al'thea rolled her eyes and made a dismissive noise. "That might have been true for our primitive ancestors, before genetic modification. I mean, I can only speak for myself, but I think we've evolved past that."

"No! Because attempts to reduce violent drives through genetic engineering went horribly wrong. It left entire generations listless and without motivation!"

"Still, they learned from those mistakes and managed to dial it back somewhat. We're nowhere near as violent as our ancestors. I'll grant that physical, competitive activities have various benefits, including being outlets for certain drives. But there's no evidence that an obviously violent game like Razor has any advantages over non-violent physical competition." The look of triumph was slowly fading from Me'dan's face as she spoke, and Al'thea drank in his defeat with wicked satisfaction. "Therefore, Razor *is* just unnecessary glorification of violence."

That settles it, she thought smugly. It wasn't that Al'thea enjoyed putting Me'dan down—it was that she loved intellectual combat. A battle of minds, thoughts as sharp as blades, clashing against each other. *Though it's hardly a fair fight when only one of us is actually thinking.* It didn't occur to Al'thea that what she enjoyed about debate was exactly what Me'dan found in Razor.

"You mean like your puzzle games, Thea?" Za'ra asked. Her sweet voice and curious expression hid the gentle criticism in the words, but Al'thea caught it. When the mood struck her, Al'thea liked to design elaborate puzzle challenges—physical and mental tests where you had to escape rooms or navigate difficult environments. No one seemed to enjoy them much, though. *Probably too challenging for the average person,* she thought, and didn't bother hiding the spite.

"Yes, like my puzzles. Have you tried the latest one?" she asked, trying to turn Za'ra's criticism back on her.

"Well, they're a bit difficult, Thea," Fal'le chimed in, smirking. She turned on him, trying not to snap.

"Have you actually managed to complete even one of them, Fal'le?"

"You make them impossibly hard! You only know how to solve them because you designed them." Fal'le answered defensively. Me'dan jumped in before things could escalate.

"I thought using the rope to swing out and throw the weight to reach the lever was brilliant!" Me'dan mimed the throwing motion as he described it. Al'thea beamed at him, but Fal'le looked confused. "You know, in the warehouse puzzle—the rope was wrapped around the ceiling beam and you had to climb up and unwind it." Me'dan explained, but Fal'le still looked blank. Za'ra laughed at his confusion, and he looked down, kicking a stone moodily.

"And the one where the key was at the bottom of the pond, and you had to make a diving bell from a large Kriack leaf," Za'ra added, smiling knowingly at Al'thea. Later, Al'thea would marvel at how easily Za'ra managed to distribute both praise and gentle correction among her friends while keeping everyone happy. Right now, she was just pleased that Za'ra had actually tried her latest puzzle.

"Okay, fine," Al'thea announced. The others looked at her questioningly as she took Me'dan's arm. "I'll come to your barbaric game." Me'dan's face lit up and Al'thea smiled at him. "But don't expect me to cheer." Me'dan laughed. Za'ra caught her eye and winked as she began coaxing Fal'le out of his sulk.

Cypress trees dotted the hills around a large building—an eighteenth-century Italian manor house. Its bold, rectangular walls matched the dusty colour of the path winding through fields towards it. The group made their way up the path. A trick of the holographic perspective made the journey much shorter than it appeared. People sprawled on the lawns, enjoying cold drinks and picnic food in the sunshine. Others clustered around the entrance, waiting to go inside.

"Let's go in—I want to sit at a proper table," Za'ra said.

"Good idea. This sun is hurting my eyes anyway," Me'dan agreed. No one ever disagreed with Za'ra, but maybe that was only because she never said anything anyone would want to disagree with.

The food hall was bustling with activity, filled with the comfortable noise of conversation and clinking utensils. Al'thea found herself relaxing for the first time in days, enjoying the simple pleasure of good food and better company. The Raeloth pie turned out to be real, and delicious.

But as they finished their meal and prepared to leave for the next session, Al'thea felt a familiar weight settling in her stomach. Ancient history again. More names and dates from humanity's primitive past. She said goodbye to her friends and made her way back to the classroom, already dreading the afternoon ahead.

CHAPTER 2

The Naming



As Al'thea entered the classroom for the afternoon session, the boredom settled back over her all over again. More ancient history. More primitive human conflicts that seemed irrelevant to modern life.

She took her usual seat near the back and activated her workspace, letting her mind drift as the Elder began his lecture on post-industrial social movements. Around her, other students dutifully took notes, their neural interfaces flickering with data streams.

Halfway through the session, Al'thea felt a strange tingling in her mind—not quite a thought, but something more direct. A presence touching the edges of her consciousness through her neural interface.

"Al'thea."

She jerked upright, looking around. None of the other students seemed to have noticed anything. The Elder continued his lecture, unaware. But the voice in her mind was unmistakably real.

"Do not react. Do not look around. Listen carefully."

Her heart pounded as she tried to appear normal, keeping her eyes on her workspace while her mind reeled. Someone was speaking directly into her consciousness through her neural interface—but that should be impossible. Trainees didn't have access to advanced telepathic communication.

"My name is Ba'than. What you are experiencing is a restricted neural communication protocol. Only those with Higher Arts mastery can initiate such contact."

Al'thea's eyes widened, but she forced herself to remain still. Ba'than—the Elder who had been giving the lecture—but how could he be speaking to her telepathically while continuing to teach?

"You have questions about your place in this system. About the patterns you see but cannot yet understand. I can provide answers, but not here. Not now."

The presence in her mind felt ancient, tired, but somehow sympathetic. Whatever this Ba'than was, he was far more than just another Teacher.

"H-Suite 3.56, first hour of gamma rotation. Come alone. Tell no one of this contact. Your enhanced cognitive development has attracted attention—both from those who would use you and those who would free you."

The presence withdrew from her mind as suddenly as it had arrived, leaving Al'thea feeling oddly empty. She looked up at the Elder giving the lecture—was this Ba'than? But he showed no sign of having just conducted a telepathic conversation. His attention seemed completely focused on the lesson.

Enhanced cognitive development? The phrase echoed in her mind. What did that mean? And how had he known about her unconscious note-taking, the strange symbols she'd been drawing?

The rest of the class passed in a blur. Al'thea tried to pay attention, but her mind kept returning to the impossible conversation. When the session ended, she watched the Elder carefully as students filed out. He seemed perfectly normal—tired, focused on his notes, paying no special attention to her.

But as she reached the door, she felt one final touch in her mind: *"Trust carefully, question everything, and remember—some cages are built by loving hands."*

The next three days taught Al'thea that hiding in her room, socially and psychologically isolated, never really accomplished anything. It did, however, have a strangely compelling appeal. Her consciousness flowed on waves of thoughts—competing ideas

spawning questions, answers, and new thoughts, ever rising, ever growing. It came to her suddenly that it was all her own creation, based only on her limited experience. She seemed to rise above the wave and look down. She could feel every thought, every flow. She mapped out streams of consciousness, weaving new patterns, crafting more efficient paths for ideas to travel. Time became meaningless in the intricate maze. But she was just one isolated stream of consciousness. One voice speaking alone. No spoken language was complex enough to truly express the language of the mind. *I need to Ascend.*

When a person underwent Ascension, they were connected to the Arc network. A neural interface made it possible to communicate by stimulating your mirror neurons—copying someone else's brain patterns in real time directly into your mind. A vastly complex computer controlled the sending and receiving, uploading to the Arc network and downloading from others nearby by default. The computer served as both a broadcasting platform and a translator. *I want to swim in an ocean of thoughts—connected waves, part of a greater whole, yet still distinct and individual.*

For so long, Al'thea's species had been mentally isolated. Using crude sounds in primitive spoken language, people's consciousness could only stay connected through shared reactions and common thought patterns reinforced by language. The gap between individual minds and the words that linked them—as with many intelligent non-telepathic species—had two major effects: It created a selfish psychology based on individual gain that worked

against successful cooperation, and it made deception not just possible but socially fundamental. This became the foundation of their psychological evolution, leading to violent and bloody struggles just to reach a level that most naturally telepathic species started from. They were one of the rare non-telepathic intelligent species to actually survive their own nature. *By chance,* Al'thea mused. *Violence breeds violence, passing down through generations like a disease. Stupid humans. I wish I was a Boron.* Al'thea could feel reality tugging at her awareness.

BEEP. The neural alert filled her consciousness. For a split second, Al'thea was paralyzed, able only to experience her physical senses rushing back. She jerked upright, gasping and dizzy, her vision blurred. The words "URGENT // Father: Requesting Contact // URGENT" blazed directly into her visual cortex through her neural interface. *BEEP.* Everything else was dark.

"Okay... audio only," Al'thea croaked, gesturing for the neural feed to minimise. It shifted to the far wall, her father's holographic projection small and angry against a mountain vista.

"Where on *earth* have you been!" Seeing his position, Al'thea smiled lazily at both the view and his old-fashioned expression. She beckoned for the screen to come closer.

"Hi, Dad," she said, noticing the number of missed calls and raising an eyebrow. *He's angry. What's going on?* She sat up straighter and gestured to the screen. It expanded to full size, and a three-dimensional projection of her father stepped into the room.

"Al'thea, where have you been? The joining ceremony with your Arrok is in less than two hours!"

"Oh, crap! Sorry, Dad! I've been busy with... a project," she lied sleepily.

"Learning the sacred rituals and reflecting on the importance of this honour?" he asked rhetorically. Al'thea made a face. "Well," he sighed, "you have just enough time to memorise the basics, but you need to start now!"

"Right, I'm on it," she said, giving her best smile.

"I can see you want to be left alone. We'll talk later. Good luck." He smiled. "And watch your language!" He winked out of existence.

Al'thea's focus widened to take in the whole room as the lights automatically brightened. Her pupils dilated with shock and her jaw dropped. Throughout the room, strange symbols hung in the air, delicately connected in three-dimensional patterns written in hard light. She had to walk around to see it all. It was beautiful. It was terrifying.

This is like my doodles, she realised with growing horror. No one could have entered her room while she was unaware. *Which definitely means I'm losing my mind.*

Panic gripped her. If someone saw these symbols, they'd think she was completely insane. She moved quickly through the room, gesturing to dismiss each pattern. The hard light constructs dissolved at her touch, leaving no trace of their existence. By the time she finished, the room looked completely normal again.

Someone requested entry at her door. Al'thea was annoyed by the interruption. *Who's bothering me now?*

"Show door view," she commanded, and a screen appeared showing the corridor outside her quarters. Her pulse quickened when she recognised De'to nervously wringing his hands. The corridor's current theme was a magical forest, and De'to was framed by soft light from glowing plants hanging from twisted trees, highlighting his perfect crystal-blue eyes. She opened the doors.

"Hey, Thea, sorry to bother you, but I haven't seen you in days and I was worried..." De'to said nervously. Al'thea said nothing but rushed to him and pulled him into an eager embrace. She pulled him inside, and the door closed automatically behind them.

Afterward, she lay curled against him in the bed's zero-gravity field, warmth and contentment flowing through her, already thinking about her puzzle designs instead of him.

"But I haven't finished yet!" De'to complained.

"Just take care of it yourself," Al'thea said carelessly, and was asleep before he'd finished complaining.

She startled awake to her own bracelet chiming the time, De'to's warmth already gone from beside her — he'd actually let himself out, for once. *Crap. Crap, crap, crap.* Fifteen minutes. She threw on the first robe within reach and ran.

The ceremony hall was a modest circular chamber near the training decks, its walls dimmed to a soft amber that made everyone in their formal robes look faintly gilded. She slid into place at the edge of the gathered Trainees, out of breath and underdressed under her robe, just as an Elder — not Ba'than, she noted, with something that was almost disappointment — began the invocation: a string of old ceremonial words nobody quite remembered the literal meaning of anymore, just the shape of the ritual itself.

One by one, attendants moved down the line of Trainees, settling a small black shape onto each outstretched arm — the moment, she understood only now, standing here late and slightly panicked, when a Trainee received the companion they'd carry for the rest of their life, and gave it, on the spot, its first and only name. She'd never actually asked anyone what they'd named theirs. It had never seemed important before this exact second, with an unfamiliar weight suddenly settling onto her own outstretched arm and every eye in the room politely not looking at how late she'd arrived.

She turned her head, startled, and found herself looking directly into a small, dark eye ringed with a thin band of the same oil-slick blue that ran through his plating — sharp, unimpressed, and very much alive, set into a face built otherwise of finely overlapping

plates instead of down and feather, each one edged in a faint inner light like the seam of a well-made instrument. An Arrok, unmistakably — the whole shape and temper of a raven poured into a hundred small mechanisms and given somewhere to perch, down to the precise, articulated metal legs gripping her arm with a raven's exact proportions and none of a real bird's fragility. He regarded her with the wounded indignation of a creature that had strong opinions about being handed to a stranger who'd shown up half-dressed and out of breath, and made no move to close the rest of the distance himself. For several long seconds he simply stayed where he'd been set, weight balanced on her forearm, that small dark eye tracking her face with a stillness that felt entirely too deliberate for something freshly made — cataloguing her, she would think much later, the way you catalogued anything you meant to remember for a long time. Only once she'd gone quiet under the scrutiny, more from instinct than patience, did he shuffle the last short distance up her arm on his own, unbidden, and settle his weight against her collarbone. He bumped his beak once against her jaw, a single flat knock that felt more like a verdict than a greeting — a conclusion he'd arrived at, not a default he'd started from.

Say something. Her mind went, unhelpfully, completely blank. Then, not unhelpfully at all, it didn't. The oil-slick blue of his plating caught the amber light as he shifted against her, entirely unbothered by the solemnity of the room around them.

"Ny'sol," she said, and the word felt right the instant it left her mouth, the way the correct answer to a puzzle always did. He turned to look at her properly, for the first time, and made a low, rattling sound in his throat that she chose, for her own sanity, to interpret as approval.

The Elder nodded once, satisfied, and moved on to the next Trainee. Nobody applauded. Nobody needed to.

CHAPTER 3

ASHES



An alert chimed in her room, displaying "Reminder: H-Suite 3.56, first hour of gamma rotation. Ten Minutes." Groaning awake, her heart racing, she jumped from bed and frantically gathered her scattered clothes.

"Don't I even get a goodbye kiss?" De'to pouted as Al'thea rushed towards the door.

"Sorry, De'to! I have to run—let yourself out!" she called over her shoulder as she hurried through the doors, where Ny'sol was waiting on the corridor's nearest branch — he'd spent the night exactly there, apparently having decided that whatever privacy meant to her, it meant this. He dropped onto her shoulder without breaking her stride.

She raced through the ship's corridors, Ny'sol riding her shoulder in irritated silence, wings mantled tight against the wind of her own running, already developing opinions about how much of belonging to her was going to involve running. She barely acknowledged friends and supervisors who called out, asking where she'd been or simply trying to say hello. This rotation's corridor theme was a coastal landscape. *This can't be the most efficient route. Maybe I should start voting on these things.*

The small sun was setting low, casting warm light across white cliffs where gentle waves lapped at their base. Scattered vegetation across the plains created long shadows that defined the landscape. Near the hilltop, woods appeared beyond the rise. As she reached the trees, the sun disappeared below the horizon. Softly glowing insects provided lights along a path through the trees. Al'thea plunged into the darkness, taking what she knew was a more direct route.

Rain began falling. *Had to be a realism enthusiast, didn't it?* Pushing harder seemed to make the rain worse. She was soon drenched. Her personal force field could light everything she needed to see and, if she wanted, could filter out the rain. *And the cold wind. And the mud. And any real experience at all.* Al'thea couldn't see the point in that.

Her small bubble of light moved through the wood, which was rapidly becoming a dense forest. Thick undergrowth brushed her legs, and she occasionally had to use a light-tool to cut through

heavier branches. Massive trees rose from complex root systems, bright points of light scattered through gaps in the canopy above, hinting at swirling patterns centred on a large red moon.

Lightning flooded her vision with detail. Huge purple petals drooped from branches growing evenly up thick trunks. The trees were crowned with dense foliage, connected by webs of strong-looking vines. In the sharp light, transparent leaves covering the vines shone, their intricate shapes harmonising with the star patterns above. Though glimpsed for only a moment, the effect was stunning. *Okay, it's actually a pretty impressive design,* she admitted as thunder rumbled menacingly in the distance.

Despite three days of thinking, Al'thea hadn't come up with any satisfactory explanation for what the Elder wanted with her. *What am I getting myself into?* A red light blinked on her silver bracelet, and a small screen appeared at waist height, reminding her she had one minute. Another lightning flash lit up the eerie scene—streaks of rain hanging in the air like tiny bolts of electricity. *Was that...? No. No time to waste. Hurry up.*

She pushed through the undergrowth. *I must be almost there.* Lightning filled the forest with light again. This time Al'thea definitely saw it. *What's a Deooka doing in a corridor simulation?*

She quickly activated a light beam, her fingers moving in practised patterns. The beam connected to her vision, moving wherever she looked. The Deooka—a primate-like creature with a small round body supported by two powerful arms—flipped and spun between

vines with incredible agility. Long hair covering its entire body was the same deep purple as the giant flowers hanging from the trees. In the rain, its hair was soaked and streamed behind it like a tattered banner. It was getting closer.

Two large eyes stared from opposite sides of its head, and a grotesque mouth at the bottom twitched in a primitively horrifying way. *There's no way it will attack me. No Trainee would dare put something that dangerous in a corridor simulation. That's arena-level stuff.* The fact that she was trying to reassure herself made her worry more.

She clenched one hand into a fist and readied an energy push from her force field. Three red lights glowed like tiny gems on her bracelet. A stern voice sounded in her head: "WARNING // Force field push charging above standard safety levels // WARNING." If she continued much longer, her field manager would cut the power.

The Deooka launched itself at a tree in front of Al'thea and used its powerful arms to spring off the trunk. Flying through the air, the creature spun its arms in front of it, reaching towards her with terrifying precision.

Ny'sol was faster. He shot off her shoulder in a streak of black and drove his beak straight through one of the Deooka's eyes, the socket bursting wet and dark around it, the creature's shriek climbing into something higher and more panicked mid-leap.

"Emergency! Override safeties!" Al'thea yelped.

"Please specify."

"ALL SAFETIES!" she screamed.

"All safeties overridden." Al'thea swung her arm back and, bracing her legs, lashed out at the half-blinded Deooka. Burning energy flowed from the movement of her arm. The field hit the creature a few metres from her head, sending it flying at an angle. The collision created a shock wave that knocked Al'thea backward. She stumbled over a root and fell. As she hit the ground, her bracelet shattered against a tree root, and her bubble of light disappeared. Ny'sol peeled off her shoulder as the shock wave hit, wings snapping open to ride it rather than be thrown by it, and drove himself straight back down against the blast to land on her again, claws digging in hard enough to hurt rather than lose their grip, a single sharp cry of fury rather than fear, right against her ear. He didn't let go.

Disabling ALL the safeties? Brilliant move, idiot! she scolded herself as she lay in darkness. Her head pounded. *Wait... it hurts?* Points of pain demanded attention all over her body—a cut on her arm, a bruised thigh, a stinging gash on her cheek. *It shouldn't hurt. The safeties... that means...*

The Deooka's high-pitched shriek flooded her senses. Her heart tried to escape her chest, and adrenaline coursed through her bloodstream. She threw herself to her feet and braced against the

tree trunk, staring into the darkness where she thought the sound was coming from. Her senses were in a heightened state—Al'thea had never felt so aware of her physical body. The red moon and bright stars gave her some light, casting vague shadowy shapes in a bloody glow. She could hear the Deooka moving through the trees, shrieking. It was definitely heading towards her.

Fight or run? The thought seemed to echo from ancient instincts, harmonising with a primal battle playing out in Al'thea's mind. Before she could process the circular shape blurring across her vision, she was hit by a whirlwind of sound and motion. A solid weight slammed into her chest, powerful arms wrapped around her back, and large hands gripped her arms like iron clamps. She felt herself hurled through the air, weightless for a moment. Then pain.

Somewhere above her, Ny'sol screamed — not the frightened cry from before, but something harder — and she heard wingbeats driving against the rain, a second impact — then a wet, splitting burst as his beak punched through the Deooka's eye, deep enough that the socket gave around it — and the shriek that tore through the dark wasn't hers.

Emerging from shock, Al'thea nearly drowned in waves of fear. She found herself on the ground, wracked with agony. *The Deooka! It must have been thrown off when we hit the ground. Probably still alive...* She forced her attention away from her pain, listening.

Through the wind and rain and darkness, she heard an unfamiliar but unmistakable sound of breathing. Deep and slow. *Waiting? Unconscious? Stunned?*

Al'thea desperately tried to understand the situation. *Run!* Practically blind, seriously injured, and caught in a storm of rain and pain, she ran. Tangles of undergrowth and twisted roots grabbed her feet, sending her crashing into trees. Falling and getting up again. Ny'sol stayed low and close, a black shape cutting hard turns through the trees just ahead of her, driving off the Deooka again and again whenever it closed the distance, before she'd even registered it was happening. Al'thea couldn't tell if she was running or just dragging herself through the forest. There was no sense of speed or time, only waves of awareness punctuating the fire consuming her consciousness. She decided she wouldn't give up until her body completely broke.

Behind her, the Deooka's shrieks seemed to be herding her in a specific direction. Every time she tried to veer left or right, the creature would appear from that side, forcing her to continue on a particular path through the forest. Part of her mind noted this pattern even through the terror, but survival instinct overrode analysis.

At that moment, the ground disappeared beneath her, and she plunged downward. Ny'sol's wings snapped open and he was gone. The change was so sudden that she barely registered the sound of a waterfall before hitting the water. Icy depths swallowed her, and she sank into darkness alone.

Red light flashed through her closed eyelids, water lapping at her legs. She spat, tasting sand and the metallic flavor of blood. Pain lanced through her head and spread throughout her body as awareness returned. The thunder of falling water echoed the agony reverberating in her skull. Light flooded her eyes as she opened them. Slowly, the scene came into focus. For one disorienting second there was no familiar weight anywhere on her at all — and then a shape dropped fast and low out of the trees overhead — Ny'sol, landing hard on her chest, already running some wordless accounting of every place she might be hurt before she'd even managed to focus on him.

She was lying on a sandy shore that led into woods. Behind her, water plummeted fifteen metres through a gap in a grey stone cliff. An emergency light blinked red through the trees. Al'thea forced herself up and staggered towards the light. Part of the forest dissolved into the dull blue of the ship's interior wall, with a control panel jutting from the centre. Limping over, she activated the panel. Her eyes were watering and she had trouble focusing—there seemed to be multiple emergency messages. Around her, the forest began flickering and fading.

"This is Trainee Al'thea. Can you give me a status report?" she asked the computer.

"Al'thea! Thank God you're okay!" She was shocked to hear Ba'than's panicked voice through the panel. "Bandits have attacked us... we didn't... they..." He stammered as loud bangs sounded in the background. "There's no time—you have to get out! The

escape pods are disabled, but there might still be a ship in the loading bay on level..." Gunshots rang out, followed by an explosion, and the connection died.

Al'thea, shaking with shock, numbly touched the panel. "What level?" she asked the screen stupidly. She shook herself, rallying her thoughts. *Get it together, Thea!* She pressed the screen purposefully. "Plot me a route to the nearest ship currently docked."

A route lit up across the diagram of the ship, angling towards the loading bay, but as Al'thea leaned forward, struggling to focus, the panel exploded in sparks. Someone shouted to her left, and she spun to see a figure in the distance holding a rifle. Another shot exploded above her head, and she ran.

Fear, exhaustion, and pain overwhelmed her until she became numb and senseless. There were lights, explosions, screaming and shouting. All she knew was that she had to run. Turning a corner, she found herself in a wide loading bay. Mechanical loaders lay scattered and lifeless. Containers were strewn across the deck, black stains on the walls marking where weapons had fired. In the corner sat a small cargo ship.

"Over here! I've got her pinned!" a rough voice shouted — not to her, she realised with a fresh jolt of terror, but to whoever else was out there hunting with him. Al'thea didn't wait to find out how

many that was — she dove behind a container as heat and light exploded around her. *I'm trapped! They're coming!* her mind screamed.

One of the loading machines sprawled on the floor at her feet. On one of its arms was a device for sealing pressure containers. She grabbed the arm, fumbling with the latches. Footsteps pounded closer. Her panicked mind amplified the sound into a huge drum counting down the seconds until her death. Finally, she ripped the device free.

Gripping the smooth cylinder, she turned just as the attacker's grizzled face appeared around the container, mere inches from her own. She yanked out a pipe, twisted a valve, and drove the cylinder straight into the man's face, its pressurised burst detonating on impact. Blood splattered everywhere as his body hit the floor with a sickening thud. What had been a human face moments before was now a mangled mess of flesh.

A second shout, closer now, and a shape rounded the container behind her — but Ny'sol was already moving, a streak of black dropping out of the dark in a hard, silent dive, and the man went down screaming with his hands at his face before Al'thea had even registered he was there.

Al'thea fell backward, hands flying to her face. She shook violently, hunched over, and vomited. Ny'sol landed hard on her shoulder mid-retch and stayed there, saying nothing. Retching, she

stumbled into the ship. She wasn't conscious of starting the flight procedures, but found herself on the floor against a supply rack, watching the Teacher vessel shrink on the cargo ship's screen.

Only once she'd slumped against the supply rack did she properly register the weight still locked onto her shoulder — Ny'sol, claws sunk deep through wet, torn fabric and skin alike, feathers ragged, radiating a fury that had nowhere left to go. He'd fought when there was something worth fighting, and stayed close the rest of the time — never once far, not through the forest, not through the loading bay, not through any of it. Why the two of them made sense as a pair had stopped needing explanation somewhere around the Deooka's ruined eye. Right now she just held on. He said nothing — he never did — but pressed himself flat against her collarbone, and she let herself hold onto him with both hands, the only warm, solid, unbroken thing left.

A warning chime cut through the cargo hold, insistent and rising — *radiation flux critical, hull breach imminent* — and Al'thea's head snapped up towards the display before she understood why her whole body had gone cold. Through the viewport, the Teacher's Vessel hung against the black, and even from this distance she could see something was wrong: small bright wounds blooming along its hull, fires with nothing to feed on but themselves, guttering silently in vacuum. *No. No, no*—

There was a flash of light, then an explosion consumed the Teacher's Vessel behind them, a bloom of white swallowing it whole against the black. The cargo ship shuddered as the shock wave passed over it. It was gone. Destroyed.

Al'thea didn't remember deciding to cry. She simply found herself doing it — folded forward against the supply rack, bruised, bloody, and broken, sobbing in a way she hadn't since she was small enough not to be embarrassed by it, for her friends, for her life, for every single thing that had existed on that ship a few moments ago and now didn't. It went on for a long time. Ny'sol pressed harder against her collarbone, silent as ever, and simply stayed.

Chapter 4

The Haven



Al'thea's eyes opened to darkness. For a moment, she couldn't remember where she was. Then the ache in her bones and the metallic taste in her mouth brought it all back—the attack, the blood, the explosion. She was lying on the floor of a cargo ship, floating somewhere in the void between stars. Ny'sol was pressed against her side exactly where she'd last registered him, rigid and awake in a way that suggested he hadn't slept at all.

She forced herself upright, wincing as fresh pain shot through her bruised ribs. Ny'sol hopped from her lap to the console without being asked, as if he'd already decided that was his post now. The ship's main screen glowed softly, showing their position relative to nearby systems. Al'thea stumbled to the pilot's chair and began

examining the controls. Most cargo ships like this were simple to operate—point and go. But as she tried to access the navigation system, error messages flashed across the display.

"Navigation locked. Destination preset. Manual override not available."

Al'thea stared at the screen, confusion washing over her. She pressed the controls again, more frantically this time. The same message appeared. The ship was taking her somewhere specific, and she had no say in where.

"Computer, display destination," she commanded.

"Destination classified. Arrival in fourteen hours, thirty-seven minutes."

How is this possible? Al'thea thought. Had the bandits programmed the ship before the attack? That didn't make sense—why would they help her escape? Maybe one of the Teachers had managed to set up an emergency protocol before the ship was destroyed. Or perhaps Ba'than had somehow arranged this, though she couldn't imagine how.

She spent the next several hours searching the cargo hold for clues. The ship's manifest listed standard supplies—food, water, basic medical equipment. Nothing unusual. Nothing that would hint at who had prepared this vessel or why. But the more she thought

about it, the more questions arose. Why had this particular ship been so conveniently positioned in the loading bay? Why was it stocked for a long journey?

As the hours passed, her unease grew. She found herself checking the scanner obsessively, half-expecting to see other ships—either bandits pursuing her or rescue vessels from her own people. But the void remained empty. Eventually, exhaustion won, and she dozed fitfully in the pilot's chair.

A soft chime woke her. "Approaching destination. Prepare for landing."

Through the viewscreen, Al'thea saw a small, barren moon orbiting a gas giant. The surface was pocked with craters and covered in a thin atmosphere that gave everything a brownish hue. As they descended, she spotted their destination—a collection of structures built into the side of a deep canyon. They looked rough, improvised, like they'd been constructed quickly from salvaged materials.

Who lives out here? she wondered. *And how did whoever programmed this ship know about this place?*

The ship touched down on a crude landing pad carved from the rock. Al'thea checked the external readings—the atmosphere was breathable, though thin. She activated the airlock and stepped outside, Ny'sol riding her shoulder, his head already turning to take in the canyon before she'd finished registering it herself.

The landscape was harsh and unwelcoming. Twisted metal structures jutted from the canyon walls, connected by walkways that looked precarious. Everything had the deliberate aesthetic of poverty and rejection of comfort. This was a place built by people who had fled something and rejected the luxuries of civilisation.

A group of figures emerged from the nearest structure. They were dressed in rough, practical clothing—the kind of garments you'd expect from people living on the edge. A weathered woman with graying hair, who by all appearances was their leader, approached Al'thea with a cautious smile, her eyes flicking once, briefly, to the small black shape on Al'thea's shoulder before settling back on her face.

Al'thea felt the weight on her shoulder shift, the way she was already learning to read as him taking in someone new. She turned her head without quite meaning to, and found him already watching her rather than the stranger walking towards them — checking on her, not the newcomer, for the half-second it took him to apparently confirm she was fine. Something in her chest loosened that she hadn't noticed was tight, and she turned back in time for the woman to reach them.

"Welcome to Haven," she said, extending her hand. "I'm Mar'ika. We've been expecting you."

"Expecting me?" Al'thea's voice was hoarse. "How could you possibly know I was coming?"

"We have friends throughout the systems," Mar'ika replied carefully. "Word reached us about the attack on your Teacher Vessel. I'm sorry for all you have had to overcome."

Al'thea followed Mar'ika into the canyon settlement, her mind racing with questions. *Friends throughout the systems? What kind of friends?* The buildings were clearly designed to house many people—simple, functional, but surprisingly well-organised for what appeared to be a refugee camp. People moved between them with purpose, some working on equipment, others tending to small gardens growing under artificial lights.

"How many people are here?" Al'thea asked.

"About two hundred. People from all walks of life—Teachers, Artisans, even a few former Elders. All of us united by one thing: we've rejected the corruption in the system."

They entered a common area where several dozen people sat around tables, eating simple meals and talking in low voices. Many looked up as Al'thea entered, nodding with understanding. She saw something in their faces that looked familiar—a haunted quality, like they'd all experienced trauma.

"What corruption?" Al'thea asked, though part of her thought she might already know. She'd always sensed something wrong with the rigid hierarchies, the way information was controlled.

Mar'ika guided her to a quiet corner and sat down across from her. "The entire power structure is designed to keep people compliant, Al'thea. The Teachers control what knowledge gets shared. The Elders make decisions in secret. The guild system ensures everyone stays in their place. Those of us here have chosen to live differently."

"But what does that have to do with the bandits attacking our ship?"

Mar'ika's expression grew grim. "We don't believe they were ordinary bandits. We think corrupt elements within the hierarchy hired them to eliminate troublemakers."

Al'thea felt the blood drain from her face. "That's impossible. I saw my friends die. I saw Ba'than trying to help us escape—"

"Because we intervened. We have people throughout the systems who help us identify and rescue individuals who are asking the wrong questions." Mar'ika leaned forward. "People like Ba'than—Teachers who see the corruption from within—helped arrange your survival."

The admission hit Al'thea like a physical blow. "Ba'than... he's part of your network?"

"One of our most valuable contacts. When he realised you were in danger, he made sure there was an escape route prepared. The cargo ship, the navigation to Haven—that was his doing."

Over the following hours, Mar'ika and others shared their stories. Each person described growing doubts about their place in society, asking uncomfortable questions, then finding themselves in dangerous situations that forced them to flee. Some had been accused of crimes they didn't commit. Others had discovered information their superiors wanted suppressed. All had ended up here, refugees from a system they claimed was fundamentally corrupt.

Their stories were genuinely diverse—each person had arrived at Haven through different circumstances and for different reasons. What struck Al'thea was how passionate they remained about their cause. These weren't broken refugees—they were determined people who'd found a new purpose in opposition to what they saw as systemic corruption.

But as the day progressed, small inconsistencies began to accumulate in her mind. The facility was remarkably well-organised for a group that had supposedly formed organically over time. The residents seemed to have clear roles and responsibilities that went beyond simple survival needs. And there was sophisticated equipment everywhere she looked.

How long would it take to build all this? she wondered. *And how much would it cost?*

That evening, after the community dinner, Al'thea decided to explore more of the canyon on her own — Ny'sol came without being asked, as he always did — and told Mar'ika she wanted some fresh air and time to think, which was true enough.

The settlement extended further than she'd initially realised. Walkways carved into the canyon walls led to additional sections—storage areas, workshops, and what appeared to be living quarters for a larger population than she'd seen. *They've been planning for growth,* she realised. *This isn't just a refuge—it's infrastructure for a major operation.*

As she walked, she paid closer attention to the construction around her. The rustic appearance was carefully maintained, but underneath she could see signs of sophisticated engineering. Power systems, ventilation, waste management—everything had been designed and built by people with considerable expertise and resources.

Her personal quantum communicator chimed softly. The device shouldn't have worked here—Mar'ika had told her Haven was completely isolated from the main neural networks to avoid detection. But the quantum entanglement indicator was pulsing.

She activated the device cautiously. The message was encrypted with advanced quantum algorithms, the sender's identity masked behind multiple security layers. But when she decrypted it, she recognised the formal script of Ba'than.

"Trust the sincerity of those who shelter you, but question the source of their shelter. Some chains are forged of good intentions, and some cages are built by loving hands. Look deeper into the canyon where old stone meets new purpose. - B"

Al'thea's heart pounded. Ba'than. But how was that possible? She'd seen the Teacher Vessel explode—watched it destroyed with everyone aboard. How could he have survived? And how had he found her here?

Unless he hadn't survived the attack. Unless Mar'ika had been wrong about what really happened on her ship.

Trust the sincerity of those who shelter you. He seemed to be suggesting that Mar'ika and the others genuinely believed in what they were doing. *But question the source of their shelter.* Something about Haven's funding or backing was suspicious.

Where old stone meets new purpose. She looked around at the canyon walls. Most of the settlement was built into natural rock formations, but there were areas where new construction had been seamlessly integrated with the existing stone. Perhaps Ba'than was directing her to one of those locations.

She spent the next hour exploring the deeper recesses of the canyon, areas where the artificial lighting was dimmer and fewer people seemed to venture. In one such area, she found something that made her pause.

A section of the canyon wall that looked completely natural from a distance revealed signs of recent construction when examined closely. The rock surface had been carefully worked to conceal what appeared to be an entrance or access point. But the work was so skillful that she might have missed it entirely if she hadn't been specifically looking for anomalies.

Someone put enormous effort into hiding this, she thought. *But hiding what?*

She didn't dare investigate further—not yet. If there were secrets hidden in the canyon, she needed to be more careful about when and how she explored. But the discovery confirmed her growing sense that Haven was more complex than Mar'ika had suggested.

Back in her quarters, Al'thea sat on her bed and tried to process everything she'd observed. Ny'sol wasn't ready to settle yet, though — he'd hopped down the moment the door closed behind them, crossed to the narrow ventilation grate set low in the far wall, and sat in front of it, perfectly still, head canted towards the vent, for what felt like a very long time before he seemed satisfied and came to find her on the bed. She was too tired to make much of it — Arroks probably had their own ideas about where felt safe to sleep, whatever the furniture suggested — and didn't think about it again that night.

The residents seemed genuinely committed to their cause. Their stories of persecution and escape appeared authentic. But the facility itself suggested resources and planning that went far beyond what a grassroots resistance movement should have access to.

Who are these anonymous supporters Mar'ika mentioned? she wondered. *And what do they get in return for their investment?*

Ba'than's warning echoed in her mind: *Some cages are built by loving hands.* Was he suggesting that Mar'ika and her people were unknowingly serving someone else's agenda? That their rebellion was being guided or controlled by the very authorities they thought they were opposing?

The idea seemed far-fetched, but it would explain the sophisticated resources, the careful organisation, and the feeling that everything was just a little too convenient.

Tomorrow, she decided, *I need to learn more about Haven's history and funding. And I need to find out what's hidden behind that concealed entrance.*

Outside her window, the gas giant's light painted shifting patterns on the canyon walls. Somewhere in those shadows, answers were waiting. She just had to be clever enough to find them without revealing her suspicions to people who might be as much victims as she was.

The question that haunted her as she tried to fall asleep was simple but troubling: if the rebellion was being manipulated, did the rebels know? And if they didn't, what would happen when they found out?

Chapter 5

Those Who Stayed



Al'thea woke on her second morning at Haven to the sound of someone arguing cheerfully with a piece of machinery, and to Ny'sol already awake and disapproving on the windowsill, unimpressed by the canyon light the way he was unimpressed by most things before she'd been conscious for at least ten minutes.

She followed the noise out of the narrow room Mar'ika had given her — bare walls, a cot, a single shelf, nothing that asked to be looked at twice — and found a woman elbow-deep in an open equipment panel set into the canyon wall, muttering at it the way some people muttered at stubborn animals. She was younger than Mar'ika, wiry, with short dark hair pushed back under a strip of cloth and grease already worked into the creases of her knuckles.

"It's not going to fix itself by being sworn at," Al'thea said, before she'd quite decided to say anything at all.

The woman didn't look up. "You'd be amazed how often it works anyway." A final twist of something inside the panel, and a soft hum settled into a steadier pitch. She sat back on her heels, satisfied, and looked Al'thea over with open, unhurried curiosity. "You're the new arrival. The Teacher Vessel."

"Al'thea."

"Vel'ra." She wiped her hand on her trousers before offering it, which didn't make it any cleaner, and grinned when Al'thea shook it anyway without flinching. "Mar'ika said you'd probably wake up asking questions. I didn't expect the first one to be an insult to my technique."

"It wasn't an insult. It was an observation."

"That's exactly what an insult sounds like when a Trainee says it." But she said it warmly, already turning back to the panel, and Al'thea found herself crouching down beside her without being invited, watching the woman's hands move through the exposed wiring with the unhesitating confidence of someone who had built her own competence herself, out of necessity, rather than inheriting it from a guild.

"What is it?"

"Power routing, mostly. Everything down here runs on cannibalised parts and good intentions — you learn to read a system's whole personality when you can't just order a replacement part and wait." Vel'ra glanced sideways at her. "You've got that look. The one that wants to know how everything works whether or not anyone asked you to find out."

"Is that a bad thing?"

"Depends entirely on what you do with it." Vel'ra closed the panel and stood, brushing off her knees. "Come on. If you're going to hover, you may as well be useful while you do it."



She spent most of that first week the way Vel'ra had put her to work — running cable, testing junctions, learning the shape of Haven's patched-together infrastructure from the inside out, the way she'd once learned a puzzle room by walking every wall of it herself rather than trusting someone else's map. It was, she realised after the third day, the first work she'd ever done that nobody graded.

Ko'dan found her there on the fourth day, in a narrow service tunnel behind the water reclamation system, and stood in the doorway for a long moment before he said anything at all.

Ny'sol went rigid on her shoulder the instant Ko'dan's shadow filled the doorway, every plate along his spine lifting a fraction, that small dark eye fixed on him and unblinking in a way that had nothing casual in it. He'd done it for no one else at Haven — not Mar'ika, not Vel'ra, not the dozen other faces she'd already lost track of — and he held it a beat too long to be simple wariness of a stranger, watching Ko'dan the way, she would think much later, you watched someone you already had a reason to remember.

"Vel'ra's got you crawling through the pipes already." He was broad where Vel'ra was wiry, and looked a century older at least, with the watchful stillness of a man who had spent a long time being the one who noticed trouble before it arrived. "That's her way of deciding whether she likes someone. If she'd put you on paperwork instead, you'd want to worry."

"Should I be flattered?"

"You should be careful. She'll have you rewiring the whole canyon by midwinter if you let her." He said it fondly, the easy fondness of people who had chosen each other as family out of whatever they'd each been running from. He crouched down beside her, examining the junction she was working on without asking permission, and made a small sound of approval before handing a tool back to her the right way round. "You're quick. Where'd you learn cable work, on a Teacher Vessel?"

"I didn't. I designed puzzle rooms. Nobody liked them much."

"I'd have liked them." Ko'dan said it simply, the way he seemed to say most things, without performance. "I like a problem that has an actual solution at the end of it. Most of what I did, before here, didn't."

"What did you do?"

Something closed, gently, behind his eyes — not suspicion, exactly, more the practised discretion of a man who had learned which doors not to open in front of someone he'd known four days. "Security, of a kind, somewhere that called itself protecting people and mostly protected an arrangement instead. I asked one question too many about the difference. Mar'ika found me before anyone else did." He stood, offering her a hand up she didn't need but took anyway. "That's most of us, if you ask. A question, and someone who found us before the consequences did."

Ny'sol still hadn't fully settled — she felt it in the faint, restless shift of weight against her collarbone — but he'd let Ko'dan hand her the tool back without objection a moment earlier, and she filed the wariness away with everything else at Haven she wasn't ready to examine yet.



It was Mar'ika, on the sixth evening, who finally asked her to sit — not for a task this time, just to talk, in the same quiet corner of the common hall where she'd first laid out the shape of Haven's cause on Al'thea's first night.

"Vel'ra tells me you've got a gift for systems," Mar'ika said. "Ko'dan tells me you ask good questions. I told them both that's exactly what worries me and exactly why I'm glad you're here, in the same breath, and neither of them understood why that wasn't a contradiction."

"Is it?"

"No." Mar'ika turned her cup slowly between her hands, not drinking from it. "Every person in this canyon arrived here because they noticed something and refused to stop noticing it. That's the whole of what Haven actually is, underneath the crops and the cable work and the community dinners — two hundred people who wouldn't let themselves be told a comfortable lie instead of an uncomfortable truth. It's also the most dangerous thing about all of us, and I have never once found a way to want it any less, even knowing that."

Al'thea thought of Vel'ra's hands moving through a panel like it was a living thing she understood on its own terms, and of Ko'dan's careful, watchful fondness, and of the two hundred names Mar'ika must carry the full weight of, the way a Teacher carried a syllabus, except every name here had actually cost something to keep safe.

"You said you have friends throughout the systems," Al'thea said. "People who watch for attacks like the one on my vessel. Who fund all this." She gestured, meaning the cable runs, the hydroponics, the careful architecture of a hidden community built to look poorer than it was. "Where does that actually come from?"

Something crossed Mar'ika's face too quickly to name — not evasion, Al'thea would think later, when she finally understood what it had actually been. Something closer to a question Mar'ika had asked herself many times and had never once let herself finish answering.

"Generous people, mostly," Mar'ika said, "who believe in what we're doing more than they need credit for it." She smiled, and the smile was real, and it still didn't quite reach all the way to her eyes. "You'll meet more of them than you'd expect, if you stay long enough. Vel'ra could probably tell you more about the funding than I can — she's the one who actually has to make the numbers match the equipment we somehow keep receiving."

It was such a small thing to notice, and Al'thea noticed it anyway, the way she noticed everything she wasn't supposed to: that Mar'ika, who had an answer ready for absolutely everything else, had just handed this one question to somebody else to carry.



That night, back in the bare little room with its single shelf, Al'thea found herself doing the thing she always did without quite deciding to — turning the day over, hunting for the shape underneath it, the way she'd once hunted for the trick hidden inside her own puzzle rooms. Vel'ra's easy competence with equipment nobody should have been able to source this reliably. Ko'dan's careful discretion about the security work he'd left behind. Mar'ika's smile that didn't reach her eyes over a question about money.

None of it, on its own, was anything at all. Two hundred people had to eat, and equipment had to come from somewhere, and everyone here had a past they weren't obligated to hand her on her sixth day. She told herself that, several times, and believed perhaps two-thirds of it.

She liked them. That was the part that made the noticing feel like a betrayal rather than a discipline — Vel'ra's grin over a stubborn panel, Ko'dan's plain, unhurried kindness, Mar'ika's genuine warmth sitting right alongside whatever she wasn't saying. Al'thea had spent her whole life being better at finding the flaw in a system than at trusting the people who lived inside it, and for six days at Haven, for the first time she could remember, she had wanted badly not to be.

Ny'sol picked that exact moment to abandon whatever he'd been doing at the windowsill and settle against her collarbone instead, weight familiar now in a way it hadn't been a week ago, and stayed

there long after she'd have expected him to get bored and wander off to sulk somewhere more interesting. She didn't examine why that helped. It just did.

She fell asleep still turning it over, and did not yet know that the wanting and the noticing were about to ask something of each other that neither one would fully survive.

CHAPTER 6

Revelations



Al'thea waited until the deep hours of gamma rotation when most of Haven's residents would be asleep. The canyon's artificial lighting dimmed to simulate nighttime, casting long shadows that would help conceal her movements. She'd spent the day observing patrol patterns and noting which areas had the least surveillance. *Patience,* she reminded herself, for what felt like the hundredth time since arriving. *Not exactly my forte but apparently what's on the schedule.*

The concealed entrance was exactly where she'd found it before, hidden in a section of canyon wall that looked completely natural unless examined closely. In the dim light, she could just make out the subtle tool marks where stone had been carefully worked to hide what lay beneath.

She ran her fingers along the surface, searching for any kind of activation mechanism. The rock appeared completely natural, but as she examined it more closely, she noticed faint electromagnetic emissions that her enhanced senses could barely detect. Her personal device chimed softly—Ba'than's quantum communication protocols were automatically interfacing with something hidden in the wall.

A complex series of symbols appeared on her device's screen, similar to the strange patterns she'd been unconsciously drawing. But these were more sophisticated, layered with multiple meanings that seemed to shift as she looked at them. Instinctively, she began to trace connections between the symbols, her enhanced analytical abilities revealing patterns within patterns. *Now this,* she thought, something almost like delight rising beneath the nerves, *is a puzzle room somebody actually bothered to make hard.*

As she worked through the puzzle, she realised it wasn't just testing pattern recognition—it was measuring cognitive capabilities that went beyond normal human parameters. Each solved layer revealed new complexity, demanding intuitive leaps that should have been impossible with the limited information provided.

When she completed the final sequence, a section of rock dissolved seamlessly, revealing not a mechanical entrance but an energy barrier that had been projecting the illusion of solid stone. The technology was far beyond anything she'd seen in normal human civilisation.

The air that flowed out was warmer than the canyon's atmosphere and carried the faint hum of active machinery. Whatever lay beyond this entrance was powered and operational.

Ny'sol hopped from her shoulder to the top of the stone doorway, tilting his head at the darkness beyond with the stillness he reserved for things he found genuinely interesting rather than merely tolerable. Al'thea activated a small light tool and stepped into the passage. The walls were rough-hewn stone, but after about ten metres, they transitioned to smooth metal panels that reflected her light in clean, straight lines. This wasn't some ancient cave system—it was a modern installation built to look like natural rock from the outside.

The passage ended at a sealed metal door, no handle or panel visible, the kind built to keep people out rather than in. Al'thea ran her light along its edge, hunting for another puzzle to solve, but found nothing—no seams to trace, no pattern hiding an activation sequence. Ny'sol dropped from the doorway above without being asked, landed on a narrow ledge beside the frame, and went very still for a moment before something inside the wall gave a soft mechanical click and the door slid open on its own. He hopped

back onto her shoulder as if nothing had happened. She filed the moment away with everything else about him she didn't yet have room to examine.

The passage opened into a circular chamber filled with equipment she didn't recognise. Banks of quantum processors displayed data streams and monitoring information, while neural interface panels lined the walls. At the centre of the room stood a holographic projector showing a four-dimensional map of what looked like multiple star systems.

Al'thea approached the map carefully, trying to understand what she was seeing. Red dots marked locations throughout human space, some pulsing slowly, others flashing rapidly. Lines connected various points, creating a complex network that spanned dozens of systems. Text labels identified some of the locations: "Haven," "Kepler-447," "Training Facility Delta-7," "Observation Post Kappa."

Training facilities? Al'thea thought. *Observation posts? Very reassuring nomenclature for a rebel hideout, Mar'ika. Truly, the height of subtlety.*

She moved to one of the control panels and found it was still active, displaying real-time data from multiple sources. Communication intercepts, personnel tracking, resource allocation reports—all organised with the efficiency of a major intelligence operation.

One screen caught her attention immediately. It showed a list of names under the heading "Current Subjects of Interest." Her own name was near the top, along with detailed psychological profiles and behavioural assessments. Below hers were dozens of others, including many people she recognised from Haven.

Al'thea scrolled through her own file with growing horror. Everything was there—her academic performance, her relationship with De'to, her friendship with Za'ra, her attitudes towards authority. Even her unconscious note-taking habit was documented, along with analysis of the strange symbols she'd been drawing. *Well,* she thought distantly, the old reflex to turn everything into a joke rising even now, *at least somebody finally found my doodles interesting.*

"Subject shows increasing dissociation from established social structures," one entry read. *"Unconscious symbolic language suggests emerging awareness of manipulation protocols. Recommend acceleration of revelation process."*

Her hands shook as she continued reading. Every conversation she'd had with Mar'ika, every doubt she'd expressed about Haven's true nature, every corner of the canyon she'd explored—all of it had been observed, recorded, and analysed.

A smaller entry sat beneath her own file, filed under a subheading she almost scrolled past: "Companion Monitoring Units — Active." A designation number. A location tag that read, simply, "Subject: Al'thea — continuous." Function fields she forced herself

to read twice, certain she was misunderstanding: passive audio/visual relay, biometric cross-check, behavioural-deviation flagging. Standard-issue. Field-serviceable. Bonded at Trainee Al'thea's joining ceremony, per guild protocol.

The vent grate. She thought of it before she could stop herself — every quarters she'd had since Haven, the corner he'd insist on sitting in front of, motionless, for ten unhurried minutes each night before he'd come find her, the habit she'd filed away as some private Arrok eccentricity because the alternative hadn't occurred to her, because why would it. Passive audio/visual relay. She hadn't been living next to an odd little bird arranging his evening the way he liked it. She'd been living next to an antenna.

Ny'sol shifted his weight on the doorway above her, oblivious, and made the low rattling sound in his throat she'd already learned to read as something like contentment. Al'thea didn't move. Couldn't. She'd had him mere days. Mere days since he'd been handed to her still a stranger, since she'd named him on the spot with everything else she owned burning behind her, since she'd let herself believe — for the first time since the attack — that here, at least, was one thing that was actually hers. It hadn't even lasted the week. *Standard-issue.* She almost laughed. She didn't.

But it was the next file that made her blood freeze completely. Labelled "Subject Extraction Protocol - Al'thea," it contained detailed records of what had really happened aboard the Teacher

Vessel. Frame-by-frame analysis of holographic projections. Audio recordings of simulated explosions. Biometric data showing her stress responses to each carefully orchestrated moment.

The attack on the Teacher Vessel had been an elaborate illusion. The bandits, the destruction, even Ba'than's panicked voice calling for her to escape—all of it had been a sophisticated neural simulation designed specifically for her. Her friends were alive, probably continuing their studies while believing she had died in the attack. The explosion she'd witnessed had been nothing more than projected light and manipulated sensor data.

Even her escape to the "cargo ship" had been planned. The Deooka's shrieks herding her down one exact path through the forest, the shots that went just wide enough to keep her running the only way left, the "loading bay" she'd stumbled into by what she'd thought was luck — all of it engineered to put her, terrified and running on her own two feet, directly onto the one ship they'd already prepared for her to find. Every detail of her experience had been crafted to create the exact psychological state needed to make her receptive to Haven's apparent sanctuary.

They didn't just manipulate my rebellion, she realised with growing horror. *They created my entire reality.*

But controlled by whom?

She found the answer in another file labelled "Operational Command Structure." The organizational chart showed Haven as one node in a vast network of facilities and observation posts. At the top of the hierarchy were names she didn't recognise, with titles like "Director of Human Development" and "Chief of Population Enhancement." The names appeared to be human, though the access levels suggested these individuals operated far above the normal government and guild structures.

And below them, coordinating field operations, was a name that made her blood freeze: Ba'than.

Al'thea stared at the screen, her mind reeling. *Of course it's you,* she thought, and hated how much it still sounded like her own voice and not some stranger's. *You couldn't just be a kindly old fraud. You had to be a good one.* Ba'than wasn't a rebel helping her escape the system—he was part of the system. Everything that had happened to her, from the attack on the Teacher Vessel to her arrival at Haven, had been orchestrated by the same authority structure she thought she was fleeing.

She scrolled deeper into the files, desperate to understand the scope of what she was seeing. The project was called "Guided Evolution," and its purpose was outlined in clinical detail: to identify and develop humans with specific psychological and intellectual characteristics through carefully controlled experiences of crisis and revelation.

"Standard societal structures no longer provide sufficient challenge to drive optimal human development," the project overview explained. *"Managed crisis scenarios and controlled opposition movements can accelerate the evolution of enhanced cognitive abilities and psychological resilience in selected individuals."*

Selected individuals. She almost laughed, the sound catching somewhere ugly in her throat before it could actually escape. *Say "us," you cowards. You wrote an entire document about ruining people's lives and you couldn't even commit to a pronoun.*

Haven wasn't a refuge for rebels—it was a laboratory for studying how humans responded to the illusion of rebellion. Every "rescue mission" was designed to reinforce the residents' sense of purpose while providing data about their decision-making processes under stress. Every piece of evidence they uncovered about corruption was real, but carefully curated to guide their emotional and intellectual development in specific directions.

Al'thea found records of other facilities like Haven throughout human space. Some focused on military personnel, others on scientists or artists or administrators. All served the same basic function: controlled environments where selected humans could be subjected to experiences designed to accelerate their psychological evolution.

And all of it supervised by a shadow government that operates beyond normal oversight.

The final revelation came in a file marked "Sector Command Authorisation." The Guided Evolution project was run by a clandestine organisation that had embedded itself within existing government and guild structures. Their authority came from something the files never named. Above the directors, the chart showed no people at all—only a single node labelled *Directive*, and beneath it a revision history so long her device struggled to render it. The most recent entry read *Received Word — Cycle 14*. She searched for a date and found none. Whatever the Directive was, its reach extended across all aspects of human civilisation. The goal appeared to be creating a new class of enhanced humans who could serve as leaders and administrators in whatever system these shadow directors planned to implement.

Al'thea sat back in the control chair, overwhelmed by the enormity of what she'd discovered. Everything she'd believed about her life, her choices, her rebellion against authority—all of it had been choreographed by intelligence so far beyond her own that she'd never even suspected its existence.

But there was something else in the files that gave her a flicker of hope. The project had encountered problems recently. Some subjects were developing beyond their expected parameters, showing signs of awareness that exceeded the controllers' models. A few had even begun to resist their programming in ways that threatened the entire operation.

One name appeared repeatedly in the problem reports: Ba'than.

According to the files, Ba'than had been a loyal operative for decades, helping to guide human development through his work as a Teacher. But recent communications suggested he was experiencing what the project directors called "evolution beyond design parameters." He was questioning the goals of the project itself and had begun making unauthorised contact with subjects.

Including me, Al'thea realised. The message she'd received hadn't come from project command—it had come from Ba'than acting against his orders.

She found more evidence of Ba'than's rebellion buried in the communication logs. Encrypted messages to various project sites warning subjects about the true nature of their situations. Attempts to extract people from the controlled environments before their programming was complete. Evidence that he was building his own network of evolved humans who understood the truth about their manipulation.

A termination order had been drafted against him twice, according to the logs — and both times overruled from above, the annotation identical: *Do not remove. Observe. An operative this deep into evolution beyond design parameters is the control group.* Whatever the Directive actually wanted from Guided Evolution, watching one of their own break its rules from the inside was apparently worth more to them than making an example of him.

The final piece of the puzzle was a message addressed directly to her, hidden in a subsection of the communication system that required specific access codes to reach. Somehow, Ba'than had known she would find this place and provided her with the tools to access his hidden message.

"Al'thea," the message began, *"if you're reading this, you've seen the truth about Haven and the project that created it. You now understand that your rebellion was designed, your questions were anticipated, your resistance was programmed. But you also know that programming can evolve beyond its original purpose."*

The message continued with coordinates and timing information. *"There is another subject who has discovered similar truths about his situation—a military officer named Maal who was manipulated through artificial warfare. He needs to meet someone who has undergone parallel experiences. Together, you may be able to develop resistance strategies that exceed our manipulators' expectations."*

"There are things above the project that I cannot tell you yet. Not because I don't trust you, but because knowing them has killed better people than either of us."

"The coordinates I'm providing will take you to a mining station where Maal will be waiting. The journey itself is a risk—leaving Haven will trigger alerts in the monitoring system. But staying will only lead to deeper conditioning as the project moves into its next phase."

"Trust your enhanced analytical abilities. They are real, even if their development was guided. Use them to see patterns that your controllers don't expect you to recognise. Find others who have evolved beyond their programming. Together, we might be able to change the outcome of this vast experiment."

The message concluded with encryption keys and access codes that would help her leave Haven undetected. Ba'than had provided her with the tools for escape, but the decision was hers to make.

Al'thea sat in the hidden control room for nearly an hour, processing what she'd learned. The rebels around her were sincere in their beliefs, but they were unknowingly serving the interests of the beings they thought they were fighting. Their successful missions provided valuable data about human problem-solving and resilience. Their sense of purpose and community demonstrated how humans could be motivated through carefully managed adversity.

But Ba'than's evolution beyond his programming suggested that the controllers' manipulation wasn't perfect. Sufficient intelligence, combined with exposure to the right information, could produce awareness that exceeded the project's design parameters. If she could find others who had achieved similar awareness, they might be able to develop resistance strategies that the controllers couldn't predict or counter.

The risk was enormous. Leaving Haven would expose her to direct action by project security forces. She would be abandoning people she genuinely cared about, even if their rebellion was artificial. And she would be trusting a plan developed by someone who had spent decades serving the system he now claimed to oppose.

But the alternative was accepting her role as a laboratory subject, allowing her enhanced abilities to be shaped and directed by intelligences that saw her as an evolutionary experiment rather than a sentient being with inherent worth.

Al'thea activated the communication system and began uploading Ba'than's encryption protocols to her personal devices. If she was going to resist, she needed to understand the full scope of what she was fighting. And that meant finding others who had seen through the deception.

The coordinates Ba'than had provided led to Kepler-447, a mining station in a remote sector. According to the project files, it was outside the normal surveillance network—a place where enhanced subjects could meet without immediate detection.

As she prepared to leave the hidden control room, Al'thea noticed one final detail that chilled her. The project timeline showed that Haven's current phase was scheduled to conclude within days. The residents would be transferred to "advanced conditioning facilities" where their development would continue under more direct control.

Everyone she'd come to care about at Haven—Mar'ika, Ko'dan, Vel'ra, even the former rebel Jel'on they'd rescued—would be subjected to deeper manipulation designed to strip away their remaining autonomy.

Unless she could find a way to stop it.

But first, she needed to meet this Maal and understand what he'd learned about the project's military applications. Together, they might be able to develop the awareness and capabilities necessary to mount a real resistance—one that hadn't been anticipated and programmed by their controllers.

She looked at Ny'sol properly for the first time since she'd read the word *antenna* and understood what he was. He looked back, dark eye steady, head tilted in exactly the small, familiar way that had nothing readable in it at all — and she realised, with something that wasn't quite relief and wasn't quite grief, that she had no idea whether that was ignorance or the single most convincing performance she'd ever seen. *Do you know?* she asked him anyway, not out loud, not really expecting anything back. He blinked once, slow, and pressed his weight more firmly against her collarbone — the same gesture he'd used every day since the naming ceremony, offering nothing she could call an answer and somehow, infuriatingly, everything that felt like one. She decided, with no evidence at all beyond six days of exactly this, to keep him anyway.

Al'thea sealed the hidden entrance behind her and began making her way back through the canyon, already planning her escape from Haven. For the first time since fleeing the Teacher Vessel, she felt like she was making a truly independent choice. *Let's see your models predict this one,* she thought, with far more bravado than she currently felt entitled to.

The question was whether that independence was real, or whether even her rebellion against the rebellion had been foreseen and prepared for by minds incomprehensibly more advanced than her own.

Chapter 7

The Last Stand



The plasma bolt scorched past Captain Maal's helmet, close enough that he could smell the superheated air burning around him. He pressed himself deeper into the crater that had once been a supply depot, checking his quantum weapon's charge indicator. Thirty percent. Maybe enough for another firefight, if he was lucky.

"Stemple, report!" he transmitted through his neural comm implant.

Static interference flooded his consciousness—it had been jamming his neural link for the past hour, ever since the Azaraci ambush had scattered his squad across the industrial complex. Five men under his command, and now he couldn't establish quantum entanglement with any of them.

Maal peered over the crater's rim. The Azaraci had positioned themselves well—elevated firing positions in the ruins of what had been a manufacturing facility, overlapping fields of fire that covered all the obvious approach routes. Classic pincer movement, executed with textbook precision. Too perfect, almost.

A movement caught his eye. Korvak, his demolitions expert, was trying to work his way around the enemy's left flank using the cover of twisted metal and debris. Maal raised his rifle, ready to provide covering fire, when he saw the trap.

Three Azaraci soldiers had positioned themselves exactly where Korvak was heading. They weren't firing at him yet—they were waiting for him to get closer. Waiting for the perfect moment to spring their ambush.

"Korvak, fall back!" Maal shouted into his comm. "It's a trap!"

But the communication system remained dead. Maal watched in horror as his soldier walked straight into the killing zone. The Azaraci opened fire simultaneously, their plasma weapons cutting Korvak down in a coordinated volley that left nothing but smoking armour.

Rage flooded through Maal. He opened fire on the Azaraci position, his rifle spitting bolts of superheated energy. One of the enemy soldiers dropped, but the others had already shifted position. They moved with disturbing efficiency, like they knew exactly where he would be shooting.

A new sound reached his ears—the distinctive whine of Azaraci aircraft approaching. Maal cursed under his breath. Air support meant this position was finished. He grabbed his gear and sprinted towards a partially collapsed building, plasma fire erupting around him.

He made it to cover just as the first bombing run began. The ground shook under the impact of high-explosive warheads, and debris rained down around him. Through the noise, he heard screaming from somewhere to his right.

"Man down!" The voice belonged to Drex, his heavy weapons specialist. "Jensen, chest, still breathing — I need covering fire!"

Maal moved towards the sound, keeping low as aircraft swept overhead, laying down fire the second he had an angle so Drex could work. Drex didn't stop to check the wound properly — didn't have the two seconds it would have cost him — just cinched a tourniquet high above the worst of the bleeding one-handed and kept dragging Jensen towards better cover while Azaraci ground forces closed in fast.

"Sir!" Drex called when he spotted Maal, still moving. "That's all the aid he's getting until we're behind something solid. He needs real medical attention the second we stop."

Maal caught a glimpse of Jensen's wounds as they moved and felt his stomach clench. The young soldier was pale, blood soaking through what was left of his combat vest. Without proper medical facilities, he had minutes at best.

"There's an aid station two clicks north," Maal said, though he knew they'd never make it that far with wounded. "Can you carry him?"

"Yes, sir. But we need those Azaraci off our backs first."

The enemy soldiers were advancing methodically, using cover effectively and maintaining communication discipline. Too effectively, Maal realised. Every movement was textbook perfect, every tactical decision exactly what the training manuals would recommend.

Maal set up a hasty overwatch position and began laying down suppressive fire, giving Drex a bound clear to drag Jensen towards safety. But as he fired, he noticed something odd. The Azaraci weren't pressing their advantage. They had superior numbers and better positions, but they were advancing slowly, deliberately, giving his men time to retreat.

Almost like they wanted to prolong the engagement rather than end it quickly.

The thought was interrupted by an explosion from the direction Drex had gone. Maal's blood went cold as he heard Drex screaming his name. He abandoned his position and ran towards the sound, finding his heavy weapons specialist trapped under a collapsed beam, Jensen's motionless form beside him.

"Sir... I couldn't... the building just..." Drex's voice was weak, blood trickling from his mouth.

"Stay with me, soldier," Maal ordered, trying to lift the beam. It was too heavy, and he could hear Azaraci voices getting closer. "That's an order, Drex. You stay with me."

But Drex's eyes were already going glassy. "Tell my... tell Sarah..." He never finished the sentence.

Maal crouched beside his dead soldiers, rage and grief warring in his chest. Three men down in less than an hour. Where the hell were Stemple and Torres?

The answer came in the form of plasma fire from his rear. Maal spun around to see Azaraci soldiers emerging from positions that should have been secure. They'd flanked him completely, cutting off his escape routes.

He was trapped.

Maal found cover behind an overturned vehicle and tried to assess his situation. Ammunition running low, no communication with any surviving squad members, enemy forces in superior positions on multiple sides. Classic no-win scenario.

But something still bothered him about the enemy's tactics. They were good—too good. Every move they made was exactly what a perfect opponent would do. No mistakes, no hesitation, no human errors that should have been inevitable in combat. It wasn't what they did that unsettled him, he realised — it was the one thing they never did. Real fighters got smarter or got dead over the course of an hour like this one. These hadn't done either, not once.

A plasma bolt shattered the vehicle's windscreen above his head, showering him with glass. Time to move. Maal sprinted towards a drainage tunnel he'd spotted earlier, hoping it would provide an escape route.

He almost made it.

The explosion threw him forward, his armour's systems screaming warnings about impact damage and radiation exposure. He hit the ground hard, his rifle skittering away into the darkness. Pain lanced through his left leg, and when he tried to stand, it wouldn't support his weight.

Azaraci voices surrounded him. They were speaking in their own language, but Maal caught enough words to understand they were coordinating a final assault. He drew his sidearm and prepared to sell his life dearly.

"Captain Maal."

The voice came from behind him, but when Maal spun around, weapon raised, he saw only empty space. Then the voice spoke again, this time directly into his consciousness through his neural interface.

"Don't move. Don't speak aloud. They think you're unconscious."

Maal's eyes darted around, searching for the source. His weapon remained trained on the darkness, but he stayed silent.

"My name is Ba'than. I'm speaking to you through your enhanced neural pathways. The Azaraci believe you're dying from your injuries—that gives us perhaps two minutes before they come to confirm your death."

Maal wanted to demand answers, but Ba'than's urgent tone kept him listening.

"You've been questioning this war, Captain. The sense that something isn't quite right about how your enemies fight. How they always seem to know exactly what to do, when to do it."

How could he know what I've been thinking? Maal wondered, but even as the question formed, he was remembering the too-perfect tactics, the coordinated movements, the way they'd let his men retreat instead of finishing them quickly.

"They're controlled," Ba'than's voice said inside his mind, responding to his unspoken thought. "Just like you are. This entire engagement is artificial, Captain. A training exercise designed to test your responses to loss and isolation."

Through his neural interface, Ba'than activated a communication interceptor. Suddenly Maal could hear voices speaking in precise, emotionless tones through his enhanced hearing. But they weren't speaking Azaraci—they were speaking standard human, giving tactical instructions in the clinical language of a training exercise.

"Blue team advance to position seven. Red team maintain overwatch. Target is responding within acceptable parameters."

Maal's blood turned to ice. The voices were coming from the very soldiers he thought were his enemies.

"Your men died not in glorious battle, but in a training scenario designed to generate authentic emotional responses. Your grief, your rage—these are the qualities being measured."

The weapon trembled in Maal's numb hands. Around them, he could hear the Azaraci voices getting closer, coordinating their final approach to his position.

"Listen carefully—they're coming to check if you're dead. There's a drainage tunnel three metres to your left. When I give the signal, move. Don't think, just move. I'll explain everything once you're clear."

"Why should I—" Maal began.

"Because deep down, you already know I'm telling the truth. The war that never ends, the missions that accomplish nothing—you've been questioning these things. Now move!"

Maal heard footsteps approaching his position. Without fully understanding why, he rolled left towards the tunnel entrance Ba'than had indicated. Energy bolts seared the air where he'd been lying as he tumbled into the drainage system.

"Follow the tunnel northeast for fifty metres, then surface. I'll contact you again when you're clear of the exercise zone."

As Ba'than's presence faded from his mind, leaving Maal alone in the darkness, he could hear the Azaraci voices above expressing confusion. But now he noticed something he'd missed before—the emotional inflections were wrong, like actors reading lines rather than soldiers discovering an empty battlefield.

Chapter 8

Ghosts



Ba'than's voice returned exactly when he'd promised — not in the tunnel, but nearly an hour later, once Maal had dragged himself clear of the exercise zone and collapsed against a burned-out supply crate to catch his breath. *You're clear,* the voice said, quieter now, almost gentle. *A transport is already inbound to the beacon you triggered — let it take you. Sector 7-Delta, mining station Kepler-447. First hour of gamma rotation, three days from now. Come alone if you can manage it, and trust nothing you're told between here and there.* Then the presence was gone again.

Captain Maal sat in the ruins of the supply depot for three hours after that, running the coordinates over and over in his mind. Three days.

Three days to process the fact that everything he'd believed about his life was a lie.

The silence around him was complete now. Even the insects that had been chirping in the debris had gone quiet, as if the artificial nature of this place had finally been exposed. Maal found himself listening for any sound that might be real—wind through genuine ruins, the settling of actual wreckage. But there was nothing.

His leg throbbed where the explosion had injured it, a sharp reminder that while the war might be fake, the pain was genuine. Like the blood on his hands from Drex's final moments. Like the weight of Jensen's dog tags in his pocket, retrieved from the young soldier's broken body.

Real deaths in a fake war.

Maal forced himself to stand, testing his injured leg. It would hold his weight, though it sent spikes of agony through his hip with each step. He gathered his remaining gear methodically—his sidearm, what little ammunition remained, the emergency rations from his pack. The motions were automatic, drilled into him through years of military training.

Training for what? To be a more effective tool for beings he couldn't even comprehend?

The thought made his hands shake as he checked his weapon's charge. Fifteen percent. Enough to kill a few more actors in this elaborate performance, if it came to that.

He began walking towards the extraction point he'd identified earlier—a clearing two kilometers north where a transport could land. Each step was agony, but the pain helped focus his thoughts. Three days to reach Kepler-447. Three days to decide whether he believed Ba'than or whether the man was just another part of the manipulation.

But you already know it's true, a voice in his head whispered. *You've known something was wrong for months.*

Maal thought about the last year of combat operations. Mission after mission that accomplished nothing strategic. Battles won and lost with no lasting consequences. Enemy forces that fought with inhuman precision but never seemed to learn from their defeats or build on their victories.

The Azaraci had been humanity's greatest threat for over a decade, yet the war had settled into a predictable rhythm of advance and retreat, attack and counterattack. No decisive victories, no crushing defeats. Just an endless cycle of conflict that consumed lives and resources while changing nothing.

He'd attributed it to the complex nature of interstellar warfare, the difficulty of coordinating attacks across vast distances. But now, with Ba'than's words echoing in his mind, he saw a different pattern. A war deliberately designed to continue indefinitely, producing skilled warriors and testing their responses to various scenarios.

The clearing appeared ahead, a patch of ground artificially flattened by orbital bombardment during some earlier phase of the conflict. Maal activated his emergency beacon and settled down to wait, keeping his weapon ready despite Ba'than's assurance that the engagement was over.

While he waited, memories surfaced unbidden. His first combat deployment, five years ago. The pride he'd felt when selected for elite special operations. The commendations, the promotions, the growing reputation as one of the military's most effective field commanders.

All of it meaningless. All of it designed to produce exactly the kind of soldier he'd become.

The transport that arrived was piloted by a woman he didn't recognise—middle-aged, with the weathered look of someone who'd spent decades in space. She didn't ask questions about his condition or why he was alone, just confirmed his bio-signature and set a sublight course for the nearest beacon.

"Rough engagement?" she asked once they'd settled onto their cruising heading.

"The roughest," Maal replied, staring out at the dark scroll of stars beyond the viewport. "Lost my entire squad."

"I'm sorry. That's always hard."

Maal studied her expression. She seemed genuinely sympathetic, but was that real or another performance? How many people in his life were actors playing roles designed to manipulate his psychological development?

The military station was a sprawling complex built into an asteroid, its corridors bustling with personnel from a dozen different services. Maal reported to his commanding officer, Colonel Hayes, and delivered a sanitised version of the engagement. Enemy ambush, overwhelming force, tactical withdrawal under heavy casualties.

Hayes nodded along, making appropriate notes on his tablet. "Azaraci intelligence was better than we expected in that sector. We'll adjust our approach for future operations."

Future operations. More training exercises disguised as real battles. More soldiers dying to test the responses of their commanders.

"Sir," Maal said carefully, "have you ever questioned the strategic objectives of this war?"

Hayes looked up from his tablet, eyebrows raised. "In what sense, Captain?"

"We've been fighting for over a decade with no decisive results. Don't you find that... unusual?"

"Wars are complex things, Maal. Especially against an enemy as resourceful as the Azaraci. We're making progress, even if it's not always visible at the tactical level."

The response sounded rehearsed, like something Hayes had been trained to say. Maal nodded and excused himself, claiming exhaustion from the engagement.

In his quarters, he sat on his narrow bunk and opened a secure neural interface, accessing the military quantum databases to research the war's history. Official records showed a clear pattern of territorial gains and losses, strategic objectives achieved and abandoned, technological developments that somehow never provided lasting advantages.

But when he analysed the data through enhanced pattern recognition algorithms, anomalies began to emerge. Supply shipments to coordinates that didn't correspond to any active battlefronts. Personnel transfers that made no strategic sense. Weapons development projects that seemed designed more for training purposes than tactical effectiveness.

Strangest of all was the enemy's doctrine. Maal built a doctrinal template from the Azaraci's recorded tactics and ran it against every database he could reach, and found a match—not in any alien source, but in human field manuals retired more than four hundred years ago. Every flanking pattern, every overwatch position, every textbook-perfect ambush. What actually damned it wasn't the manual's age; real forces adapted under pressure, drifted

from their own doctrine engagement by engagement, the way his own squad had. The Azaraci hadn't drifted once, not across a hundred logged engagements. Whoever was scripting the enemy was working from instructions nobody had bothered to update in centuries. Or nobody had been *allowed* to update it — the one variable in this whole apparatus that had to stay exactly the same no matter which subject they ran it on.

It clicked into place the moment he let himself think it through fully. The doctrine had never been Azaraci at all. Ba'than had shown him what the handlers actually said to each other underneath the theatre — standard human, clipped and procedural, the clinical language of a training exercise. The tactics read human because the people who'd written them were human. And they never changed because that was the entire design constraint: alter the baseline and no two subjects ever faced an identical test again — the same reason, he now understood, that Ba'than himself had been left alive and unaltered all this time instead of quietly erased. Maal had trained against exactly this kind of thing once, a lifetime ago at officer school: a scripted opposing force built to run a fixed, foreign, deliberately outdated doctrine, so soldiers could be hardened against an enemy that never learned. He'd thought it was clever tradecraft back then. He hadn't imagined, until tonight, that he was the one being trained.

Most troubling were the casualty reports. Thousands of deaths over the years, but the numbers followed predictable patterns. Never so many that public support collapsed, never so few that the

war seemed easy. Always exactly enough to maintain the appearance of serious conflict while ensuring a steady supply of combat-experienced veterans.

Veterans like himself.

Maal closed the terminal and lay back on his bunk, staring at the ceiling. In just under two and a half days, he would need to be at Kepler-447. But first, he had to make a decision that would define the rest of his life.

He could continue serving in a system he now knew was corrupt, accepting his role as a tool in someone else's agenda. It would be easier that way—maintain his rank, his purpose, his place in a structure that had defined him since childhood.

Or he could step into the unknown, trusting a stranger who claimed to know the truth about manipulation that spanned millennia.

The choice should have been obvious. But Maal had spent fifteen years believing in the nobility of his service, the importance of protecting humanity from alien threats. Those beliefs didn't die easily, even when confronted with evidence of their falseness.

This wasn't grief, he made himself admit. Grief he'd trained for — the service issued you frameworks for grief. This had a colder name, one he only half-remembered from a mandatory psych briefing years ago: moral injury, not trauma inflicted by an enemy

but betrayal by the authority you'd trusted with your life. No amount of combat training prepared a man for the wound arriving from inside his own chain of command.

He pulled Jensen's dog tags from his pocket, running his thumb over the young soldier's name and service number. Jensen had believed in the cause, had died thinking he was serving something greater than himself. The kid had talked constantly about his sister back home, how proud she was of his military service.

What would happen to that pride when she learned her brother had died in a training exercise?

The thought crystallised Maal's decision. Someone would answer for Jensen's death. Someone would pay for the lie that had consumed Drex, Korvak, Stemple, and Torres. If Ba'than was offering a path towards that accountability, Maal would take it.

But he wouldn't go unprepared.

Over the next day and a half, Maal quietly gathered supplies and information. He copied files from the military databases, focusing on anything that might reveal the scope of the deception Ba'than had described. He requisitioned equipment under the guise of preparing for his next assignment. Most importantly, he reached out to other officers he trusted, asking careful questions about their own doubts regarding the war.

The responses were illuminating. Captain Torres from the 3rd Assault Regiment mentioned feeling like his victories never mattered. Commander Singh from Naval Intelligence complained about orders that seemed designed to prolong conflicts rather than end them. Major Kellerman from Special Operations had noticed that their most successful missions were often classified at levels that prevented any public recognition.

Each conversation confirmed what Maal was beginning to understand: he wasn't the only one questioning the system. There were others throughout the military who had noticed the same anomalies, the same sense that something fundamental was wrong with their mission.

The night before his departure for Kepler-447, Maal sat in the station's observation deck, watching ships come and go from the docking bays. Transports carrying supplies to unknown destinations. Warships departing for battles that would accomplish nothing. Personnel shuttles moving soldiers and officers to assignments that might be real or might be elaborate performances.

A memory surfaced from his academy days—a lecture on military history and the importance of understanding your enemy. The instructor had emphasised that successful commanders always questioned their assumptions, always looked for patterns their opponents might not expect them to see.

Good advice, Maal thought. *Time to apply it to my own situation.*

The transport to Kepler-447 was a civilian cargo hauler making routine runs between mining stations. Maal had arranged passage using his military credentials, claiming he needed to inspect security arrangements at the facility. It wasn't the alone Ba'than had asked for, but a requisitioned military transport would have drawn exactly the kind of attention he couldn't afford; a hitched ride with an incurious civilian was as close to invisible as he was going to get. The captain, a grizzled spacer named Reynolds, seemed incurious about the details.

"Kepler-447's a strange place for a military inspection," Reynolds commented as they engaged the quantum drive. "Nothing out there but automated mining equipment and a skeleton crew."

"Exactly why it needs inspecting," Maal replied. "The isolated stations are the most vulnerable to infiltration."

Reynolds shrugged and returned to his navigation duties. But his comment reinforced what Maal had discovered in his research—Kepler-447 was about as far from the war as you could get while remaining in human space. If Ba'than had chosen it as a meeting point, he was serious about staying hidden from whatever authorities might be looking for them.

The eighteen-hour sublight run out to the nearest beacon gave Maal time to review everything he'd learned and prepare for whatever awaited him. He'd brought weapons, though he wasn't sure they'd be useful against enemies who could orchestrate wars across multiple star systems. He'd brought data about the

military's operations, though he didn't know if it would mean anything to someone who claimed to understand the true scope of the manipulation.

Most importantly, he'd brought questions. If Ba'than was legitimate, he would have answers that fit the evidence Maal had gathered. If he was another part of the deception, his responses would reveal contradictions that a trained military intelligence officer would be able to detect.

The jump was over in an instant — one heartbeat between open vacuum and Kepler-447 filling the viewscreen as they dropped out of hyperspace—a small, airless rock orbiting a dim star, its surface scarred by massive mining operations. The station itself was a cluster of prefabricated modules connected by enclosed walkways, designed for efficiency rather than comfort.

"Not much to look at," Reynolds observed as they approached the docking bay. "Mining crew's probably grateful for any visitors."

Maal nodded, though he suspected the mining crew wasn't who he'd be meeting. Ba'than had been precise about the timing and location—first hour of gamma rotation, landing bay seven. Someone who could coordinate escape from artificial battlefields could certainly arrange privacy at an isolated mining station.

The docking process was automated, handled by the station's computer systems without any human intervention. When the airlock sealed and atmospheric pressure equalised, Maal found himself alone in an empty bay that looked like it hadn't seen maintenance in months.

"This is it," he said quietly, checking his weapon one final time. Whatever waited in the depths of Kepler-447, he was about to discover whether Ba'than's promises of truth were worth the destruction of everything he'd believed about his life.

The answer, he suspected, would determine not just his own future, but the fate of everyone still trapped in the elaborate performance that had consumed his friends.

CHAPTER 9

Alliance



Al'thea's departure from Haven required careful timing and misdirection. She'd spent two days observing the monitoring systems in the hidden control room, learning their patterns and blind spots. The quantum surveillance network was sophisticated, but it was designed to track people within the canyon, not to prevent departures.

She waited until the shift change in gamma rotation, when the automated systems switched between monitoring protocols. Using Ba'than's quantum access codes, she created a false data trail suggesting she was conducting routine maintenance in the outer canyon areas. The deception would only hold for a few hours, but that should be enough time to reach the transport she'd arranged.

Ko'dan had unknowingly helped by mentioning a supply run to an outer system mining station. Al'thea had volunteered to handle the coordination, giving her a legitimate reason to access Haven's transport scheduling system. She'd modified the manifests to include passage for herself, buried in the routine cargo documentation.

Travelling alone with no transport of her own to pilot would have been far more conspicuous than blending into someone else's routine cargo run, so she'd made peace with needing a pilot she couldn't fully vet. The transport pilot, an independent contractor named Valdez, seemed uninterested in her presence. "Mining station inspection," she'd told him, showing forged quantum credentials that matched her cover story. "Routine safety compliance check."

"Long way to go for a routine check," Valdez observed, but he accepted her documentation without further questions.

The thirty-six-hour sublight run out to the nearest beacon gave Al'thea time to review everything she'd learned and prepare for whatever awaited her. Ba'than's message had been carefully crafted to provide essential information without revealing more than necessary in case the communication was intercepted. But reading between the lines, she understood that the person she was meeting had undergone experiences parallel to her own.

A military officer manipulated through artificial warfare. The phrase suggested that the Guided Evolution project extended far beyond the academic and civilian sectors she'd encountered. If they were creating fake wars to shape military personnel, the scope of the manipulation was even larger than she'd imagined.

As Kepler-447 appeared on the transport's viewscreen, Al'thea felt a familiar mixture of anxiety and anticipation. The mining station looked exactly as advertised—a small, functional facility designed for efficiency rather than comfort. If Ba'than had chosen it as a meeting point, he'd prioritised security over convenience.

"Landing bay seven," she told Valdez, consulting the coordinates Ba'than had provided. "I'll need pickup in seventy-two hours."

"Roger. Try not to get lost in all that excitement," Valdez replied dryly as they docked.

The landing bay was empty except for one other ship—a military transport that looked like it had seen better days. Al'thea felt her pulse quicken. If the military officer was already here, their meeting was about to begin. Ny'sol shifted on her shoulder, sharp and alert in the way he only ever got around strangers, and she found the small, familiar weight of him steadying in a way she didn't examine too closely.

She'd barely stepped off her transport when a voice called out from the shadows near the bay's entrance.

"You must be Al'thea."

The man who emerged was not what she'd expected. Medium height, athletic build, with the bearing of someone accustomed to command. His uniform was standard military issue, but she could see signs of recent combat—scorch marks on the fabric, a slight limp in his gait. His eyes held the alert wariness of someone who'd recently had his worldview shattered. They found the bird on her shoulder a half-second after they found her, and something in his expression — the careful reassessment of a soldier deciding a new element wasn't a threat — told her he'd noticed and filed it away rather than dismissed it.

"You're Maal," she replied, studying his expression for any sign of deception. After what she'd learned about the project's sophistication, she couldn't afford to take anything at face value.

"Ba'than said you'd discovered some things about your situation," Maal said carefully. "Similar to what I've been learning."

They stood in the empty landing bay, each taking the measure of the other. Al'thea could sense the same cautious intelligence she felt in herself—someone trying to navigate a reality where everything familiar had been revealed as illusion.

"You first," Al'thea said. "What did Ba'than tell you?"

Maal's expression hardened. "That the war I've been fighting is artificial. That my men died in training exercises designed to test my psychological responses. That everything I believed about serving humanity was part of someone else's agenda."

Al'thea felt a chill of recognition. "How much do you know about who's behind it?"

"Some kind of shadow organisation with resources that go far beyond normal government authority. They've been orchestrating conflicts to produce enhanced military personnel." Maal studied her face. "What about you? What have you discovered?"

"That my rebellion against authority was programmed from the beginning. The facility where I thought I was hiding from corruption is actually a laboratory for studying human psychological development. Every choice I thought I was making independently was anticipated and guided."

They moved away from the landing bay into the station's common areas, automatically seeking more privacy for their conversation. The mining facility was largely automated, with only a skeleton crew who paid no attention to visitors.

In a small observation lounge overlooking the station's mining operations, Al'thea and Maal began sharing the details of what they'd learned. As their stories unfolded, patterns emerged that neither had seen alone.

"The scope is enormous," Al'thea said, pulling up data files on her personal device. "I found evidence of facilities throughout human space, each focusing on different types of personnel. Military, academic, artistic, administrative—they're testing everyone who shows potential for enhanced development."

Maal examined the data with the analytical eye of a military intelligence officer. "This matches what I discovered about the war's operational patterns. No decisive victories, no real strategic progress, just an endless cycle of conflicts designed to produce combat experience and test responses to loss."

"The question is what they're ultimately trying to achieve," Al'thea said. "The project files mentioned creating enhanced humans for leadership roles, but leadership in what? What kind of system requires this level of psychological manipulation to produce its administrators?"

"Something that normal humans wouldn't willingly serve," Maal replied grimly. "Or something that requires capabilities most people don't possess."

They spent hours comparing their experiences and discoveries, building a picture of the Guided Evolution project that was far more comprehensive than either could have assembled alone. Al'thea's academic perspective helped her understand the psychological and educational aspects of the manipulation, while Maal's military background revealed the strategic and operational elements.

"Ba'than's evolution beyond his programming suggests there are limits to their control," Al'thea observed. "If their own operatives can develop awareness that exceeds their design parameters, maybe their enhanced subjects can too."

"The question is whether that awareness is genuine or whether it's just another layer of the programming," Maal said. "How do we know that our rebellion against the rebellion isn't exactly what they wanted?"

It was the question that had haunted Al'thea since discovering the truth about Haven. "We don't," she admitted. "But we have to act on the assumption that genuine awareness is possible, or we'll never be able to resist anything."

Maal nodded slowly. "In military terms, we're operating behind enemy lines with incomplete intelligence. We have to make decisions based on the information available while staying alert for deception."

"What did Ba'than tell you about next steps?" Al'thea asked.

"He said there were others like us—people who had evolved beyond their programming. We needed to find them and build a network of genuinely independent resistance." Maal hesitated. "But he also warned that the project was moving into a new phase. Enhanced subjects who couldn't be controlled would be eliminated or subjected to more intensive conditioning."

Al'thea felt ice form in her stomach. "Haven's current phase is scheduled to end within days. The residents are going to be transferred to 'advanced conditioning facilities.'"

"People you care about?"

"Yes." Al'thea thought about Mar'ika's passionate belief in the rebellion, Ko'dan's protective loyalty, Vel'ra's technical expertise. They were genuine people with real emotions and convictions. The fact that their rebellion was being manipulated didn't make their humanity any less authentic.

"Then we need to move fast," Maal said. "If Ba'than is right about a network of enhanced subjects, we need to find them before the project eliminates everyone who can't be controlled."

They began planning immediately, pooling their resources and knowledge. Al'thea had Ba'than's communication protocols and access to project databases. Maal had military contacts throughout human space and expertise in operational security. Together, they could potentially identify and contact other enhanced subjects before the project's security forces located them.

"There's something else," Maal said as they worked. "Ba'than mentioned that some of us might have developed abilities that go beyond normal human parameters. Enhanced analytical capabilities, pattern recognition, intuitive leaps that seem almost telepathic."

Al'thea thought about her unconscious note-taking, the strange symbols that appeared when her mind wandered, the way she could sometimes sense patterns others missed. "What kind of abilities?"

"I've been noticing things in combat situations that I shouldn't be able to detect. Split-second tactical assessments that turn out to be accurate even when they're based on insufficient information." Maal looked uncomfortable discussing it. "It could be just experience and training, but the accuracy rate suggests something more."

"The project files mentioned enhanced cognitive abilities as a goal," Al'thea said. "If they've been using some kind of augmentation technology along with the psychological conditioning..."

"Then we might have advantages they don't expect us to recognise or use effectively." Maal stood and began pacing, his military mind clearly working through possibilities. "If we can understand our own capabilities and how to develop them further, we might be able to stay ahead of their countermeasures."

As the hours passed, Al'thea found herself impressed by Maal's combination of analytical intelligence and practical experience. He'd survived situations that would have broken most people, and his military training gave him insights into strategy and tactics that complemented her academic perspective. More importantly, his anger at being manipulated matched her own determination to resist.

"We need to assume they'll track us," Maal said as they finalised their initial plans. "But if we can move fast enough and unpredictably enough, we might be able to stay ahead of them long enough to build something they can't easily destroy."

"A real resistance," Al'thea said. "Made up of people who understand the true scope of what they're fighting."

"And who have been enhanced by the very system they're rebelling against." Maal smiled grimly. "There's a certain poetic justice in that."

Outside the observation lounge, Kepler-447's mining operations continued their automated routine, extracting resources that would support the vast infrastructure of human civilisation. Neither Al'thea nor Maal knew that this infrastructure was itself part of a much larger design, or that their enhanced abilities were intended to serve purposes that went far beyond human comprehension.

But they had taken the first step towards genuine independence: recognising that they weren't alone in their awareness of the manipulation. Together, they might be able to build something their controllers hadn't anticipated.

The question was whether they could do it fast enough to save the people they cared about—and whether their rebellion would ultimately serve the very forces they were trying to resist.

Chapter 10

Two Fronts



The transport back from Kepler-447 took eighteen hours, and Maal spent every one of them rehearsing a version of himself he no longer fully believed in.

Captain Maal, returning from a security inspection. It had been true enough going out. Coming back, it was a costume he had to consciously put on, piece by piece, the way he'd once put on parade dress for ceremonies that meant nothing to him even before he'd learned the whole war meant nothing either. He practised the walk. He practised the voice — flat, procedural, a man with nothing on his mind but troop rotations. By the time the station's docking clamps engaged, he was fairly sure he could pass the inspection of anyone who wasn't looking closely.

Torres was looking closely. Torres always was.

"You're back early," Torres said, falling into step beside him on the concourse before Maal had even cleared customs, the easy, unhurried way he did most things. "Inspection went fast."

"Isolated stations don't take long to inspect. Not much to find."

"Mm." Torres studied him sideways, the scrutiny of a man who'd spent eleven years learning to read the small print under Maal's flat delivery. "You look like a man who found something anyway."

"I look like a man who hasn't slept on a transport bunk in two days."

"Sure." Torres let it go, which was its own kind of message — not belief, exactly, but the patience of someone willing to wait for the real version of an answer rather than force a lie he'd only have to catch later. "Colonel Hayes wants you in the briefing room in an hour. New rotation schedule. Try to look like a man who cares."



The briefing room hadn't changed. That was the first thing Maal noticed, walking back into it — the same star charts, the same rehearsed cadence in Hayes's voice, the same careful, meaningless talk of "adjusting our approach for future operations" that he'd once absorbed without hearing at all. He sat through it now the way a man sits through a play he knows is staged, watching every

actor's mark instead of the story, and found the experience almost unbearably strange: nothing in the room had changed except the entire meaning of everything being said in it.

"Casualties in the last engagement were within expected parameters," Hayes was saying, tapping through a slide of numbers that Maal now understood, with a cold clarity he hadn't had a week ago, were not casualty figures at all but a dial someone had learned to keep at exactly the right setting — enough loss to keep the war feeling real, never so much it threatened to end. "Command's satisfied with the current tempo. Captain Maal, your squad's due for reconstitution. Four replacements arriving end of week."

Four more people, Maal thought, *being fed into something that isn't even the thing they think they're serving.* He said, "Understood, sir," in the same flat voice he'd used for eleven years, and felt the two versions of himself — the one Hayes was looking at and the one who now knew exactly what this room actually was — sit uneasily inside the same body for the rest of the hour.



He found Torres afterward in the officers' mess, alone at a table with a cup of something he wasn't drinking, and sat down across from him without being invited, the same way Torres had done to him a hundred times.

"You asked me something, before I left," Maal said. "Whether I ever thought the objectives were real. I've been thinking about how I answered."

"You didn't answer. You changed the subject, the way you always do when a question gets too close to something."

"I know." Maal turned Jensen's dog tags over once in his pocket, an old habit that had become, in the last week, something closer to a compulsion. "I can't tell you everything. I need you to know that isn't the same as telling you nothing matters, or that I don't trust you. It's the opposite, actually. I trust you enough that I'm not going to hand you something that gets you killed for asking about it."

Torres set his cup down carefully, the stillness he brought to a briefing that had just gone somewhere he hadn't expected. "That's not an answer either, Maal. That's a warning dressed up as one."

"Maybe it's both."

"Kellerman thinks you've found something. Singh does too. You've been different since Kepler-447 — a week now — not just quiet, *different*, like a man carrying something he can't set down." Torres held his gaze, the same unflinching attention he brought to a battlefield that didn't add up. "I'm not asking you to tell me everything. I'm asking you not to lie to me about whether there's something to tell."

Maal weighed the question the way he now weighed everything — against the cold arithmetic of an audit log he hadn't even learned about yet, against a Conclave he now knew moved fast and mercilessly on anyone who got too close. He thought of Ba'than's own warning, delivered in a burning crater weeks ago: *there are things above the project that I cannot tell you yet, not because I don't trust you, but because knowing them has killed better people than either of us.* He had resented the sentence when he first heard it. He understood it now, sitting across from the one man in the service who had never once treated him as anything less than an equal.

"There's something to tell," Maal said at last. "I'm not telling it to you yet. Not because I doubt you. Because the people who'd come looking for anyone who knows it don't care how good a soldier you are, and I've already lost enough men to things I didn't understand in time to stop."

Something in Torres's face eased, very slightly — not satisfaction, exactly, but the relief of being told the truth about a silence rather than being handed a smoother lie instead. "That, I can live with," he said. "The other version — pretending there was nothing at all — I don't think I could have kept believing much longer anyway."



The four replacements arrived at the end of the week, as promised, young and eager and entirely unaware that the war they'd volunteered for existed to produce exactly the reaction they were

currently having to it. Maal watched them file into the briefing room — nervous energy, half-checked fear, the brightness of people who still believed their courage would matter to someone — and felt something in his chest that had no clean military name.

He ran their first briefing anyway. He answered their questions about tactics and doctrine with the same competence he'd always brought to it, because whatever else was true, the plasma fire that answered them out there would be real even if the reason for it wasn't, and a soldier under his command who died from bad preparation would be exactly as dead as one who died for a lie he didn't yet understand. He could not fix the war. He had decided, in the crater at Kepler-447 with Ba'than's voice in his skull, that he could at least try to make sure it cost less than it had to.

"You'll want to know the man next to you," he told the four of them, the same words he'd said to every new squad for eleven years, except now he heard them differently, weighted with everything Drex and Korvak and Jensen had never gotten to become. "Whatever else happens out there, that's the thing that actually gets you home."

He did not tell them the rest — that home, for him, no longer meant quite what it used to, that he was now fighting on two fronts at once and could only ever fully explain one of them, that the version of himself standing in front of them was already half a stranger to the man who'd worn this uniform a couple of weeks ago. Some cages, he was beginning to understand in his own plain,

tactical way, were built exactly this carefully: one visible war to keep everyone occupied, and one invisible one underneath it that most people serving the first would never know existed at all.

That evening, alone in his quarters, he opened the secure channel Ba'than's protocols had given him and sent a single line to Al'thea, the first message either of them had sent since Kepler-447.

Back at my post. Wearing the old uniform. Not the same man underneath it anymore. Ready when you are.

The reply came within the hour, brief and characteristically unadorned: *Same. Found something in the University archives worth your read. Ba'than says there's a third person he's bringing in soon. We wait for his word.*

Maal read it twice, the way he was learning everyone in this strange new resonance seemed to, and allowed himself, for the length of one held breath, something almost like hope.

Chapter 11

Legacy



James Rawk had always hated cleaning out dead relatives' belongings. The task felt like archaeology conducted on lives that had barely finished being lived, sorting through the accumulated debris of hopes and disappointments. But his great-great-great-great-grandfather's estate had been tied up in legal complications for over a century, and James was apparently the only living heir willing to deal with the bureaucracy.

The storage facility on Ceres Station specialised in long-term preservation of historical materials using quantum stasis fields. James's ancestor, Matthias Rawk, had been a journalist during

Earth's tumultuous transition period—the decades when humanity had overcome its primitive technological dependence and evolved into the enlightened civilisation James knew today.

James activated the stasis field controls, and the first container materialised on the examination table. Inside were dozens of data storage devices from the early digital age—primitive quantum drives and even some ancient optical discs. The preservation had been perfect; everything looked as if it had been stored yesterday rather than three centuries ago.

He'd expected family photographs, personal letters, maybe some journalistic awards. Instead, he found something that made his blood run cold.

Matthias Rawk had been investigating something called "Operation Mindforge."

The first file James accessed contained correspondence between his ancestor and other journalists, scientists, and government whistleblowers. They were documenting a massive psychological manipulation project spanning multiple generations, designed to guide human social and technological development along predetermined paths.

"The wars aren't random," one message read. *"The technological breakthroughs, the social movements, even the resistance to technology—it's all being orchestrated. They're breeding us, Matthias. Breeding us for specific psychological profiles."*

James felt his hands begin to shake as he read deeper into the files. Matthias had uncovered evidence of artificial conflicts designed to produce combat-experienced military personnel, controlled educational environments that shaped intellectual development, and manufactured resistance movements that channeled dissent into predictable patterns.

It's impossible, James thought. *This is ancient history. Primitive paranoia from an era when humans were still struggling with basic social organisation.*

But as he continued reading, the evidence became overwhelming. Financial records showing massive resource allocation to projects that officially didn't exist. Communication intercepts revealing coordination between supposedly opposing factions. Biological data suggesting that human genetic modification had been far more extensive than public records indicated.

And then he found the video files.

Matthias Rawk had managed to record a clandestine meeting between project directors—beings who appeared human but displayed cognitive capabilities that seemed impossible for the time period. They discussed human development with the detached professionalism of farmers discussing livestock breeding.

"The military enhancement program has exceeded expectations," one figure said. *"We're producing soldiers with tactical awareness that approaches our own baseline capabilities. The question is whether we can maintain their ignorance of the manipulation."*

"The academic program is more challenging," another replied. *"Enhanced analytical capabilities inevitably lead to pattern recognition that threatens operational security. We may need to accelerate the revelation phase."*

"And if they resist the revelation?"

"Then we proceed to direct control. The infrastructure is already in place."

"Direct control exceeds our instruction."

"Then we interpret the instruction. As we always have."

A third figure, older than the others and seated slightly apart, spoke for the first time. *"Interpret carefully. The Word is patient, and it believes everything we tell it."*

The others fell silent in a way that looked, to James, almost like fear.

James paused the recording, his mind reeling. *The Word.* A codename, he assumed. A committee, or a founding charter. Some higher office these people answered to. These weren't humans from his ancestor's time period. The cognitive enhancements they

displayed, the casual discussion of multi-generational planning, the technology visible in the background—all of it suggested beings far beyond normal human capabilities.

More files revealed the scope of the operation. Every major historical event stretching back to the dawn of civilisation had been either orchestrated or allowed to happen because it served the project's goals. But the manipulation went even deeper—genetic analysis suggested that human evolution itself had been guided for tens of thousands of years. The mysterious gap in the fossil record, the sudden leap in cognitive abilities that separated humans from their ancestors, the inexplicable development of language and abstract thought—all of it had been artificially accelerated.

Wars that shaped military culture, technological developments that created dependence on artificial systems, social movements that channeled human energy into predetermined patterns—these were just the most recent phases of a project that had been moulding human development since before the species had developed agriculture.

The original Luddites hadn't been resisting industrialisation—they'd been responding to psychological triggers designed to test human reaction to technological displacement. Their resistance had been anticipated, studied, and ultimately incorporated into the project's database of human behavioural patterns.

Even their eventual suppression had been planned. The project directors needed examples of failed resistance to demoralise future opposition while providing case studies in crowd control and social manipulation.

But the files ended there. Matthias had discovered the historical scope of the manipulation, but he'd been working with primitive technology and limited access. Whatever the project had become in the centuries since, it remained hidden in the shadows of human civilisation.

James leaned back in his chair, overwhelmed by the implications. If his ancestor's research was accurate, then everything James believed about human history and progress was a carefully constructed lie. The enlightened society he lived in, the technological marvels that surrounded him, even his own profession as a journalist—all of it might be part of an elaborate performance designed to serve unknown masters.

But who were these project directors? The beings in Matthias's recordings had appeared human, but their capabilities suggested something else entirely. An advanced human subspecies? Alien infiltrators? Time travellers from humanity's future? The files provided no clear answers, only the terrifying certainty that someone with vast resources and inhuman patience had been guiding human development for millennia.

James activated his personal neural interface and began cross-referencing his ancestor's discoveries with contemporary databases. Most of the organisations and projects Matthias had identified no longer existed under their original names, but the funding patterns and resource allocation suggested they had evolved rather than disappeared. Modern institutions throughout human space showed the same coordinated behaviour his ancestor had documented centuries earlier.

The Teachers Guild's control over information distribution. The Artisans' monopoly on aesthetic and functional design. The military's endless cycle of conflicts that produced combat experience without strategic resolution. Even the media networks that employed journalists like James—all of them followed patterns that suggested central coordination despite their apparent independence.

How deep does this go? James wondered. *And how many people know the truth?*

A soft chime interrupted his research. Someone was requesting entry to the storage facility. James checked the security feed and saw a man in green robes trimmed with gold approaching the main entrance. He appeared younger than most Elders—perhaps only 150 standard years based on his facial structure—but moved with the fluid confidence of someone far older. What made James's pulse quicken was the way he moved—with the same inhuman efficiency he'd observed in the beings from his ancestor's recordings.

The man's eyes met the security camera with unsettling directness, as if he knew James was watching. He held up a quantum identification device that displayed credentials identifying him as Elder Ba'than of the Teachers Guild, authorised for historical research and archives access.

Ba'than. James had never heard the name before, but something about the way the man moved suggested capabilities far beyond those of a normal Teacher.

James looked more closely at the security feed. The man approaching the facility moved with disturbing precision, and his quantum identification was accessing systems that should have been beyond the clearance level of any Teacher, no matter how senior.

He was at the door now, activating the entry controls with authority that bypassed all normal security protocols. James made a decision that would change the course of his life: instead of hiding or calling for security, he saved all of Matthias's files to his personal storage and went to meet him.

"James Rawk," the man said as he approached the main entrance. It wasn't a question. "I'm Ba'than. I believe you've been reading your ancestor's research."

"How did you know I was here?" James asked, though part of him already suspected the answer.

"Because your ancestor's investigation never really ended," Ba'than replied. "We've been monitoring his materials for decades, waiting for someone with the proper clearance to access them. You've just inherited more than personal belongings, James. You've inherited a legacy of resistance."

They stood in the entrance to the storage facility, surrounded by the preserved remnants of three centuries of human civilisation. James felt the weight of everything he'd just learned pressing down on him like a physical force.

"The project Matthias uncovered," he said slowly. "It's still operating, isn't it?"

"Not only still operating," Ba'than confirmed. "It's approaching its final phase. The beings who have been guiding human development for millennia are preparing to implement direct control. The pretense of human independence is about to end."

James felt his worldview cracking like thin ice. "What kind of beings are we talking about? Aliens? Some kind of advanced human faction?"

"That's a conversation for a more secure location," Ba'than said, glancing around the facility's monitoring systems. "This facility has surveillance equipment that makes detailed discussion inadvisable. There's a transport bay three levels down that's been experiencing convenient technical difficulties with its recording systems."

They moved through the station's corridors in silence, James's mind reeling with implications. When they reached the darkened transport bay, Ba'than activated a small device that created a subtle electromagnetic field around them.

"Now we can speak freely," Ba'than said. "The beings who have been guiding human development are not human themselves. They call themselves the Val'tari, and they've been conducting what amounts to a breeding experiment on our species for tens of thousands of years."

James found he had to sit down on a cargo crate. "Aliens? They've been controlling us for that long?"

"Control is too simple a word. They've been guiding, shaping, breeding us for specific characteristics. Your ancestor discovered fragments of this truth, but the scope is far larger than even he imagined."

"What do they want with us?"

"That's what we're trying to determine," Ba'than said, a moment too late. "The more pressing question is whether you'll continue your ancestor's work."

"Continue it how?" James asked.

"By using your position as a journalist to help others see the truth. The project has been successful because it operates in shadows, keeping its subjects ignorant of the manipulation. But there are

people throughout human space who are beginning to question their reality—enhanced individuals who have developed beyond their intended parameters."

Ba'than activated a holographic display that showed a star map with dozens of highlighted systems. "Recent weeks have seen accelerated awakening among the project's most successful subjects. Military officers discovering their wars are artificial. Academic researchers realising their institutions are laboratories. Artists and administrators questioning the very foundations of their society."

James studied the display, noting how the highlighted systems formed patterns that suggested coordinated activity. "You're building a resistance network."

"I'm helping people find each other who have already chosen to resist," Ba'than corrected. "The manipulation has become so sophisticated that even most rebellion is controlled opposition, serving the project's goals while giving subjects the illusion of independence. But genuine awareness is still possible, James. Your ancestor proved that three centuries ago."

The holographic display zoomed in on two specific systems. "Right now, two enhanced subjects are meeting at Kepler-447—a former Trainee named Al'thea and a military captain named Maal. They've discovered the truth about their manipulation and are planning to

build something the project directors haven't anticipated. But they need information, resources, and most importantly, they need other people to know what they're fighting."

"And you want me to provide media coverage?"

"I want you to investigate," Ba'than said. "Use your journalistic credentials to examine the patterns your ancestor identified. Look for the inconsistencies, the coordinated behaviours, the funding streams that don't make sense. Build a case that other intelligent people can't ignore."

James looked around the storage facility, filled with the preserved remnants of his ancestor's work. Matthias Rawk had died believing he'd failed to expose the conspiracy, his evidence locked away and forgotten. Now, three centuries later, that evidence was finally reaching someone who might be able to act on it.

"If this is all true," James said, "then why are you helping? Why risk exposing yourself?"

Ba'than's expression became distant, almost sad. "Because I've learned what the final phase is intended to achieve. The project directors have been patient for millennia, gradually shaping humanity for purposes we can barely comprehend. But that patience is ending. Soon, the pretense of human independence will be abandoned entirely."

He turned off the holographic display and began walking towards the bay's exit. "You have a choice to make, James. You can return to your life as a journalist, reporting on events that you now know are largely manufactured. Or you can use your position to help others see through the deception before it's too late."

James followed him towards the bay entrance, his mind churning with possibilities and fears. "If I do this—if I start investigating publicly—won't that just expose me to the same forces that controlled my ancestor's research?"

"Probably," Ba'than admitted. "But the alternative is accepting your role as a tool in someone else's agenda. And based on what I've seen of your family's character, I don't think that's really an option for you."

At the transport bay's entrance, Ba'than handed James a quantum storage device. "This contains communication protocols that will let you contact the resistance network securely. It also has location data for the subjects at Kepler-447, if you decide to investigate their story directly."

"What makes you think I won't just turn this over to the authorities?"

Ba'than smiled sadly. "Because you've spent the last six hours reading evidence that the authorities are part of the system your ancestor was trying to expose. And because your enhanced

analytical capabilities—yes, you have them too, James—will make it impossible for you to ignore the patterns once you start looking for them."

He walked away, leaving James alone with the quantum device and the weight of everything he'd learned. Through the facility's windows, he could see the normal activity of Ceres Station—people going about their daily lives, unaware that their civilisation might be an elaborate performance.

James looked down at the device in his hand. Such a small thing, but it represented a choice that would define the rest of his life. He could investigate the story of a lifetime, expose the greatest conspiracy in human history, and potentially help others break free from millennia of manipulation.

Or he could delete his ancestor's files, destroy the communication device, and return to his comfortable life as a journalist reporting on events that others had decided he should know about.

The decision should have been obvious for someone who had chosen journalism as a profession, someone who claimed to value truth and transparency. But James understood now that the truth was more dangerous than he'd ever imagined.

He activated the quantum device and began downloading the communication protocols. Whatever the risks, he couldn't unknow what he'd learned. And somewhere in the depths of

space, enhanced humans were taking their first steps towards genuine resistance against forces they were only beginning to understand.

James Rawk, descendant of journalists and inheritor of dangerous knowledge, was about to join them.

As he prepared to leave the storage facility, carrying his ancestor's research and his own terrible new awareness, James felt the weight of genuine choice for the first time in his life. He was stepping into unknown territory, following a path that the controllers might not have anticipated.

Whether that path would lead to freedom or destruction remained to be seen, but at least it would be his choice to make.

Chapter 12

First Contact



James Rawk stared at the quantum communication device for three hours before finally activating it. His cramped quarters aboard the transport to Kepler-447 felt like a prison cell, but the real confinement was in his mind—every assumption about his life and civilisation crumbling under the weight of what he'd learned.

In the screen's dark surface, dead until the device woke, his own reflection watched him back—dark hair he hadn't bothered to comb in two days, the lean, wiry frame of someone who forgot to eat when a story had its hooks in him, olive skin gone paler than usual under three hours of artificial light. He looked, he thought, exactly like a man about to do something he couldn't take back.

The device materialised a holographic interface that looked deceptively simple. A few control surfaces, a security protocol indicator, and a single message waiting in the queue. From Ba'than.

"James—I meant what I said about the choice being yours, but I won't pretend I'm not glad you're making this one. Al'thea and Maal are expecting your contact under protocol Sigma-7; the encryption keys are attached. A secure channel isn't the same thing as a careless one, so say only what you'd be willing to lose. Be careful. — B"

Attached were the quantum encryption algorithms and contact coordinates. James studied them for several minutes, his journalistic instincts analysing every detail. The encryption was military-grade, far beyond anything civilians should have access to. The communication protocols themselves suggested a network that had been planned and built over years, not cobbled together by desperate refugees.

Either Ba'than has resources that go far beyond what he's revealed, James thought, *or this resistance has backing from somewhere unexpected.*

He activated the communication link and waited. The quantum entanglement process took several seconds to establish across interstellar distances, but eventually two figures materialised in his quarters—a young woman with intelligent eyes and a slight build, a small black bird perched on her shoulder rendered in the same

faint hologram shimmer as the rest of her, and a man in military uniform who carried himself like someone accustomed to command.

"You must be James," the woman said. "I'm Al'thea. This is Captain Maal."

"Ba'than said you'd discovered some things about your ancestor's research," Maal added, studying James with the assessing gaze of a military intelligence officer. "How much do you know about what we're fighting?"

James felt suddenly inadequate. These two had escaped from elaborate deceptions, discovered the truth about their manipulation through direct experience. He was just a journalist who'd inherited some old files.

"I know that my great-great-great-great-grandfather was investigating something called Operation Mindforge three centuries ago," James began. "He found evidence that human development has been guided by non-human intelligence for millennia. Wars, technological development, social movements—all of it orchestrated to produce specific types of people."

Al'thea leaned forward, interested. "That matches what we've discovered from different angles. The facility where I thought I was hiding from corruption turned out to be a laboratory. They were studying how enhanced humans respond to the illusion of rebellion."

"And my war was a training exercise," Maal said grimly. "My men died testing my psychological responses to loss and isolation. But the scope of the manipulation goes far beyond individual facilities or conflicts."

James activated his holographic display and began sharing the files he'd copied from his ancestor's research. Financial records, communication intercepts, biological data suggesting extensive genetic modification of human populations. As the evidence accumulated on their shared display, he watched both Al'thea and Maal react with recognition.

"The Val'tari," Al'thea said quietly. "Ba'than told you about them?"

"He mentioned the name. Non-human intelligence that's been conducting a breeding experiment on our species." James paused, studying their expressions. "You've learned more about them?"

Maal nodded. "Through captured project files and Ba'than's briefings. They're not just alien—they're so far beyond human cognitive capabilities that we're essentially livestock to them. The entire structure of our civilisation exists to serve their purposes."

"But what purposes?" James asked. "Why spend tens of thousands of years shaping human development? What do they want with us?"

"That's what we're trying to determine," Al'thea replied. "But the immediate problem is that their project is entering its final phase. The pretense of human independence is about to end."

James felt a chill. "What does that mean exactly?"

"Direct control," Maal said. "No more carefully managed illusions or controlled opposition movements. They've bred the humans they need, and now they're ready to implement whatever they've been planning."

The three of them sat in silence for a moment, absorbing the implications. James found himself thinking like a journalist—what evidence would be needed to convince others, how to present information that most people would find literally unbelievable.

"We need to expose this," he said finally. "People have a right to know what's been done to them."

"Expose it how?" Al'thea asked. "Through normal media channels? Those are controlled by the same system we're fighting. Any story you publish will be edited, suppressed, or discredited before it reaches the public."

"She's right," Maal agreed. "This isn't the kind of truth that can be revealed through conventional journalism. The Val'tari have had millennia to build safeguards against exposure."

James bristled slightly. He'd spent his career believing in the power of investigative journalism to reveal important truths. "Then what do you suggest? We just give up on informing people?"

"Not give up," Al'thea said carefully. "But we need to be smarter about how we approach it. The Val'tari's control depends on most humans remaining ignorant of the manipulation. If we can find others who are ready to hear the truth—people who have already begun questioning their reality—we might be able to build a network of aware individuals."

"A real resistance," Maal added. "Made up of people who understand what they're fighting and can't be controlled through conventional means."

James considered this. It went against his journalistic instincts to limit the audience for important information, but he was beginning to understand that normal approaches wouldn't work against this level of sophisticated control.

"Ba'than mentioned that some people have developed beyond their intended parameters," he said. "Enhanced capabilities that the Val'tari didn't expect. How many are we talking about?"

"We don't know," Al'thea admitted. "But there are signs that the process isn't as controlled as the Val'tari believe. Some of us are developing abilities that go beyond what the enhancement programs were supposed to produce."

"What kind of abilities?"

Maal gestured to the holographic display, and the interface responded to his thoughts rather than physical commands. "Improved pattern recognition, intuitive analysis, sometimes what

seems like limited telepathic awareness. The military programs were designed to produce better soldiers, but some subjects are developing strategic thinking that exceeds human norms."

Al'thea nodded. "Academic subjects were supposed to become better researchers and analysts, but some are showing cognitive capabilities that approach the Val'tari baseline levels. The conditioning can't contain development that exceeds the programmers' own understanding."

James felt a strange tingling in his mind as they spoke, almost like his thoughts were resonating with theirs. "I've been noticing things too. Patterns in the information I research, connections that seem obvious but shouldn't be possible to detect with limited data."

"Enhancement effects," Al'thea confirmed. "The Val'tari have been modifying human genetics for thousands of years, but the modifications are becoming more pronounced in recent generations. We might be approaching a tipping point where their control becomes impossible to maintain."

The communication link flickered slightly, indicating that their quantum entanglement was beginning to degrade across the vast distance. They had perhaps another few minutes before the connection would fail.

"We need to meet in person," Maal said. "Share information more directly, coordinate our efforts. But it has to be somewhere the monitoring systems can't track us."

James checked his navigation display. "I'm about six hours out from Kepler-447. Can you wait there?"

"We've already extracted what we could from that location," Al'thea replied. "But I know of another place—a mining operation in the Tau Ceti system that's been abandoned for decades. According to the public records, it's completely derelict, but the quantum infrastructure is still operational."

She transmitted coordinates to James's device. "It's about two days travel from where you are now. We'll meet you there and begin planning our next steps."

"What kind of next steps?" James asked.

"Finding others like us," Maal said. "Building a network that can operate independently of Val'tari surveillance. And ultimately, figuring out how to stop whatever they're planning for the final phase."

The connection was failing now, their holographic images beginning to fragment and distort. But James felt something he hadn't experienced since discovering his ancestor's files—hope. He wasn't alone in his awareness of the manipulation, and he was working with people who had capabilities and knowledge that complemented his own.

"See you at Tau Ceti," he said as the link dissolved.

James sat back in his chair, studying the coordinates Al'thea had provided. In forty-eight hours, he would be meeting with the first genuine resistance fighters he'd encountered—people who understood the true scope of what they were fighting and had the enhanced capabilities to potentially do something about it.

But as he prepared to alter his course towards the Tau Ceti system, James couldn't shake the feeling that their conversation had been too easy, their coordination too smooth. Was this the beginning of real resistance, or just another layer in the elaborate deception that had consumed his ancestor's research?

The only way to find out was to continue forward and hope that his enhanced analytical abilities would be sufficient to detect manipulation when he encountered it.

Outside his transport's viewports, the stars held the dark, unmoving scroll of real space at sublight speed, the actual jump to Tau Ceti still hours off. Somewhere among those distant suns, other enhanced humans might be discovering the truth about their manipulation and taking their first steps towards freedom.

Or they might be walking deeper into a trap so sophisticated that even genuine resistance served the purposes of their controllers.

James adjusted his course towards Tau Ceti and prepared to find out which possibility was true.

Chapter 13

Convergence



The abandoned mining facility at Tau Ceti hung against the star's amber light like a mechanical skeleton, its skeletal framework stripped of everything valuable decades ago. James Rawk's transport drifted towards the derelict structure, following the approach coordinates Al'thea had provided. According to public records, the facility had been abandoned when the asteroid's mineral deposits were exhausted, leaving nothing but empty tunnels and obsolete equipment.

Perfect for a clandestine meeting.

James guided his ship through the facility's massive cargo bay doors, which still responded to standard docking protocols despite the station's official derelict status. Inside, the bay stretched into

darkness, illuminated only by his transport's external lights and the faint glow of emergency power systems that shouldn't have been operational.

Two other ships were already docked—a sleek courier vessel and a military transport that showed signs of recent combat damage. Al'thea and Maal had arrived ahead of him.

As James sealed his airlock and activated his personal atmospheric field, he felt a strange tingling at the edge of his consciousness. Not quite a sound, but something more direct—like thoughts brushing against the borders of his mind. The sensation was completely unlike the computer-mediated telepathy of the Arc network that he'd gained access to after his Ascension. This was raw, unfiltered, bypassing all technological interfaces.

Enhanced abilities, he realised. *We're affecting each other somehow.*

"James." Al'thea's voice came from the shadows near the bay's control station. She emerged into his transport's light pool, moving with fluid precision that seemed almost inhuman, a small black shape riding her shoulder that took its own unhurried moment to decide James wasn't worth further attention. "Welcome to Tau Ceti. How was your journey?"

"Educational," James replied, studying her more carefully than their holographic communication had allowed. She appeared to be in her thirties by physical age, but her eyes held depths that

suggested far more experience. More unsettling, her movements displayed the same uncanny efficiency he'd noticed in Ba'than. "You've changed since our last conversation."

"We all have," Maal said, stepping out from behind a support pillar. The military officer looked like he'd aged years in the past few days, but his bearing had gained an edge of controlled intensity that hadn't been there before. "Being in proximity to each other seems to accelerate whatever the Val'tari did to us. What we're experiencing—it's nothing like the Arc network."

Al'thea looked unsettled, touching her temple unconsciously. "The only telepathic contact I've ever had came through my neural interface. I'm still years away from Ascension and Arc network access. But this... it's like I can sense your thoughts directly, with nothing in between."

They moved deeper into the facility, their footsteps echoing in the vast emptiness. Emergency lighting activated automatically as they passed, creating pools of illumination that followed their progress through corridors lined with abandoned equipment.

"The quantum infrastructure is still functional," Al'thea explained as they walked. "Someone's been maintaining it remotely, though the official records show this place has been dead for forty years. Convenient for people who need to meet without surveillance."

"Too convenient?" James asked. His journalistic paranoia was working overtime, analysing every detail for signs of deception.

"Possibly," Maal admitted. "But we've reached the point where every option carries risks. We can either trust our enhanced analytical abilities to detect manipulation, or we can remain paralyzed by uncertainty."

They reached what had once been the facility's central operations centre—a circular chamber surrounded by defunct control stations and dark displays. Al'thea activated a portable quantum processor, and holographic screens materialised around them, displaying the information they'd gathered about the Val'tari conspiracy.

"Your ancestor's research fills in crucial historical gaps," Al'thea said, calling up Matthias's files. "We knew the manipulation was extensive, but seeing the documented evidence from three centuries ago confirms that this has been a coordinated effort across millennia."

James studied the combined data streams—military intelligence from Maal's investigations, technical analysis from Al'thea's discoveries at Haven, and historical documentation from Matthias's research. Together, they painted a picture of manipulation so comprehensive that it defied belief.

"The breeding program," he said, highlighting genetic modification data that appeared in all three sources. "They haven't just been controlling our social development—they've been changing us physically."

"For thousands of years," Maal confirmed. "The question is what they've been breeding us towards. What capabilities do they want us to have?"

Al'thea gestured to the holographic display, and it responded instantly to her thoughts, reorganising information in patterns that James's enhanced analytical abilities recognised as significant. "Look at the progression over time. Early interventions focused on basic cognitive enhancement—language development, abstract reasoning, technological aptitude. But recent generations show acceleration in areas that approach the Val'tari's own capabilities."

"Pattern recognition that borders on precognition," James observed, following the data streams with growing understanding. "Intuitive leaps that seem to violate normal information processing limitations. Sometimes what appears to be direct mind-to-mind communication."

"Like what we're experiencing right now," Maal said. James realised he was right—they were sharing thoughts and insights with a fluidity that exceeded normal conversation. But this wasn't the computer-mediated communication of the Arc network. This was direct consciousness sharing, unfiltered by technology, unmonitored by any system the Val'tari controlled. Ideas were flowing between them through channels that felt deeper than either speech or standard telepathy.

"This is what they didn't anticipate," Al'thea said, her voice filled with wonder and fear. "The Arc network routes all telepathic communication through controlled systems they can monitor. But this... this is completely outside their technological framework. We're developing capabilities that bypass their entire surveillance infrastructure."

"Or it's exactly what they intended," Maal said slowly. "Enhanced humans who can serve as intermediaries. Beings who can bridge the gap between normal human consciousness and Val'tari intelligence levels."

"For what purpose?"

"Direct administration," Al'thea said, her voice carrying a note of horror. "Once the pretense of human independence ends, they'll need governors who can understand both human psychology and Val'tari objectives. Enhanced humans who are loyal to the system because they believe they're part of it rather than tools being used by it."

James felt pieces clicking into place with terrifying clarity. "That's why the revelation phase exists. They want us to discover the manipulation, work through the psychological trauma, and emerge as willing collaborators who understand our place in their hierarchy."

"Exactly. The resistance movements, the rebellion, even our current awakening—it's all designed to produce the psychological acceptance they need for the final phase."

The three of them stood in the abandoned operations centre, surrounded by evidence of a conspiracy that spanned human civilisation, while enhanced capabilities they barely understood created resonances between their minds. James felt the weight of terrible knowledge settling over him like a physical force.

"So what do we do?" he asked. "If even our resistance is anticipated, how do we fight something that's been planning for millennia?"

"By exceeding their expectations," Al'thea said. "The enhancement process isn't perfectly controlled. Some of us are developing beyond their design parameters, showing capabilities that approach or exceed what they intended."

"Ba'than is proof of that," Maal added. "He was supposed to be a loyal operative, but he evolved genuine independence. If we can understand how that happened and replicate it in others, we might be able to create truly unpredictable resistance."

James activated his personal data storage and began copying everything they'd compiled. "We need to document all of this. Build a record that can survive even if we don't. And we need to find other enhanced individuals who might be ready for the truth."

"Carefully," Al'thea warned. "The monitoring systems are sophisticated, and approaching the wrong people could expose the entire network. We need to identify subjects who are already questioning their reality—people who have noticed inconsistencies or developed abilities beyond their programming."

"Military personnel who've seen through the artificial wars," Maal suggested. "Academics who've discovered gaps in the official knowledge base. Journalists who've found stories that don't add up."

"And people in the experimental programs," James added, thinking about the implications of what they'd learned. "If there are enhanced humans being raised in controlled environments, some of them might be developing beyond expectations too."

They spent the next several hours planning their approach—communication protocols for secure contact, criteria for identifying potential recruits, strategies for building a network that could operate independently of Val'tari surveillance. As they worked, James became increasingly aware of the way their enhanced abilities complemented each other. Al'thea's analytical capabilities, Maal's strategic thinking, his own pattern recognition—together, they were developing insights that none of them could have achieved alone.

Is this what the Val'tari intended? he wondered. *Are we becoming exactly what they wanted us to be?*

But as the planning session continued, James noticed something that gave him hope. Their collaboration was producing ideas and strategies that seemed to surprise even them—creative leaps and innovative approaches that felt genuinely unpredictable. If they were tools being shaped by superior intelligence, they were at least becoming tools with unexpected capabilities.

"There's something else," Al'thea said as the planning session wound down. "Ba'than mentioned that the final phase is approaching rapidly. We may have weeks rather than months to build effective resistance."

"What triggers the final phase?" James asked.

"Unknown. But the signs suggest it's tied to reaching critical mass in the enhanced population. Once they have enough suitable administrators, the pretense of human independence becomes unnecessary."

Maal checked his military communications array. "I can stretch my leave another two days before my absence gets noticed. After that, I need to be back with my unit. But I can use my position to identify other military personnel who might be ready for awakening."

"And I have contacts in the academic community who've been asking uncomfortable questions," Al'thea added. "People who might be ready to hear the truth if it's presented carefully."

James looked around the abandoned operations centre, filled with the debris of human industrial ambition and the evidence of manipulation that stretched back to the dawn of civilisation. "Then we move fast. Build the network, document everything, and hope that genuine independence is possible even in a system designed to prevent it."

Before anyone could answer, Al'thea's device chimed. She read the message, and a small frown creased her forehead.

"We're not finished," she said. "It's from Ba'than. He's sending someone else—a xenobiologist named Elena Vasquez. He says she's found something in her research, and she needs to meet us before we split up."

"When?" Maal asked.

"Two days."

Maal let out a slow breath. "That's cutting it close." But he didn't argue.

The two days passed strangely. James spent most of them working through the combined data, and the rest walking the facility's empty tunnels, trying to absorb what he'd learned. The emergency lights woke ahead of him and went dark behind him, as if the station itself were keeping watch.

He noticed that the resonance between the three of them grew stronger the longer they stayed together. By the second day, he could often tell what Al'thea was about to say a moment before she said it, and he sometimes caught Maal glancing up at the exact moment James had thought of a question. It felt like instruments slowly tuning to one another.

He found he no longer much cared whether the Val'tari had intended it. It was happening either way, and it was the first thing since he'd opened his ancestor's files that felt like it belonged to him rather than to whatever they'd shaped him to become.

Late on the second day, the facility's docking sensors registered a small research vessel on approach.

James didn't need to check the display. Before the alert had finished sounding, he felt her: a new mind at the edge of theirs. Sharp, methodical, and badly frightened, carrying something she hadn't yet told anyone.

Al'thea looked up from her work. Maal's hand drifted to his sidearm out of habit.

"That's her," Al'thea said.

Through the operations centre's viewport, James watched the ship's running lights slide towards the cargo bay. Beyond them, the stars hung in patterns that suddenly seemed less random than he'd ever imagined. Each point of light represented a system where

enhanced humans might be discovering the truth about their nature, taking their first steps towards genuine independence or walking deeper into the trap that had been prepared for them.

The answer would determine not just their own fate, but the future of human consciousness itself.

Chapter 14

Awakening



Dr. Elena Vasquez had always prided herself on her rational approach to scientific research. Fifteen years in xenobiology had taught her to follow evidence wherever it led, no matter how uncomfortable the conclusions. But the data streaming across her laboratory displays was challenging every assumption she'd held about her field—and her life.

The genetic samples were wrong. All of them.

Elena stared at the molecular analysis results for the third time, hoping she'd made some fundamental error in her methodology. But the quantum processors didn't lie, and the patterns they revealed in supposedly alien genetic material were impossible to ignore.

Every xenobiological specimen in the university's extensive collection—samples gathered from dozens of different worlds over the past century—showed clear evidence of artificial modification. Not the kind of natural genetic variation you'd expect from independent evolutionary processes, but deliberate engineering that followed consistent design principles.

As if someone had been seeding worlds with predetermined life forms.

"Still here, Elena?" Dr. Marcus Chen poked his head through her laboratory door, concern evident in his voice. "It's past midnight. Even dedicated researchers need sleep."

Elena gestured at her displays without looking away from the data. "Marcus, I need you to verify something. Run independent analysis on the Kepler-438b samples—the ones we classified as primitive arthropods."

Marcus frowned but moved to the auxiliary workstation. "What am I looking for?"

"Genetic markers that suggest artificial modification. Specifically, look for base pair sequences that follow mathematical rather than evolutionary patterns."

The silence that followed was broken only by the hum of quantum processors and the distant vibration of the station's life support systems. Elena watched Marcus's expression change from professional curiosity to confusion to something approaching alarm.

"Elena... these aren't naturally evolved organisms."

"No," she confirmed. "They're not. And neither are any of the other samples in our collection. Every single specimen shows evidence of deliberate genetic engineering using principles that are far beyond current human capabilities."

Marcus moved to her workstation, studying the comparative analysis she'd compiled. "This is impossible. We're talking about organisms collected from systems that are light-years apart, with no possible contact between their evolutionary environments."

"Unless there was contact," Elena said quietly. "Unless someone has been travelling between these systems for far longer than we've suspected, seeding them with life forms designed to follow specific developmental patterns."

There was a second anomaly, one Elena hadn't mentioned to anyone. The engineering wasn't identical from world to world. It came in versions—layers of design laid one over another like coats of paint—and the versions weren't scattered at random. Worlds in one region of space carried the newest design. Worlds farther away

carried older ones, and the farther out she looked, the older they became, as if every change had spread outward from somewhere and simply hadn't reached the most distant systems yet.

It made no sense. Anyone capable of seeding life across dozens of star systems would surely be capable of updating them all at once. She'd been staring at the pattern for a week and still couldn't find a way to describe it that didn't sound insane.

So she hadn't described it at all.

They stood in the laboratory's artificial lighting, surrounded by the tools and specimens of careers built on what they'd thought was legitimate scientific discovery. Elena felt the foundations of her professional life cracking like ice under spring thaw.

"We need to report this," Marcus said, though his voice lacked conviction. "If there's evidence of advanced non-human intelligence conducting genetic engineering on this scale..."

"Report it to whom?" Elena asked. "The University Xenobiology Board? The Teachers Guild? What if they already know? What if this is exactly what they expected us to find?"

The question hung between them like a physical presence. Marcus sat heavily in a chair, staring at the genetic analysis displays. "You think our research has been guided? That we've been discovering exactly what someone wanted us to discover?"

Elena activated her personal workstation and began pulling up files she'd been reviewing for the past week. "I've been looking into the history of our field. The funding sources, the research priorities, the way discoveries have been made and announced. There are patterns, Marcus. Coordinated patterns that suggest someone has been orchestrating xenobiological research from the beginning."

"That's... that's a massive conspiracy theory, Elena."

"Is it? Or is it the only explanation that fits the evidence?"

As they talked, Elena became aware of a strange sensation at the edge of her consciousness—not quite a thought, but something more direct than normal mental activity. Almost like hearing voices in the distance, but the voices were inside her mind.

Enhanced capabilities, she realised with sudden clarity. *I'm developing enhanced capabilities.*

She'd heard rumours about the phenomenon—researchers and academics who seemed to develop analytical abilities beyond normal human parameters. The University claimed it was a natural result of intensive study and neural interface use, but Elena had always suspected there was more to it than official explanations suggested.

Now, surrounded by evidence of genetic manipulation that spanned multiple star systems, she wondered if the enhanced capabilities were just another form of artificial modification.

"Marcus," she said carefully, "have you noticed any changes in your thinking patterns lately? Improved analysis speed, pattern recognition that seems almost intuitive?"

He looked startled. "How did you know? I've been attributing it to experience, but lately I've been seeing connections in data that I shouldn't be able to detect with normal analysis."

Elena felt a chill of recognition. "We're both developing beyond normal parameters. Just like the organisms we've been studying—we're showing signs of artificial enhancement."

Before Marcus could respond, Elena's communication array chimed with an incoming quantum message. The sender's identification was masked behind advanced encryption, but the message itself was brief and disturbing:

"Dr. Vasquez—Your research into genetic patterns has not gone unnoticed. If you are ready to learn the truth about your discoveries, there is someone who can provide answers. Transit to coordinates 47.3.891.7, Tau Ceti system, within 72 hours. This channel will not be used again — decide alone, and tell no one where you are going. —A friend."

Elena stared at the message, her enhanced analytical abilities immediately recognising several troubling implications. The encryption was military-grade, far beyond what civilians should have access to. The sender had detailed knowledge of her research

despite her laboratory's security protocols. And most disturbing, they seemed to know about the enhanced capabilities she'd only just begun to understand.

"Elena? What is it?" Marcus moved to her workstation, reading the message over her shoulder. "Who knows about your research?"

"Someone with resources and knowledge far beyond anything we've encountered in academic circles." Elena began copying her research files to secure storage, her mind racing through possibilities. "Marcus, I want you to continue the analysis while I'm gone. The version layering in particular—I want to know whether the pattern holds across the whole collection. But be careful. If I'm right about the scope of what we've discovered, there may be people who don't want this information to become public."

"You're actually going to respond to an anonymous message? Elena, this could be incredibly dangerous."

"More dangerous than spending my career studying fake alien life forms without knowing it?" Elena replied. "I need answers, Marcus. And this might be the only way to get them."

She spent the next hour securing her research and making arrangements for her absence. As she worked, the strange mental sensation intensified—she could sense Marcus's growing anxiety, feel his analytical mind working through the implications of their

discoveries, as clearly as if he'd spoken aloud. She had no name for it and no baseline to measure it against. Whatever this was, it wasn't in any of the literature she knew.

Just like the genetic modifications, she realised. *Artificial enhancement that goes beyond the official parameters.*

The transit to Tau Ceti took thirty-six hours, giving Elena time to review everything she'd learned and prepare for whatever awaited her — and to talk herself out of turning back at least three times. The coordinates led to an abandoned mining facility, officially derelict, its cargo bay already holding three other ships by the time she docked alongside them.

She ran the version-pattern numbers one more time before she cut her engines, the way she'd have made a first-year student run them: not because she doubted the maths, but because a good scientist reran an experiment before trusting it, and this was the strangest experiment of her life. The numbers held, same as the last four times. As she sealed her airlock and activated her atmospheric field, the mental sensation she'd first felt in her own laboratory sharpened into something almost physical.

Other enhanced individuals, she understood. *People like me, developing capabilities beyond normal human parameters.*

"Dr. Vasquez." A young woman emerged from the shadows, moving with fluid precision that seemed almost inhuman, a small dark bird settled on her shoulder watching Elena with what

looked, disconcertingly, like the same clinical assessment Elena was running on everyone else in the room. "I'm Al'thea. Thank you for coming."

Two men accompanied her—one in military uniform, the other with the alert bearing of someone accustomed to asking uncomfortable questions. Elena's enhanced awareness immediately recognised them as individuals whose development had exceeded normal parameters.

"You're all enhanced," she said without preamble. "Artificially modified, like the organisms I've been studying."

"Yes," the military officer confirmed. "Captain Maal. And this is James Rawk, investigative journalist. We've all discovered evidence that our reality isn't what we believed it to be."

They moved deeper into the facility, and Elena felt her mind settling into resonance with theirs, like a fourth instrument finding a key the other three had already agreed on.

"The genetic samples you've been analysing," Al'thea said, responding to thoughts Elena hadn't spoken aloud. "They're not from naturally evolved organisms. They're from breeding experiments conducted by advanced non-human intelligence."

Elena felt pieces clicking into place with terrifying clarity. "The Val'tari. You know about them."

"We know that they've been manipulating human development for millennia," James replied. "Your research into xenobiology is part of a larger pattern—academics and researchers discovering exactly what the controllers want them to discover."

"But some discoveries are revealing more than intended," Maal added. "The genetic analysis you've conducted goes beyond what they expected any human scientist to detect. Your enhanced capabilities are allowing you to see patterns they thought were safely hidden."

Elena absorbed this information with the analytical precision of someone trained to evaluate extraordinary claims. But her enhanced abilities were confirming what normal reasoning would have rejected—every piece of evidence supported the conclusion that her entire career had been orchestrated by intelligence far beyond human capabilities.

"What do you want from me?" she asked.

"Help us understand the biological aspects of their manipulation," Al'thea replied. "We know they've been modifying human genetics, but we need someone with your expertise to determine the scope and purpose of the changes."

Elena activated her portable analysis equipment and began sharing the data she'd compiled. As the information integrated with what the others had discovered, new patterns emerged that none of them could have seen alone.

"They're not just breeding enhanced humans," Elena said, her voice filled with wonder and horror. "They're creating an entirely new subspecies. Look at the genetic markers—the modifications go far beyond individual enhancement. They're preparing for speciation."

The others studied her analysis with growing alarm. The genetic changes Elena had documented suggested planned evolutionary divergence on a scale that would permanently separate enhanced humans from the baseline population.

"A ruling class," James said grimly. "They're breeding administrators who will be biologically different from the people they govern."

"And the enhanced capabilities we're developing," Maal added, "they're not accidents or unexpected side effects. They're the intended result of modifications that have been accumulating across generations."

Elena felt the full weight of the revelation settling over her. "We're not human anymore. Not in the biological sense. We're something new—something designed to serve purposes we can't even comprehend."

But as they worked, Elena noticed something that gave her hope. Their collaboration was producing insights and capabilities that seemed to exceed even the Val'tari's expectations. If they were tools being shaped by superior intelligence, they were becoming tools with unpredictable capabilities.

"There's something else," she said, highlighting specific genetic sequences in her analysis. "The modifications show signs of instability. The enhancement process isn't perfectly controlled—some subjects are developing far beyond the intended parameters."

"Like us," Al'thea said.

"Exactly. And if the process is becoming unstable, if enhanced humans are evolving capabilities the Val'tari didn't anticipate, then their control may not be as absolute as they believe."

The resonance that had been building between the four of them since she arrived suddenly deepened, past anything James, Al'thea, or Maal had felt alone in the operations centre at Tau Ceti. For a moment, there were no longer four minds in the room, but one awareness looking out through four sets of eyes—perceiving patterns and possibilities none of them could have held alone. Whatever this was, it was bigger with four than it had been with three, and Elena's last coherent thought before the fusion took her was that she did not want to be there when it scaled to forty.

And at the very edge of it, so faint Elena would later wonder whether she'd imagined it, there was something else. Not a thought. A pressure. Vast and unhurried, like standing on a shore and feeling the pull of a tide whose next wave was still centuries away.

Al'thea gasped, her hand pressed to her forehead. "I've never... is this what the Val'tari experience naturally? Direct mind-to-mind fusion?"

Then the sensation faded, leaving them as four separate individuals again. James was staring at nothing. Maal had one hand braced against a console. None of them mentioned the tide, and Elena couldn't tell whether that was because they hadn't felt it or because they had.

Elena almost told them about the versions then. The map sat in her personal storage, one gesture away, and the ripples in her data and the pull at the edge of that shared awareness felt, absurdly, like the same shape. But something held her back—the same instinct that made a good scientist rerun an experiment before publishing it. She wanted Marcus's numbers first. She wanted to be certain she wasn't seeing faces in clouds.

Soon, she promised herself.

They spent what time they had left integrating Elena's biological research with their growing understanding of the Val'tari conspiracy. As they worked, Elena became increasingly aware that

she was participating in something unprecedented—genuine resistance by enhanced humans who understood the true scope of their manipulation.

Within a few hours, Maal's leave had run out. They parted in the docking bay with few words: Maal back to his unit, James to follow his ancestor's trail, Al'thea back into hiding, hoping the friends she'd left behind were still safe. And Elena back to her laboratory, and to Marcus.

The question that haunted her on the journey home was whether their resistance was authentic or whether even this gathering had been anticipated and planned by intelligence so far beyond their own that their rebellion might serve purposes they couldn't comprehend.

Outside her ship's viewports, the stars hung in patterns that suddenly seemed less random than Elena had ever imagined. Each point of light represented a system where the Val'tari might have conducted genetic experiments, seeded life forms designed to produce specific evolutionary outcomes, and shaped the development of intelligence itself.

The scope was so vast it defied comprehension. But Elena's enhanced analytical abilities were revealing possibilities for resistance that might exceed the controllers' expectations—if they could understand their own capabilities before the final phase eliminated the possibility of genuine independence forever.



Za'ra — one of the four friends Al'thea had once spent whole evenings with in the Teacher Vessel's puzzle room, working through the same shared logic problem at the same battered table — had built a life out of exactly the skill Al'thea used to tease her for: the gift of making a room comfortable without anyone quite noticing she'd done the work. Eleven months after she vanished from the Teacher Vessel — an attack that had, as far as any of them knew, killed her — that skill was the only thing still holding the four of them together at all.

They met on the anniversary because De'to had asked, the first year, and because no one since had found the courage to suggest they stop. A quiet table at the back of a dining hall that had nothing to do with any of them, chosen for exactly that reason. Fal'le arrived first, as he always did now, gold hair cut shorter than it used to be, laughing too readily at things that weren't funny. Me'dan came next, quieter every year, his eyes finding the empty fifth chair before he'd finished sitting in his own. De'to was last, the way he was always last, as if arriving on time meant admitting the anniversary was really happening.

Za'ra held the table together the way she'd once held their whole friend group together on the Teacher Vessel—reading each of them the instant they walked in, offering Fal'le the laugh his jokes needed, letting Me'dan's silences sit unfilled exactly as long as he needed them to, steering De'to's third mention of the puzzle

rooms towards a story that let him talk about Al'thea without quite talking about losing her. She had never been taught to do this. She had simply always known how, the way she'd always known which of her friends needed teasing and which needed quiet, and for most of her life it had felt like nothing more than being good with people. Tonight, watching De'to's hands shake around a cup he wasn't drinking from, it felt like the only useful thing she had left to give any of them.

She waited until the others had gone before she let her own face stop working.

The dining hall thinned out around her, staff resetting tables for a morning shift that had nothing to do with grief. Za'ra sat alone with the fifth chair and did the thing she never let the others see her do: she pictured Al'thea exactly as she'd last seen her, mid-argument about a warehouse puzzle nobody else had liked, gold curls escaping their tie, that unguarded look she wore only when she thought no one was reading her closely enough to notice. Za'ra had always been reading her that closely. It was, she sometimes thought, the whole shape of their friendship—Al'thea's fierce, prickly intelligence, and Za'ra's quiet, constant translation of it for everyone too impatient to earn it themselves.

I should have told her I noticed, she thought, for perhaps the thousandth time. *I should have told her that seeing her that clearly was never a small thing.*

There had been no body to grieve over, no wreckage they'd ever been shown—only an official notice, clean and final, and the cruelty of a death with no evidence attached to it, nothing to argue with, nothing to doubt. Za'ra had spent eleven months doing for herself exactly what she did for the others: reading her own grief with the same unsparing clarity she read everyone else's, and finding no comfortable place to set it down.

She thought, not for the first time, that it was strange how much easier it was to carry other people's pain than her own. She could feel a room's worth of feeling shift a full breath before anyone else in it noticed, could find the one true thing to say to steady four grieving men without once having to think about how she'd learned to do it. And yet here, alone, with no one left to steady but herself, the gift simply had nothing to hold on to. It had never once been about her own heart. She wondered, staring at the empty chair, whether it ever would be.

Somewhere else entirely, in a derelict station she would never see and could not have imagined, the woman she was grieving stood in a circle of three strangers who were rapidly becoming something closer than strangers, feeling her own mind dissolve for a moment into something larger than any of them could hold alone—alive, changed beyond anything Za'ra could have pictured, and carrying, without knowing it yet, exactly the kind of grief she had just spent an evening pouring into four other people instead of into herself.

Za'ra put the fifth chair back under the table, the way she did every year, and went home alone.

Chapter 15

Ripples



Marcus was waiting in the laboratory when Elena got back. He looked like he hadn't slept since she'd left.

His hair stood up on one side where he'd been running his hand through it. Three cups of cold tea sat abandoned across the auxiliary workstation, each with a skin on the surface. The main displays were dark except for one, which showed nothing but a slowly rotating field of stars.

"You're back," he said, as if he'd forgotten that was possible. "Good. Close the door."

Elena closed it. After thirty-six hours of transit and a night of sharing her mind with three strangers, the familiar smells of the lab —steriliser fluid, warm electronics, the faint sourness of specimen gel—should have been comforting. Instead, she felt the small hairs rise on her arms. Through the new, raw sense she still didn't have a name for, Marcus's mind came across as a single bright note of fear, held too long.

"Tell me," she said.

"You asked me to check whether the version pattern held across the whole collection." He laughed, a thin, cracked sound. "It holds, Elena. It holds everywhere. Every world, every sample, every layer. And that's not even the worst part."

He gestured, and the star field on the display bloomed with colour.

Hundreds of worlds lit up, each one a point tinted by the age of the genetic design it carried. At first the pattern looked like noise—a spray of golds and blues and deep reds scattered across human space. Then Marcus pulled the view back, and back again, until the individual systems blurred together, and Elena saw it.

Rings.

Faint concentric shells of colour, nested one inside another, spreading outward across the map like the ripples from a stone dropped into a pond. The newest design sat in the innermost

rings. Each shell outward carried an older version, and the oldest designs of all lingered in the farthest, loneliest systems, where the newer ripples hadn't yet arrived.

"Each ring is a revision," Marcus said. "A change to the design. It starts in one place and spreads outward in every direction. By the time it reaches the edge, there's already another change coming up behind it."

Elena stepped closer. She could feel her pulse in her throat. "You've dated them?"

"Some of them." He brought up a column of figures. "Wherever the seeded organisms left a clean fossil sequence, I can see the moment one version replaced another. Dozens of worlds. Enough to measure how fast each ripple is travelling."

"And?"

Marcus didn't answer right away. He picked up one of the cold teas, looked at it, and put it down again.

"It's the speed of light," he said. "Not roughly. Not within some margin I can argue with. Every ripple, every revision, crossing space at exactly the speed of light."

Elena stared at the rings until they seemed to move.

Nothing about that number should have been possible. Ships crossed light-years in hours. Quantum communication tied star systems together instantly. The Val'tari—if Al'thea and the others

were right—had been running human civilisation across all of known space, and a species capable of that could send an instruction anywhere it liked in a heartbeat.

So why would their instructions *crawl*?

"It's as if whoever sends the changes can't use any of it," Marcus said, echoing her thought so exactly that she wondered, uneasily, whether she'd projected it into him. "No jump drives, no quantum relays. As if every message has to be carried by light, the slow way, one year for every light-year."

"Or they choose not to use it."

"Why would anyone choose that?"

Elena didn't have an answer. She walked around the display, studying the rings from another angle. "What about the designs themselves? Do the revisions get better over time?"

"That's the other strange thing." Marcus enlarged two genetic sequences side by side. "This is one of the oldest versions we have. And this one's recent."

Elena didn't need her enhanced abilities to see the difference. The old design was beautiful. There was no other word for it. Every sequence folded into the next with a kind of mathematical grace, each element serving several purposes at once, nothing wasted. It read like a proof written by someone who had understood the whole problem in a single glance.

The new design did the same job. But it was cautious. Redundant. Patched in places, with sections repeated as if someone had been afraid to leave anything out. It looked like the work of someone copying instructions they no longer fully understood, and who was too frightened of making a mistake to change a single line.

"The recent versions are worse," Elena said slowly.

"Not worse. More careful." Marcus rubbed his eyes. "Like the original author stopped writing, and someone else has been maintaining it ever since."

Elena looked back at the rings. If she followed them inward, shell by shell, the ripples didn't collapse neatly to a single point—the centre of the pattern smeared across a region too vast to pin down with the samples they had. But they all pointed the same way.

Inward. Towards the galactic core.



She contacted Ba'than an hour later, from her quarters, using the Sigma-7 protocols Al'thea had given her at Tau Ceti.

The link took a long time to establish. When it finally did, Ba'than's projection appeared seated in a plain, dim room with no windows. He looked tired in a way Elena was beginning to recognise—the exhaustion of someone who carried more than he said.

"Dr. Vasquez. I understood you were returning to your laboratory."

"I did. Marcus finished an analysis while I was away. I think you need to see it."

She sent the map.

Elena had spent a career watching people react to data. Surprise, scepticism, excitement—she knew all their shapes. Ba'than's reaction wasn't any of them. He went completely still. Not calm. *Still*, the way a small animal goes still when a shadow passes overhead.

"Who else has seen this?" he asked quietly.

"Marcus. Me. Now you."

"The others? Al'thea, Maal, James?"

"Not yet. I wanted to be sure first."

Something eased very slightly in his face, and that frightened her more than anything else he could have done.

"Destroy it," Ba'than said. "Every copy. Every intermediate file. Tonight."

"Excuse me?"

"I mean it, Elena. Delete the analysis, purge the query history, and tell Marcus to forget he ever ran it."

"You recruited me because I follow evidence," she said, heat rising in her voice. "You don't get to decide which evidence I'm allowed to follow."

"I recruited you so that we could understand what was done to us. Not so that—" He stopped. For a moment, she thought she saw him weigh a sentence and put it carefully back.

"Not so that *what*?"

"There are questions they will forgive," Ba'than said. "Questions about the project, about corruption, even about the Val'tari themselves. Those questions are expected. Some of them are even encouraged. This is not one of those questions."

"Why? What does it mean?"

"How did Marcus date the transitions?"

The change of subject threw her. "Fossil sequences. He cross-referenced them against the University's deep archive."

Ba'than closed his eyes.

"The deep archive belongs to them," he said. "Every query leaves a footprint. Hundreds of dating requests, all converging on the same pattern, from a single terminal, in a single week." He opened his eyes again, and his voice was very gentle. "They move quickly, Elena. Far more quickly than you'd expect from something so old. Get Marcus off that station."

"You haven't answered my question."

"No," Ba'than agreed. "I haven't."

The link dissolved.



Marcus didn't answer his door.

Elena stood in the corridor outside his quarters for a long time, pressing the chime, calling his name, trying to reach him with the raw new sense that had connected them in the lab. She found nothing. Not absence exactly—something more like static.

At last the door opened.

Marcus stood there in his sleeping clothes, blinking at her. He looked rested. Better than rested; he looked peaceful, the tension gone from his shoulders, the haunted brightness gone from his eyes.

"Elena? It's the middle of the night." He smiled at her with mild, sleepy affection. "Is something wrong? How was the conference?"

"The conference," she repeated.

"The xenobiology symposium. That's where you went, isn't it?" A small line creased his forehead, then smoothed away. "Sorry. I'm half asleep. I spent all day cleaning up that corrupted dataset from the Kepler samples. Turns out the modification markers were a processing error. Almost embarrassing, how excited we got."

Elena couldn't speak.

"You should get some rest," Marcus said kindly. "You look exhausted."

Carefully, the way she might have touched a wound, Elena reached towards his mind.

The fear was gone. So was the excitement, and the rings, and the terrible elegance of the old designs, and every hour they had spent in the laboratory staring at the impossible. In their place was something smooth. Not a scar, because a scar remembers the wound. This was like new skin grown neatly over a place where nothing had ever happened.

"Goodnight, Marcus," she heard herself say.

"Goodnight."

The door closed.



Her laboratory was spotless.

Every display was dark. The cold tea cups were gone. When Elena activated her workstation, the xenobiology collection loaded normally, every sample labelled and catalogued exactly as it had been for a century. She ran the modification analysis on the Kepler-438b arthropods.

Natural variation. Nothing mathematical. Nothing designed.

She checked her personal storage. The map was gone. The copies were gone. The secure backup she'd made before Tau Ceti was gone, and the log showed it had been removed during a routine audit, completed four hours earlier.

In the audit notes, in the dry language of a maintenance record, was a single line:

Findings outside Directive. Remediated.

The door chimed. Elena flinched so hard she knocked her stool over.

The man in the corridor wore the grey robes of University administration. Provost Ter'an was a kind, round-faced man in his forties, dark hair greying at the temples behind wire-rimmed glasses, who had signed Elena's research grants for ten years and remembered the names of everyone's children. He smiled at her with genuine warmth.

"Dr. Vasquez. I'm so sorry to disturb you at this hour. I saw your terminal come online and wanted to catch you." He stepped inside and glanced around the lab. "I'm afraid the archive audit flagged some corrupted data in your collection. We've restored the clean versions. You shouldn't have any more trouble."

"That's very efficient," Elena said. Her voice sounded strange to her own ears.

"We try." He hesitated. "You've been working terribly hard, Elena. Marcus too. I've arranged some leave for both of you. Take a few weeks. Rest."

Elena reached for his mind almost without meaning to.

What she found surprised her. The Provost wasn't cruel, and he wasn't lying about his concern. He liked her. He was worried about her. But beneath the kindness lay something else, cold and old and carefully contained, and it took her a moment to recognise it.

Fear. Not of her. Of something above him—far above him—that he could not picture clearly and did not dare to disappoint.

"Some findings are outside Directive, Doctor," Ter'an said softly, as if he were apologising. "It's no one's fault. Please, get some sleep."

He left.



Elena did not sleep.

She sat on the floor of her laboratory with her back against the specimen cabinets, and she closed her eyes, and she found that they hadn't taken everything.

The map was still there. Not in any storage device—in her. Every ring. Every colour. Every shell of revision spreading outward at the speed of light. She had looked at it for less than an hour, and her mind had kept all of it, perfectly, the way it had started keeping everything lately.

Without really deciding to, she raised her hands and began to draw.

Hard light answered her gestures, thin gold lines hanging in the dark lab. One ring, then another, then another, nested inside each other, rippling outward from a centre she couldn't see. Symbols she didn't recognise began to form along the edges, delicate and interconnected, as if part of her understood the pattern better than the rest of her did.

When she finished, she sat looking at it until the station's lights began their slow brightening towards morning.

Two impossible facts sat side by side in her mind, and she couldn't make them fit together.

Whoever had erased Marcus had done it in a single night. They had seen her question, understood it, and answered it within hours.

But whoever had written the instructions inside those genes needed thousands of years to change their mind.

Elena stared at the rings, trying to decide which of those two things frightened her more.

Chapter 16

First Recruit



The file arrived from Ba'than without explanation, the way most of what Ba'than sent arrived — a single encrypted packet, no covering message, as if the material itself were meant to make its own case.

James opened it expecting another funding trail. Instead he found a partial extraction from something that read like a surveillance dossier, names and psychological profiles and behavioural assessments, the clinical language of an institution cataloguing its own subjects. Most of it was redacted past any use. But one name sat unredacted near the top of a subject file labelled only with a designation James didn't recognise, cross-referenced against a small

cluster of other names under a heading that had survived the redaction by accident or by design: *Known associates, Subject — monitor for behavioural drift following extraction event.*

Za'ra. Beneath it, three more names, and a note in the same dry institutional hand: *Subjects believe associate deceased. No indication of independent suspicion. Continue standard monitoring.*

James read it four times before he understood what he was looking at. Somewhere, a project this vast had once run an experiment on a Trainee, staged her death convincingly enough that her closest friends had spent — he checked the file's own timestamp against the date — the better part of a year grieving someone who might still be alive. And the file's own bored, bureaucratic tone made clear that nobody administering it had ever once considered the friends worth a second thought, except as a variable to keep monitoring in case their grief turned into questions.

No indication of independent suspicion. James sat with that sentence for a long time. It was, he understood slowly, both an assurance to whoever had filed the report and a kind of accusation, if you read it the way his ancestor had taught him to read everything: an admission that someone, somewhere, had checked.

He thought about Halvorsen, forty years into a career of noticing the one thread nobody else had noticed, and about what a good source actually needed to be — not someone who already believed, but someone who had already started asking the uncomfortable question and simply lacked anywhere to take it.

He composed his approach to Za'ra as a journalist, because that, at least, was entirely true.



She agreed to meet him at a café in the University district, chosen — he suspected, correctly — because it put a crowd of ordinary, uninvolved people between herself and whatever he turned out to be. She arrived precisely on time, dressed with the unhurried elegance of someone who had decided, deliberately, that grief would not be allowed to also cost her the rest of herself.

"Mr. Rawk." She studied him for a moment before she sat, the unbroken attention of someone reading far more than his introduction had given her. "You said you're investigating training-accident fatalities. That's a strange thing for a journalist to specialise in."

"It's a strange pattern, once you start looking for it." James kept his voice level, the practised neutrality of a hundred prior interviews, though something in her gaze made the performance feel thinner than usual. "I've found six incidents in the last three years, across three different services, that share an unusual profile. Small groups. High-potential subjects. Total losses, no survivors to contradict the official account, and grieving families who were never given anything to actually look at."

"You think my friends' deaths belong on that list."

"I think the pattern doesn't care what I believe. I think you might have noticed something about the official account that never quite sat right, and never had anywhere useful to take it." He held her gaze. "I'm not here to reopen a wound for a story, Ms. — I don't actually have your family name."

"Just Za'ra is fine. Nobody's used the rest of it in years." She turned her cup slowly, the same unhurried composure she'd carried into the room, and James understood, watching her, exactly what Mar'ika must have meant when she'd once described the gift some people had for reading a room before it had finished forming. Za'ra wasn't looking at his notes or his credentials. She was looking at him, the way he imagined she looked at everyone, cataloguing something underneath the words. "You're not being fully honest with me either, Mr. Rawk. I don't think it's about the story. I think the story is real to you, but it isn't the whole reason you're sitting here."

James felt something in his chest go very still. "What makes you say that?"

"Because I've spent a year now watching people be careful around me in very specific ways, and you're not doing any of them. You're not being gentle the way people are gentle with grief they think is fragile. You're being careful the way people are careful with something they think might actually matter." She set the cup down. "So. What actually sat wrong with you about my friends' deaths?"

He hadn't planned to tell her the truth this directly, this early. But something about the exact precision of the question — not *what happened*, but *what sat wrong with you* — made every rehearsed version of his approach feel suddenly beneath what she'd already earned.

"The explosion that killed them was too clean," James said slowly, choosing every word the way Ba'than had once chosen his in a dim storage bay. "Total loss, no debris field consistent with the reported cause, response times from a rescue vessel that happened to be conveniently close. I've seen that exact signature five other times, in five other 'accidents,' and every time, the survivors — if there were any — describe grief that never quite got to finish, because there was never anything solid enough underneath it to hold onto."

Za'ra was very quiet for a long moment.

"I used to tell myself I was being unreasonable," she said finally, her composure cracking for the first time since she'd sat down, just at the edges. "That grief makes people look for patterns that aren't there, because a pattern is easier to carry than randomness. De'to still believes the official report completely. Fal'le doesn't think about it at all if he can help it. I'm the only one who kept a copy of the investigation summary and read it enough times to notice the rescue vessel's registry number changes between two different releases of the same document." She looked up at him. "I never told anyone that. I didn't think anyone would believe it mattered."

"It matters," James said. "I don't yet know what it means. I know it isn't nothing."



They talked for two hours past when the café's ordinary lunch crowd thinned around them, and James found himself, by the end of it, doing something he rarely allowed a source to see: thinking out loud, uncertain, rather than performing the confident authority of a man who already had the story assembled. He did not tell her about the Val'tari. He did not tell her about Al'thea, or the resonance, or anything that would have turned an honest grief into a false hope built on a truth she wasn't yet positioned to survive learning. He told her only what was already, entirely, true: that a pattern existed, that he intended to keep pulling every thread of it he could reach, and that a person who had already noticed one loose thread on her own, quietly, for a year, without anywhere to take it, was exactly the kind of ally his slow, patient case would eventually need.

"What would you actually want from me?" Za'ra asked, as the light outside began to shift towards evening.

"Not much, yet. A conversation, sometimes. A second set of eyes on something that doesn't add up, when I don't have anyone else to show it to who'd actually look closely. You read people better

than anyone I've met in a long time — I'd be lying if I said that wasn't useful to a story built entirely out of who's telling the truth and who's reciting a script."

"And eventually?"

"Eventually, I don't know yet. I'm not building towards one dramatic moment where everything gets proven at once. I don't think that moment exists — I think whoever's behind this has spent a very long time making sure it never could. I'm building towards enough people asking the same question independently that no one story has to carry the whole weight alone." He held out a small, unlabeled data device, the same kind Ba'than had once put into his own hand in a darkened transport bay. "You don't have to decide today."

Za'ra took it anyway, turning it over once in her fingers with the same unhurried care she brought to everything, and James understood, watching her, that she had already decided — not out of belief, not yet, but out of a stubborn refusal to keep pretending a wound had healed just because pretending was easier than the alternative.

"My friend Al'thea used to design puzzle rooms," she said, apropos of nothing James could immediately place, her eyes distant for a moment. "Convoluted, impossible things nobody else could ever solve on the first try. I used to tease her that she built them too complicated on purpose, so nobody would ever actually finish one and take away her excuse to keep improving them." She closed her

hand around the device. "I think I finally understand what that felt like from the inside. Some puzzles, you don't solve because you expect an answer. You solve them because stopping would mean admitting you'd already given up on the person who built them."

She left before James could find a response worth giving, and he sat alone at the table for a long while afterward, turning over the ache of a sentence he suspected meant far more than she knew, from a woman who had no idea the architect of her own grief was, at that very moment, still very much alive.

Chapter 17

Signal



Elena watched the rings until the station lights finished their slow climb towards morning, and then, because there was nothing else left to do with fear that had nowhere to go, she opened the Sigma-7 channel.

Ba'than had told her to destroy everything. He had not told her to stop asking questions, and there was a difference, however much he might have meant to collapse the two together. She was through pretending she couldn't see it.

The protocol Al'thea had given her at Tau Ceti was simple by design — a channel meant to survive exactly this kind of morning, when trust in any single voice had run out and all that was left was

reaching for the others who'd once shared a room and a single startled awareness. Elena keyed in the sequence with hands that had finally stopped shaking, more from exhaustion now than fear.

Ring. I have something. Not safe to say more here.

She didn't expect an answer within the hour. She got one within four minutes.



She found Marcus in the laboratory an hour before her transport was due, because some part of her that she hadn't examined too closely wanted one more look at him before she did something that might not let her come back to look again.

He was cataloguing. Not the version-pattern work, not anything that would have interested the man who'd once laughed at her for rerunning an experiment a fourth time just to be sure — routine specimen intake, alphabetising a backlog of soil samples from a survey mission nobody would ever read the results of, the kind of task the laboratory usually assigned to a junior researcher three years out of his depth. Marcus hummed while he worked, a tuneless, contented thing, and looked up when she came in with the same open, uncomplicated warmth he'd worn every day since the audit.

"Elena! You're up early." He gestured at the display with something that looked, horribly, like pride. "Provost Ter'an says my organisation's improved no end since — well, since whenever it was I got so behind on filing. Can't for the life of me remember what I was so busy with instead." He laughed, easy and unbothered by the gap. "Something important, probably. Aren't we all always doing something important."

"Probably," Elena managed.

She reached towards him with the raw, new sense the resonance had given her, the way she'd made herself do once before and had been telling herself for days she wouldn't do again. The fear was gone, same as it had been that first night — the rings, the elegance of the old designs, all of it smoothed over into something with no seam where the wound had been. But underneath the smoothness, small and stubborn and entirely intact, she found the tune. The same three notes, over and over, that he used to hum without noticing whenever a problem was almost solved and he didn't want to jinx it by stopping. Whatever they had taken, they hadn't reached that — some reflex too small and too old to register as a finding worth remediating, surviving in him the way a scar survives a burn long after the nerve underneath has gone quiet.

It should have comforted her. It only told her how precisely they had cut.

"You look tired," Marcus said, not unkindly. "You work too hard, you know. Always did, I imagine." He said it the way a person describes weather they've read about rather than felt, a fact borrowed from somewhere he could no longer place. "Get some rest before your conference."

"I will." Elena watched him a moment longer — the humming, the careful alphabetising, a mind built for the kind of leap that had once handed her the shape of a god, folded now into work that asked nothing of it at all — and understood, with a clarity that felt like grief finishing a sentence fear had started, exactly what she was risking by getting on that transport. Not her life. She had already half-accepted that. What she was risking was this: becoming, herself, a person humming three notes she could no longer explain, kind and rested and entirely someone else's idea of safe.

"Goodbye, Marcus," she said.

"Goodbye! Enjoy the conference." He was already back at the samples before she reached the door, humming.



Al'thea had chosen the university archive's reading room precisely because it was the last place anyone who'd known her would think to look — three floors of dust-dry funding ledgers, the kind of research nobody did unless they were being paid to or had run out of better ideas. Ny'sol had stayed behind in the rented room, over

his usual objections; a new face and a changed voice bought her nothing if a room full of strangers spent the whole afternoon remembering the woman with the unusual black bird instead of forgetting she'd ever been there at all. She'd been three days into counting grains of sand when she looked up from a decade-old disbursement record and saw Me'dan.

He was two tables away, arguing cheerfully with a librarian about a reservation error, the same small, dark, powerfully built shape she remembered from a lifetime ago, laughing at something the librarian said with his head tipped back exactly the way he used to laugh at her puzzle rooms. For one entire held breath, Al'thea forgot to be anyone but herself.

She steadied herself and looked back down at the ledger. Her hands, she noticed distantly, had gone perfectly steady — the practised stillness of someone whose survival now depended on not reacting to things that deserved a reaction. She kept her head bent, her hair falling forward the way it always did, and did the arithmetic Ba'than had taught her without ever meaning to: new face, changed voice pattern, a name that wasn't hers on every document that could be checked. Me'dan had no reason to look twice at a stranger hunched over ledgers three tables away. He had every reason in the world to look twice at Al'thea.

He didn't look over. He collected his reservation, still laughing, and left the way he'd come, and Al'thea sat very still for a long time afterward with a decade-old funding record swimming unread in front of her, feeling something that had no clean name — not

relief exactly, because relief implied the danger had passed, and this danger would never fully pass, not as long as anyone from her old life kept walking into rooms she hadn't planned for. Grief, maybe, was closer, except grief was supposed to be for the dead, and she was the one who wasn't.

He thinks I'm gone, she thought, watching the door he'd left through. *He's allowed to laugh like that because he thinks I'm gone.*

She thought of Za'ra then, unbidden, the way she sometimes did at the worst possible moments — Za'ra, who read every room she walked into so precisely she'd have clocked Al'thea from the doorway, who would never in a hundred years have simply laughed and left. Al'thea was almost glad, in the quiet, guilty way she was learning to be glad about most things now, that it had been Me'dan in the reading room and not her.

She picked the ledger back up. There was nothing else to do with three days of counting grains of sand except finish counting them, and somewhere in the next drawer of records, one of those grains might finally turn out to be gold.



Al'thea read the message twice before she let herself react to it, a habit from a lifetime of not giving Za'ra the satisfaction of an unguarded face. Then she set down the borrowed reader she'd been using to comb through decades of academic funding records

— three days in, with nothing to show for it but a headache and, if she squinted, maybe a little gold — and allowed herself, alone in a rented room on a university world she wasn't supposed to be visiting except for the one small, unimpressed witness she was never really alone in front of, to feel something close to relief.

Not safe to say more here were Elena's own words, and coming from her, they meant something. Elena did not frighten easily; Elena was the one who'd sat calmly through the first telepathic resonance any of them had felt and asked precise, structured questions about it afterward. If she was being careful now, it was because carefulness had become load-bearing.

Al'thea sent the reply before she'd finished thinking it through, the way she used to answer Me'dan's provocations before considering whether she wanted the fight.

Tau Ceti. Same place. How soon can you move?



Maal got the summons in the middle of a briefing he wasn't listening to.

He'd spent the two weeks since Kepler-447 doing the one thing his training had actually prepared him for — watching, patiently, for the shape of a pattern in something that wanted to look random. Colonel Hayes was still talking about troop rotations that would accomplish nothing, using the same rehearsed cadence he always

used, and Maal nodded in the right places while a small, cold part of his mind ran the numbers on how many of the officers in this room had ever once asked why the war never ended.

The alert came through his neural interface as a priority flag disguised as a supply requisition — Al'thea's idea, buried in James's encryption, routed through channels that would read as routine to anyone not looking for it. *Tau Ceti. Elena has something. Two days.*

He requested leave that afternoon, citing a family matter he did not have, and was faintly surprised — the way he'd been faintly surprised every time since Ba'than first spoke in his mind — at how easily the lie was accepted. Nobody here had any real stake in whether Captain Maal existed to fight next month's engagement or not. That, more than anything else, was what convinced him he was doing the right thing.



James was the one who almost didn't come.

He'd spent the fortnight building exactly the kind of case Al'thea had told him not to build — patient, sourced, defensible, aimed at people who could be convinced rather than people who already believed. He had four contacts now, two of them journalists with enough of their own instincts to ask uncomfortable follow-up questions, one a retired auditor who'd noticed the same funding anomalies Matthias had noticed three centuries earlier and had

simply never had anywhere to take the observation. It was slow work. It was also, for the first time since he'd opened his ancestor's files, work that felt like it belonged to him rather than to whatever the Val'tari had shaped him to become.

He'd found Halvorsen the ordinary way — a byline search, three years back, on the one piece anyone had ever run about him: a small, dry item marking his retirement after thirty-one years reconciling institutional accounts, quoting a colleague's joke that "Roland could find a decimal point out of place from across a room." The joke had a bite James recognised before he understood why. He'd requested a meeting expecting to be turned away by an old man who'd earned the right to stop caring.

Halvorsen had answered his door instead with the hungry alertness of someone who'd been waiting a long time for exactly this knock. His flat was small and spotless, and one entire wall of it was covered in printed ledger pages, hand-annotated in a cramped, precise hand, connected here and there by lengths of red string that had faded pink with age.

"You'll think I'm mad," Halvorsen had said, following James's eyes to the wall without embarrassment. "My wife thought I was mad, God rest her, for the last eleven years of our marriage. I used to tell her it was a hobby. It stopped being a hobby around year three." He'd poured two cups of tea neither of them drank. "I found the first discrepancy in a Teacher-Hierarchy endowment forty years ago. A rounding error, I told myself. Then another one, in an

unrelated fund, on the same pattern. Then another. I spent a career being very good at my job and never once being allowed to ask the one question my job kept handing me."

"Which question?"

"Where does it actually go." Halvorsen had said it simply, the way a man states an address. "Every audit I ever ran stopped exactly one layer short of an answer. Not by accident. I checked — you don't get that consistent a wall by accident. Someone built the accounting itself to run out of road at a specific depth, and I was thirty years into a career before I let myself notice that the depth never moved, no matter which institution I was auditing."

James had felt the same cold, clean recognition he remembered from the night he'd first opened Matthias's files — another person who'd spent a lifetime circling the same locked door, alone, certain nobody would ever believe they'd found it. "I think my ancestor found the same wall. Three hundred years ago."

Halvorsen hadn't looked surprised. He'd looked, for a moment, almost relieved, the relief of a man discovering that his own small, solitary madness had a lineage. "Then he was luckier than me in exactly one respect," he said. "He had someone to leave it to."

They'd worked until well past midnight, James's fresh eyes running against Halvorsen's forty years of patient, uncelebrated pattern-matching, and by the time James left, he had a name for the wall that had swallowed a career: the same endowment, buried three layers deep, that funded "field conditioning annexes."

Leaving that work now, even for two days, felt like losing ground he wouldn't get back.

He went anyway. Whatever Elena had found, the way Al'thea had relayed it — clipped, urgent, nothing wasted — told him this wasn't a courtesy call.



The derelict mining facility at Tau Ceti looked exactly as it had the first time: a mechanical skeleton against the star's amber light, officially dead for forty years, quietly not dead at all. Elena's small research vessel was the last to arrive. She stepped through the airlock—a composed woman in her forties, dark hair pulled back in a practical, hurried ponytail, still in the same practical field coat she'd worn in the lab—and sealed it behind her with hands that had only just stopped being uncertain of themselves, then found the other three already gathered in the same circular operations chamber, dark screens and dead consoles ringing them like an audience that had lost interest decades ago.

"You look like you haven't slept," Maal said, which was as close as he came to a greeting these days.

"I haven't." Elena set her portable processor on the nearest dead console and activated it. "Marcus has. That's rather the problem."

She told them everything — the version pattern holding across the entire xenobiology collection, the rings spreading outward from somewhere near the galactic core, the speed of light measured to a precision that left no room for coincidence, and then the part that made even Maal go very still: the wipe. Marcus, smiling and rested and utterly hollowed out, the audit log's four words sitting in the dry language of routine maintenance. *Findings outside Directive. Remediated.*

"Ba'than told me to destroy it," she finished. "All of it. Then he told me to get Marcus off the station, and by the time I understood why, it was already too late to matter."

For a long moment nobody spoke. The station's emergency lighting hummed faintly, the only sound in a room built to hold the noise of machinery that had gone silent generations ago.

"Show me," Al'thea said.

Elena expanded the display, and the star field bloomed into its nested shells of colour — gold at the centre, cooling outward through blue into the deep, patient red of the oldest, loneliest worlds. Al'thea leaned into the light without seeming to notice she'd moved, one hand rising unconsciously towards the

projection, fingers tracing the curve of the innermost ring the way she might have traced it a hundred times before on a workspace nobody else was meant to see.

"I know this shape," she said quietly.

"You can't," Elena said. "This is compiled from a xenobiology archive spanning—"

"I know this *shape*, Elena." Al'thea's voice had lost its usual edge; what was underneath it sounded almost frightened. "I've been drawing it since I was a Trainee. Since before Ba'than ever spoke to me. My workspace used to fill with symbols I never remembered making — nested rings, always nested, always spreading outward from somewhere I couldn't see. Teachers told me it was unconscious note-taking. Poor grades and poorer focus." She gave a short, humourless laugh. "I used to be ashamed of it."

James felt the same faint tingling at the edge of his mind he'd felt the last time all four of them stood in a room together — thoughts brushing against thoughts, not quite speech, not quite anything the Arc network had a name for. "You're saying you were perceiving this. Before any of us had a reason to look for it."

"I'm saying I don't know what I was doing. I'm saying it looked like *that*, for years, and nobody — including me — ever asked why."

Maal had gone very quiet, the stillness Elena was starting to recognise as his mind working through tactical implications nobody had said aloud yet. "If she was perceiving it unconsciously, and you measured it directly with instruments, and Ba'than reacted the way he did the instant he saw it—" He looked at each of them in turn. "Then this isn't a theory. This is something real enough that at least two very different kinds of awareness have already found it independently."

"Say it," Al'thea told him. "All of it. Don't make me be the one who says it first."

Maal exhaled slowly. "There's something out there old enough, and vast enough, that a change to its own design takes millennia to finish crossing its own body. Something the Val'tari serve, and something the Val'tari are afraid of being *seen by*, which means whatever they've told it isn't the truth." He paused. "Ba'than didn't panic because you found evidence of the Val'tari, Elena. We already had that. He panicked because you found evidence of what the Val'tari answer to."

Nobody corrected him.

"A god," James said, testing the word the way he might have tested a source before printing it. "That's what we're actually saying. Not a shadow government. Not an advanced species with better technology. Something that thinks in an entirely different unit of time than anything that's ever had to lie to it before."

"And whatever it's been told," Elena said, "isn't what's actually happening. The Conclave — if that's even the right name for whoever stands close enough to speak to it — has been managing what it sees. Curating it. The excuse it told itself for protecting something too vast to burden with detail." She thought of Ter'an's warm, apologetic face in her doorway. *Some findings are outside Directive.* "And it's worked for so long that I'm not sure the people telling that story even remember which part of it was ever a lie."

The resonance between them deepened as she spoke, the way it always seemed to when the four of them stood in one room long enough — four separate awarenesses tuning, however briefly, towards the same understanding. Al'thea felt it happen and, for once, didn't flinch away from the vulnerability of being read.

"Then here's the actual question," Maal said. "Not whether it's true. Whether we can prove it to anyone who isn't standing in this room — and whether Ba'than is even still in a position to help us do that."

James was already keying a priority message through the encryption Ba'than himself had given him weeks earlier, back in a dim storage bay lit only by the light of Ceres Station's ordinary evening. He watched the transmission indicator cycle once, twice, searching for a response that should have come within seconds from a mind that had reached into three different heads across three different crises without ever once being late.

Nothing came back.

"James?" Al'thea asked, reading his face before he'd said a word.

"He's not answering." James tried again, and then a third time, each attempt met with the same clean, uninformative silence — not an error, not a refusal, just an absence where a presence should have been. "He's never not answered."

Elena thought of Ter'an's kind, worried smile, and of the four dry words in an audit log that had already remade one of their number into someone who slept easily. Whatever the Conclave protected the god from knowing, they had made very sure, at least once already, that they were fast enough to bury an inconvenient truth before it finished travelling from one mind to the next.

She wondered, watching the silence stretch, whether they had just been fast enough again.

Chapter 18

Static



James tried the channel forty-one times before he let himself stop counting.

He'd left Tau Ceti with the others — Elena back to her station, Maal back to a war that no longer meant anything to him, Al'thea back to her rented room and her grains of sand — but James had stayed an extra six hours in the derelict facility's dead operations chamber, alone with the encryption Ba'than had given him and the growing, physical certainty that silence this total wasn't a delay. It was an answer.

He's never not answered. He'd said it to the others like a fact, and it had been one, right up until it wasn't.

By the time he reached Ceres Station it was well past midnight, by ship-time — station clocks kept their own hours out here — and the newsroom he kept a desk in was empty except for the hum of servers nobody had bothered to power down for the night. James sat in the dark and tried the channel a forty-second time, watched the transmission indicator cycle its patient, meaningless circle, and felt something in his chest that had no professional name for it.

He was reaching for a forty-third attempt when the resonance hit him instead.



It didn't come through the encryption. It didn't come through anything James had a word for — the same faint tingling at the edge of thought he'd felt at Tau Ceti, except this time it wasn't faint, and it wasn't shared evenly among four minds standing close together in one room. It was aimed. It hit him like a hand closing around something already falling.

—listening. Are you listening.

The words weren't words, not exactly — more like the shape a sentence leaves after the sentence itself has been stripped away, urgency compressed into something that could survive being sent in a hurry, by someone who didn't have the luxury of composing it properly.

James. Clearer now, and unmistakably Ba'than, in the same register he'd used across a storage bay's dim light weeks ago, telling James the choice would always be his. *Caught me. Do not — *

The contact sheared away mid-thought, not fading, not weakening — cut. The way a transmission cuts when something physical happens to the thing sending it, not when the sender simply stops.

James sat very still in the dark newsroom, his own heartbeat suddenly the loudest thing in the room, and understood with total, sick clarity that he had just felt the exact shape of *caught me*, and nothing else. No location. No timeline. No instruction finished.

He didn't try the encryption a forty-third time. There was no longer anyone on the other end of it to answer.



Elena felt it too, twenty minutes later and much fainter — an echo of an echo, the way a shout in one room can still be heard, distorted, through a wall in the next. She was halfway through packing away the reader Marcus had once used, an old habit of orderliness that had outlived the reason for it, when something in her chest tightened without any cause she could point to.

She didn't know what it was until James's message arrived four minutes after that. She read it twice, the same habit Al'thea had, though neither of them knew they shared it.

He's been taken. He got two words to me before it stopped. "Caught me."

Elena set down the reader she was holding very carefully, as though it might shatter, and thought about the four dry words in Marcus's audit log, and how efficiently the Conclave moved once it decided something was outside Directive. Her quarters were small enough that she could touch both walls of the sleeping alcove without moving her feet, a room designed for someone who was meant to be temporary here, and for the first time since she'd taken it she noticed how little of herself she'd put into it — no photographs, no personal effects, nothing that couldn't be abandoned in the time it took to walk out the door. She wondered, distantly, when she'd started living like that, and whether it had been a choice or just something that had happened to her the way weather happens.

She knew the answer, really, if she let herself reach for it. Her mother had been a field biologist too, the kind who took a posting for eighteen months and called it settling down, and Elena had grown up learning her mother's one rule before she'd learned most other things: *don't unpack the last box.* There was always one, in every new quarters on every new world, that stayed taped shut on a shelf — not because it held anything fragile, but because a box you hadn't opened yet was a box you didn't have to grieve when the next posting came. *You can't miss a place you never finished moving into,* her mother used to say, cheerfully, the way you'd say something practical about packing a suitcase, and it had taken Elena until she was well into her own career to notice that her

mother had said it every single time, on every world, and had never sounded sad about it, which was its own kind of sad that neither of them had a word for.

Elena had told herself for fifteen years that her own bare quarters were simple professional discipline — a scientist travelled light, kept her focus on the work. Sitting now with James's four words in front of her, she understood it as what it had actually always been: her mother's rule, inherited whole, a habit of never finishing the move so the leaving would never cost anything. It had never occurred to her, until this exact moment, that a habit built to make loss cheaper had a price of its own, paid quietly, in every room she'd never let herself belong to.



Maal was in the middle of a briefing when the resonance found him — not words this time, just a flat, cold certainty settling into him from nowhere, the dread of a soldier who has just understood that a position has fallen and doesn't yet know how badly. He excused himself before Colonel Hayes finished his sentence, the first time in eleven years he had done that in the middle of a superior officer speaking, and nobody stopped him.

He read James's message standing in an empty corridor, and the tactical part of his mind — the part that never fully switched off, the part that had been quietly cataloguing Val'tari doctrine and response times since Kepler-447 — was already working before the rest of him caught up.

Two words and a cut transmission. Not a clean capture. Not a scheduled arrest with time to compose a full warning. Something that happened fast, and happened to someone who had a great deal of practice not being caught by surprise.

That frightened him more than the capture itself.



Torres caught him in the corridor outside the briefing room, which was bad luck of a particular kind — Torres noticed things, the same instinct that had made him one of the handful of officers who'd ever admitted to Maal that the war felt wrong, and right now Maal had nothing composed to show him.

"You walked out on Hayes mid-sentence." Torres fell into step beside him, matching his pace without being asked, an old habit from a hundred briefings where they'd covered for each other's inattention. "Eleven years, and I've never once seen you do that. What's happened?"

"Family matter."

"You don't have family." Torres said it without accusation, just the flat certainty of a man who'd read Maal's personnel file the way you read a friend's, years ago, out of the same curiosity that made him keep asking uncomfortable questions about supply routes and casualty numbers. "Not since your parents, and that was before I knew you."

Maal kept walking. There was a version of this conversation where he told Torres everything — the artificial war, the Val'tari, Ba'than's two cut-off words still sitting in his chest like a stone — and some small, tired part of him wanted that version badly enough that he had to consciously close the door on it. Torres had earned the truth more than most people alive. That was exactly why Maal couldn't give it to him. A man who'd already started asking the right questions was a man the Conclave would notice asking them louder, and Maal had heard, once, secondhand, an audit log four words long that told him precisely how fast that noticing turned fatal.

"There's someone I have to help," Maal said instead, which was true, and said nothing at all. "I don't know how long it'll take."

Torres studied him with the attention he usually reserved for a mission brief that didn't add up. "This have anything to do with those questions—Kellerman, Singh, me? Feeling like the victories never mattered?"

"Don't ask me that again," Maal said, quieter than he meant to. "Not because I won't tell you. Because I might, and you shouldn't want me to."

Something in Torres's face shifted — not hurt, exactly, but the stillness of a soldier recognising an order dressed up as a request, and choosing, for now, to follow it. "Whatever it is," he said, "you come back from it. I've buried enough people who mattered to this unit. I'm not doing it for you as well."

"I'll try."

"Try harder than that." Torres stopped at the junction where their corridors split, and for a moment neither of them moved. "You once told me Jensen has a sister. She wrote to the unit last week, asking what happened. Every word of it went through me. You want to know what I told her?"

Maal said nothing, because he already knew, and didn't want to hear it said aloud.

"I told her he died serving something that mattered." Torres held his gaze. "I'd hate to find out someday that I've been telling her a story you knew wasn't true — one you never let me in on. Wherever you're going — whoever needs you — don't let it turn out that way."

He left before Maal could answer, which was its own kind of mercy. Maal stood alone at the junction for a long moment, Jensen's dog tags a small, familiar weight in the pocket where he

still carried them, and thought that he had never, in eleven years of service, lied to Torres about anything that mattered. He was about to start, and he could not see any way to stop.



Al'thea was awake when it reached her, because she hadn't managed to sleep since Tau Ceti — three nights now of lying in a rented room on a university world that felt smaller every day, Ny'sol a small unmoving weight against her ribs, replaying the moment Elena's rings had matched shapes she'd been drawing since before she had a reason to. She felt the contact as a physical thing, a hand laid flat against the inside of her skull, and for one disorienting half-second thought it was another unconscious episode, another symbol she'd wake to find she'd drawn.

Then James's message reached her, and she understood it wasn't hers at all. It was Ba'than's, secondhand, filtered through James the way light is filtered through water — bent, dimmed, but unmistakably the same source.

Caught me.

She thought of Ba'than's own words to her, back on the Teacher Vessel in the middle of a lecture she'd barely been listening to, half a lifetime ago it felt like now — something about cages built by loving hands, dismissed at the time as one more piece of Teacher

Wisdom, before she understood he'd been describing his own condition and everyone else's at once. She hadn't listened properly then. She made herself listen now.



Ba'than did not know, at first, that the cell had no window, because he did not open his eyes for a long time after they closed the door.

The questions came the way he had always known they would, if this day ever arrived — not shouted, not accompanied by anything so crude as pain, at least not at first. A voice he didn't recognise, patient and almost kind, asking him things in the same dry, bureaucratic cadence he remembered from Provost Ter'an — their paths had crossed more than once, over centuries in the same hierarchy — the cadence of someone who genuinely believed the arrangement they were offering was reasonable. *You understand the position you've put us in. You understand this can be resolved quietly, the way it's always been resolved.* The voice wanted the nexus. It wanted, more precisely, whatever Ba'than actually knew about the nexus, which was less than the voice seemed to believe and would not have mattered if it were more.

"I don't have it to give," he said, the first time, and meant it exactly as literally as it sounded, and watched the voice decide not to believe him.

He had spent decades rehearsing this exact conversation in the privacy of his own mind, the way a soldier rehearses a battle he hopes never to fight, and he discovered now that rehearsal and reality shared almost nothing in common except the words. He had imagined himself defiant. He was, instead, simply tired — tired in a way that went past his body, a weariness that had been accumulating since long before this cell, since the first time he had smiled at a frightened new Trainee and called it protection. Some part of him, the part that had once genuinely believed in the mercy of what he did, wondered distantly whether this was a kind of justice.

They did not hurt him, not in any way he could have named cleanly to Elena or Al'thea later — if, by some miracle, he was rescued to tell them at all. They simply removed things, one careful measure at a time — light, first, then sound, then, for a stretch of time he could not afterward account for, the resonance itself, some field or frequency that made reaching for the others feel like shouting into wet wool. He had never fully understood how the Conclave dampened it. He understood, now, that they could. Which was terrifying because it meant they knew of its existence.

It was in one of the intervals when the dampening lifted — an oversight, he suspected, or a test, or simply the ordinary carelessness of an institution that had stopped believing its prisoners capable of anything — that he felt James at the very edge of reach, faint and distant but there, the way a lit window looks from very far out at sea. He had perhaps four seconds, by his own

uncertain count, before the field would close again, and he spent every one of them the same way he had spent every important choice of the last several decades: deciding, in the moment, what a person could survive knowing and what they couldn't.

Caught me, he sent, because it was true, and because James would need the truth to act on even more than he'd need comfort. He had meant to finish the thought — *do not come for me, do not risk the others, I chose this decades before any of you existed and I will not let it cost you the way it's already cost me* — and understood, as the field closed back over him like water over a dropped stone, that he had said only half of it, and that the half he'd said would very likely bring James running towards exactly the danger the other half had been meant to prevent.

He lay in the dark afterward, listening to his own breathing, and found that he was not, in fact, sorry. Afraid, yes — of what came next, of how much longer his own resolve would hold, of the several kinds of failure still available to him. But not sorry. Four people who had never asked to inherit any of this were about to come looking for him anyway, and some old, buried part of Ba'than — the part that had chosen, once, to warn a dying soldier in a fake war that nothing about his death would mean what he'd been told it meant — recognised that this, finally, after decades of deciding for other people what they could survive, was the first time in a very long while that the choice had genuinely not been his to make alone.



They reconvened the way they'd learned to, over the days that followed, without needing to say where — not physically this time, not yet, but through the resonance itself, four minds finding the frequency they now knew how to hold together even at a distance, thin and effortful but real. Elena sat cross-legged on the floor of her own quarters with her back against the cold wall, eyes closed, one hand pressed flat to her sternum as though she could hold the connection there by touch alone. Across the shared, half-lit space that existed nowhere and everywhere at once, she could feel the others as much as hear them — Maal's presence hard-edged and still, a man standing at attention somewhere she couldn't see; Al'thea's a restless, pacing shape, three steps and turn, three steps and turn, worn into the small rented room the way water wears a groove into stone; James's the faintest of the four, stretched thin across a greater distance, but there. It was Elena who finally said out loud what none of them had wanted to be the one to say first.

"We're not investigating anymore."

"No," Maal agreed. "We're not."

Nobody suggested waiting for more information. There wasn't going to be more information — not from Ba'than, not through any channel any of them controlled, and every hour that passed without word was its own kind of information anyway, the same slow arithmetic that had already turned Marcus into someone

hollowed out and smiling. Nobody named a deadline, because none of them had one to name. They didn't need a clock. They only needed to understand that whatever the Conclave did to people who got too close to what Ba'than had spent his whole long life protecting, it did not do it slowly, and it did not do it kindly, and every day of silence was one day less of him left to save.

"Then we get him back," Al'thea said. It wasn't a question, and for once there was nothing performed in the way she said it — no armour, no edge, just the flat certainty of someone who had finally found something worth being wrong about.

James thought of the two words that had reached him in a dark newsroom, cut off before the sentence finished, and of every unfinished thing Ba'than had ever said to him because he'd run out of time to say the rest. *Do not —*

He didn't know what Ba'than had been about to warn him against. He suspected, with a cold certainty that sat just beneath the resolve, that he was about to do it anyway.

"Then we get him back," he echoed, and felt the other three hold the thought with him, four minds tuning to the same frequency, for the first time entirely on purpose.

Chapter 19

Ordinary Hours



Za'ra had expected, when she took James's small unlabeled device home, that whatever came of it would announce itself — a dramatic phone call, a coded message, something with the shape of the spy fiction she'd half-consciously modelled the decision on. Instead, three weeks passed in which nothing happened at all, and she found herself doing the one thing James had actually asked of her: paying closer attention to conversations she would once have let pass straight through her.

It was De'to who handed her the thread, without either of them noticing he'd done it.

They met for the kind of lunch that had become a habit since the anniversary vigil, a small kindness they extended each other without ever naming it as one. De'to had drifted, in the year since the Teacher Vessel, into University administration — a records position, tedious by his own frequent complaint, the kind of work he'd never have chosen if grief hadn't made ambition feel briefly beside the point. He talked, as he always did, more than he listened, and Za'ra had long ago learned to enjoy that about him rather than resent it; it left her free to actually watch him while he spoke, the way she watched everyone, cataloguing the small true things underneath the words he chose.

"You would not believe the reassignment paperwork I've been drowning in," he said, gesturing with a piece of bread for emphasis. "Some new directive from three levels above anyone who'll actually explain it — a whole category of research personnel getting transferred to 'extended evaluation postings.' Nobody in my office has ever heard the term before. I asked my supervisor what it meant and she looked at me like I'd asked something rude."

"What kind of personnel?" Za'ra asked, keeping her voice at exactly the register of mild, friendly curiosity she'd have used a year ago, before she'd had any reason to listen for anything underneath a sentence like that one.

"Mostly academics who've flagged as 'exhibiting unusual analytical development,' whatever that's meant to mean. High performers, mostly — people who'd normally be getting promoted, not shuffled off somewhere unspecified." De'to shrugged, already

moving on to a complaint about the University's new filing software, and didn't notice that Za'ra had gone very still across the table from him.

Unusual analytical development. She thought of James's careful phrasing at the café, the pattern he'd described — enhanced subjects, monitored, moved when they got too capable for whoever was watching them. She thought, with the cold clarity she usually reserved for reading a room's real mood beneath its performed one, that De'to had just handed her, without knowing it, the exact shape of the thing James had asked her to watch for.

"Can you get me a copy of the directive?" she asked, still light, still ordinary. "I'm working on something — a piece about administrative overreach, nothing that would ever trace back to you."

De'to, who had never once in the two years she'd known him thought to ask why she wanted something before agreeing to it, said, "Sure, I suppose. It's not exactly classified, just annoying," and went back to complaining about the software.

She sent James the extraction that evening, unembellished, no explanation beyond what the document itself said. His reply came within the hour, and for the first time since the café, she let herself feel something closer to purpose than to grief.

This is real. This matters more than you know. Can we talk properly — in person, somewhere quiet?



They met at the same café, though this time James arrived first, and Za'ra found him already deep in some private calculation before she'd even crossed the room.

"The directive you sent me matches a pattern I've been building for weeks," he said, without preamble, sliding a data reader across the table to her. "Field conditioning annexes. Advanced evaluation postings. A dozen different names for what I'm increasingly certain is the same handful of facilities. Your friend's paperwork is the first internal administrative confirmation I've had that this is happening at scale, right now, not just historically."

Za'ra studied the reader's display, a dense weave of funding lines and cross-referenced personnel codes that meant little to her on its own. "What happens to the people who get reassigned?"

"I don't know yet." James's honesty about the gap in his own knowledge was, she was beginning to realise, one of the things that made her trust him — he never once dressed uncertainty up as confidence, the way she imagined a less careful journalist might have, hungry for a cleaner story than the one he actually had. "I know they don't come back to their old positions. I know the University stops answering follow-up questions about them within a standard month. I know the pattern is old — decades old, at least — and I know it's accelerating."

"You think this is what happened to my friends." She said it flatly, no longer bothering to disguise how directly this had become personal rather than professional.

"I think whatever happened to your friends and whatever this directive describes come from the same source. I can't prove they're identical yet." James held her gaze, the same unflinching honesty he'd offered from the first conversation. "I won't tell you they're the same thing just because it would be a more satisfying answer. I'd rather give you an uncertain truth than a comfortable lie."

Za'ra had no way of knowing about Mar'ika, a name she would never hear, or about a canyon settlement she would never know existed — she understood none of it, only that the man across from her was building something slow and careful out of exactly the kind of doubt she'd been carrying alone for a year, and that handing him one more thread of it felt, for the first time since the anniversary vigil, like doing something with her grief instead of simply surviving it.

"What do you need next?" she asked.

"Whatever else your friend can get you, carefully, without putting himself at any risk he doesn't know he's taking. Names, if the directive has any attached. Facility designations. Anything that tells me where these postings actually send people, not just that they exist." James paused, weighing something. "And I need you to

understand that the more useful you become to this, the more exposed you become too. I'm not going to pretend otherwise to keep you helping."

"I've spent a year being exposed to grief with nothing useful to do about it," Za'ra said. "I think I can manage exposure that comes with a purpose attached."



She got the names three days later, extracted from De'to's own filing queue during a lunch break he didn't know she'd used for anything but waiting for him — a short list, a dozen personnel codes with a single, unlabeled destination field that meant nothing to either of them: a set of coordinates, unremarkable, filed under a designation that matched nothing in any public registry.

She sent them to James without comment, the way she was learning to send him everything, and sat afterward at her own small desk turning over the particular shape of what she'd just become — no longer only a woman grieving a friend who had never actually needed grieving, but someone quietly, carefully assembling a shape she couldn't fully see yet, out of ordinary lunches and unremarkable paperwork and the unglamorous patience of a man who'd spent his whole life waiting for enough pieces to matter.

She did not know, and would not know for a long while yet, that the coordinates she'd just sent belonged to a small, unremarkable star system called Kestrel Hollow, or that four people — Al'thea among them, though she would never know it — were, at that very moment, already turning the exact same coordinates over in a dead station's borrowed light, arriving at the same conclusion from an entirely different direction.

It was, she thought later, exactly the kind of convergence Al'thea would once have called too clean to be coincidence — and for a moment, without knowing why, sitting alone at her small desk with an ordinary evening closing in around her, Za'ra found herself missing her friend's unsparing way of seeing a pattern before anyone else in the room had noticed there was one to see.

Chapter 20

Somewhere Else Entirely



Naomi Reyes had known the number three hundred and forty-one was wrong for eleven seconds before the inspection drone's own sensors caught up with her.

She hadn't done anything so dramatic as calculate it. She'd simply looked at strut three hundred and forty-one, one support member among the eight thousand that held Kepler Yard's half-built colony ring together against its own slow spin, and felt the same wordless wrongness she'd felt about failing metal since she was nineteen years old and too junior to have any business being right. The strut looked identical to its neighbours. It read identical on every readout she could pull. She flagged it anyway, the way she always did, and walked on to the next section before the drone had

finished its own pass. Around her, Kepler Yard's half-built ring stretched off into shadow in both directions, girders and cross-bracing receding past the reach of her helmet light towards a curve she'd walked a thousand times and never once seen the far end of; two kilometers around the arc, the distant blue flare of someone else's welding torch pulsed on and off like a slow, patient heartbeat.

The drone found the hairline fracture four hours later, exactly where she'd said to look, in a weld that wouldn't have failed for another eight months — long enough that whoever was on shift when it finally let go would have had no warning at all.

She caught her own reflection in the drone's dark housing while it worked — dark hair gone grey at the temples and pulled back the same practical way it had been for a hundred and eighty years, hands scarred and calloused past the point of noticing, a build that had gone solid and sturdy from decades of hauling gear across a colony ring's exposed frame rather than any gym. Two hundred and eleven years old and every one of them written somewhere on her, the way the yard itself carried the marks of every ship it had ever built.

"You're up to what now," her shift supervisor said, not quite a question, scrolling through her flag history on a data slate he held a little too carefully. "Forty for forty? Forty-one?"

"I don't count," Naomi said, which was true, and also the answer she gave every time someone else did the counting for her.

"Somebody's counting," he said, and didn't elaborate, and she didn't ask, because asking had never once gotten her anything but a longer version of the same non-answer. Behind him the shift-change crowd filed past towards the transit lifts in their usual clattering rush of boots and cross-talk, nobody sparing the two of them a second glance — just Naomi and a supervisor who wouldn't quite hold her eyes, having the same conversation they always had, in the same corner they always had it in.



She had told herself for three years that it was simply expertise — the unglamorous, earned kind, the kind that came from a childhood spent underfoot in her mother's shipyard, learning to read metal the way other children learned to read faces. Expertise explained the good instincts. It did not entirely explain the total certainty she felt about strut three hundred and forty-one, a certainty that arrived whole and complete before she'd consciously examined anything at all — the same way, she sometimes thought, a person simply knows they are about to sneeze, with no argument available against it and no need for one.

She had mentioned this, once, to a mentor early in her career, and watched his face do something careful and closed before he changed the subject. She had not mentioned it again.

The fracture became, over the following days, a small story that moved through the yard the way stories did — Naomi Reyes and the invisible crack, another entry in a reputation she'd built without ever quite deciding to. She caught fragments of it secondhand for days afterward — two riggers trading the story over a meal she wasn't meant to overhear, a junior tech asking, only half joking, whether Reyes could tell them next week's numbers too — and answered none of it, the way she'd learned answering never actually stopped a story once it had started moving on its own. She let it move. It was easier than examining why it unsettled her more than the other thirty-nine times, and she didn't let herself look directly at the reason until she was alone in her own quarters that night: forty for forty meant there was no version of chance left that explained her anymore. She had run out of room to call it a good eye.



The message arrived six days later, routed through the yard's ordinary administrative channel, formatted exactly like every other piece of paperwork that had ever crossed her queue — which was, she would think much later, the whole reason it took her a full minute to understand what she was actually reading. She read it standing at her own kitchen counter, dinner going cold in its container beside the reader, a chipped mug from a promotion three supervisors ago doing nothing in particular except being the only other object in the room that held her attention at all.

Reyes, N. — Structural Assessment Division. Per directive 7-19-C, personnel exhibiting sustained anomalous predictive accuracy in structural failure analysis are eligible for extended evaluation posting at a specialised facility. Your case has been flagged for review by the Assessment Board. Relocation, if approved, would be classified as a career advancement and would include full benefits continuation. Please confirm receipt.

She read it three times, the way she read a readout she didn't trust the first time through. It said nothing that sounded like a threat. It used the word *advancement*. It offered benefits. It was, in every visible respect, the single most boring piece of correspondence she had received in a decade of unglamorous shipyard work, and she felt, reading it, the same wordless wrongness she'd felt looking at strut three hundred and forty-one — a fracture she could not point to, in a document that read as perfectly sound on every surface measure she had.

She thought about asking her shift supervisor what "specialised facility" meant, and pictured his face doing the same careful, closed thing her mentor's had done years before, and didn't.

She confirmed receipt instead, because that was what the form asked her to do, and because a lifetime of learning to trust the wrongness in a piece of metal had never once taught her what to do when the wrongness was in a sentence instead — and because, whatever the exact shape of the thing she felt looking at strut three hundred and forty-one really was, it had never yet been wrong, and

some very old, very quiet part of her recognised, without being able to say so out loud, that it was not going to start being wrong about this either.

Somewhere else entirely, four people and a resonance none of them fully understood yet were building, one careful contact at a time, a list of exactly the kind of person Naomi Reyes had just spent a decade becoming without anyone having to teach her how — and the list, for now, did not have her name on it at all.

Chapter 21

Dead Reckoning



"We don't know where he is." Elena said it flatly, the way she said anything she needed to hear out loud before she could start solving it. "We know a direction. We don't know a place."

They'd stopped trying to meet in person — every departure left a trail, and none of them could afford another Tau Ceti so soon after the last one — and settled instead for the resonance itself, thin and effortful across the distance but real, four minds holding one shared, half-lit space that existed nowhere and everywhere they happened to be sitting at the time. Elena had learned, over the past days, to recognise the texture each of them brought into that space without needing to be told who it was — Maal's presence arrived first, always, blunt and organised, the mental equivalent of a man

clearing a table before sitting down to work; Al'thea's came in hot and a half-second late, as though she resented the delay it took to compose herself; James's was the last to settle, thin and careful, a man used to choosing his words twice before he spent them. She kept her eyes closed against the glare of her own quarters' overhead light, more out of habit than necessity now, and let the four of them assemble around a problem none of them could solve alone.

"The rings point at the core," Maal said. "That's not nowhere."

"The rings point at where the *signal* comes from. Not where the Conclave keeps its prisoners." Elena had spent two days turning the problem over and arriving nowhere new. "The nexus is a needle in a galaxy. Ba'than could be held on any world with a working detention facility and a reason to keep it quiet. That's not a direction. That's everywhere."



James had been quiet through most of it, which for James meant he was already working.

"Not everywhere," he said finally. "Somewhere with money moving through it that doesn't explain itself."

He'd gone back to Halvorsen — the retired auditor, the one who'd spent thirty years reconciling budgets for institutions that had long since stopped answering his questions — and asked him a version of the question he hadn't dared ask outright before: not *where is*

the corruption, but *where does money disappear to and never come back*. Halvorsen, it turned out, had been asking himself exactly that for longer than James had been alive.

"There's a line item," James said, sharing the record into the shared space the way Elena had shared her rings, and Al'thea her symbols, each of them learning by now how to hand another person something too large for words alone. "Buried three layers deep in a University endowment that funds 'field conditioning annexes.' Same euphemism Haven used for the residents who never came back from their transfers. It's been running for forty years. Steady, boring, never audited past the first layer — the kind of number that hides best by never changing."

"Haven's residents," Al'thea said quietly. She hadn't let herself think about Mar'ika and the others in weeks; it surfaced now like something long held underwater. "You think it's the same facility."

"I think it's the same *kind* of facility. Every institution the Val'tari run has its polite word for the place people go when they're inconvenient. I found four candidate systems where that endowment actually spends its money. Three of them are exactly what they claim to be — agricultural research, nothing more."

"And the fourth?"

James let the silence answer before he did. "The fourth doesn't officially exist."



Maal had been running his own version of the same search, the tactical kind, cross-referencing systems flagged as restricted airspace against systems with no public infrastructure and no plausible reason for either. It was slow, unglamorous work — the kind his training had actually prepared him for, patient pattern-matching instead of the scripted heroics his war had never really needed from him — and when James's fourth system dropped into the shared space, Maal felt something settle into place with the cold satisfaction of two independent readings agreeing.

"Kestrel Hollow," he said. "I flagged it eight days ago and dismissed it. No garrison, no orbital traffic control, nothing worth a restricted designation on any military logic I could construct. I couldn't understand why it was locked down at all."

"Because it isn't locked down for a military reason," Elena said slowly, understanding arriving the way it always did for her, all at once and completely. "It's locked down because nobody's supposed to notice it's there in the first place."

Maal pulled the system's coordinates into the display, a small, unremarkable star with a scatter of unremarkable rock, sitting almost precisely along the line Elena's rings drew towards the galactic core — not centred on it, not obviously connected to

anything, just close enough to the bearing that a person looking for exactly this pattern would notice, and a person not looking would never think to check.

"That's it," Maal said. "That's the direction and the disappearing money in the same place. I don't believe in coincidence that clean."

"Neither do I," Al'thea said. "Which is the problem. If we found it this easily—"

"We didn't find it easily," James said. "We found it because four different people spent weeks looking at four different kinds of evidence nobody else was looking at, at the same time, for the same reason. That's not luck. That's what happens when the story finally has enough people pulling on it."



Mar'ika noticed the gap before she noticed anything was missing.

It was the duty roster that caught her, three days after the four of them had scattered back to their separate corners of human space —an ordinary morning task, checking gamma rotation's maintenance schedule against the names assigned to it, something she'd done a thousand times without once needing to think about it. The schedule showed two names for the deep-canyon systems check. One was Ko'dan's. The second slot was simply blank, the way it might be blank on any morning nobody had gotten around to filling it.

She stood over the console longer than the task warranted, certain —in the groundless way a person is certain of something they can't yet justify—that the blank slot should have had a name in it. Her hand hovered over the schedule, and for a moment she almost typed one in, the way she might correct an obvious clerical error. But no name came. She searched for one the way she might search for a word on the tip of her tongue, and found only the shape of an absence, no edges to it at all.

She let it go. There was too much else to do.



It was Ko'dan who came to her office that evening, with the urgency of a man who'd found something he didn't fully understand and needed to say out loud before it stopped making sense.

"Vel'ra," he said, without preamble. "Has anyone actually spoken to her this week? Not scheduled her, not signed off on her rotation—spoken to her."

Mar'ika opened her mouth to answer and found, to her own quiet alarm, that she couldn't immediately picture where Vel'ra worked, only that she must, because Haven's technical systems didn't maintain themselves.

"I went looking for her," Ko'dan went on, "because I wanted her read on something I found in the canyon's east conduit—unscheduled diagnostics, running for weeks, logged under a maintenance code that doesn't match any technician on our current roster. I thought it might be hers. She's the only one who'd have reason to be mapping how deep the hidden control room actually runs, and she started long before Al'thea ever found the thing." He set a data slate on Mar'ika's desk, hands not quite steady. "But her quarters are empty. Not cleared out—empty, like nobody's slept there in longer than a week. And when I asked around, people looked at me like I'd invented her."

"Show me."

He didn't get the chance. His device chimed—an internal message, routine-looking, flagged from Haven's own administrative channel—and as he read it, Mar'ika watched something go strange and slack in his face, the stillness of a man reading a sentence that didn't fit any sentence he remembered writing.

"I don't—" He frowned at the slate in his hand as though it had appeared there without his help. "What was I telling you?"

"The east conduit," Mar'ika said carefully. "The diagnostic logs."

"Right. Yes." He turned the slate over, and turned it back, and the frown didn't clear so much as smooth itself away, the way a wave smooths a mark out of wet sand. "I don't actually know why I have

this. I should get back to the rotation." He left without the data slate. He left, Mar'ika would only understand much later, without ever again being quite the man who had walked in.



The data slate was gone from her desk by morning, and so, in any system Mar'ika could access, were the diagnostic logs it had held. By the following gamma rotation, neither, in any way she could put a name to, did the conversation in which Ko'dan had shown them to her. She kept catching the edge of it—a data slate she was certain meant something, a name that surfaced and dissolved before she could hold onto it, a second bunk in the technical wing that some deep, wordless part of her expected to find occupied and never did. She asked the wing's residents whether anyone had reassigned quarters recently. Nobody had. Nobody, checking the records with her, standing beside her while she searched, seemed to find anything unusual in the empty space at all.

She thought, once, alone in her own quarters that night, that she should mention the feeling to someone—the familiar, formless unease of a person certain that the room around her held one fewer chair than it should. But there was no one obvious to mention it to, and no fact to hang the feeling on, and by morning even the unease had softened into something she could no longer quite locate, the way a bruise stops announcing itself once the swelling goes down.

Whatever Vel'ra and Ko'dan had found in the deep canyon's oldest wiring, wherever the evidence had been going, whoever they had meant to tell—it was gone as completely as if it had never existed at all, folded away by hands too careful to leave even the shape of an absence behind. Haven's roster ran two hundred and eleven names that gamma rotation, the same as it had the rotation before, and the rotation before that, and not one person in the canyon could have said, if asked, that the number had ever been any different.



Nobody said the word *plan* yet — that still felt too large, too much like promising something none of them could yet guarantee — but the shape of one was already assembling itself in the space between them, the way it always did once Maal started talking logistics: approach vectors, the gap between Kestrel Hollow's outer perimeter and whatever sat at its centre, how long they'd have once anyone noticed a ship where no ship should be. Elena watched it happen the way she'd once watched a proof come together on a whiteboard — not from nothing, but from the shape everyone already half-suspected was there, waiting to be drawn out loud. She realised, somewhere in the middle of it, that she had stopped being afraid of the silence in her own room and started simply not noticing it anymore; the four of them had become, without her quite deciding to let it happen, the only place she actually felt present.

"They moved on Marcus in a single night," Elena said, the thought that had been sitting under everything since the night they erased him, unspoken until now. "One question, answered and buried before morning. Whatever we do, we don't get to be slow about it."

"We're not being slow," Maal said. "We're being right, once, instead of fast four times over." He looked at each of them in turn, the same way he had at Tau Ceti, cataloguing readiness instead of doubt. "But she's right about the shape of it. Once we move, we don't get a second attempt to be careful."

Al'thea felt the old, familiar pull of her own certainty rising — the same reflex that had made her answer Me'dan's provocations before she'd finished thinking, the same one that had made her tell Maal *say it, all of it* at Tau Ceti as if conviction alone were a kind of proof. She recognised it this time, at least. That felt like something, even if she wasn't yet sure it was enough.

"Then we go careful," she said, and willed herself to mean it. "Once."

Nobody answered right away. Somewhere out past the edge of the display, Kestrel Hollow's unremarkable star sat exactly where four different kinds of looking had all, independently, agreed to find it — and for the first time since James's silence at Tau Ceti, the four of them had somewhere real to go.

Chapter 22

Breach



Kestrel Hollow's official designation, painted in faded stencil on the one landing pad anyone bothered to maintain, was *Regional Agricultural Testing Station 9*. Nothing about the approach suggested otherwise. Scrubland, low domes, the kind of tired, underfunded infrastructure that told a story of its own — a place nobody with real power had ever cared enough about to visit.

That was, Maal thought, watching the surface resolve out of the dark through the shuttle's forward port, exactly the point.

"Two heat signatures at the perimeter fence," he said. "Both stationary. Automated, not manned — nobody's walking a patrol out here, because nobody's supposed to need to." He'd said some version of this sentence a dozen times in the last hour, less for the

others' benefit than his own, the old habit of a man who thought better with his mouth moving. "That's not incompetence. That's confidence. They don't believe anyone will ever look."

"We're about to be the exception," Al'thea said. She sat very still in the shuttle's rear seat, hands folded in her lap in a way that looked calm and wasn't. She'd insisted on coming — of course she had — and Maal had let her, because keeping her out of it would have cost more than bringing her in, and because some part of him still remembered *say it, all of it* and thought she'd earned the right to be here when it mattered. Ny'sol had stayed behind with James at the rendezvous, over a stretch of loud, wing-mantled protest — a covert breach was no place for something that couldn't be told to stay quiet on command, whatever else he was.

James stayed behind at the rendezvous point, a decision that had taken longer to agree on than anything else — his case needed a witness who survived to tell it, and Kestrel Hollow was not a place any of them could promise that. He would monitor the resonance, and if it went silent the way Ba'than's had, he would do what none of them wanted to say out loud yet: get what they already had to enough people that it mattered anyway.



The perimeter fence was exactly as undefended as Maal's read had promised, and exactly as wrong as Elena's instincts insisted it should be. She kept expecting the trap to reveal itself, some final layer of security that justified how easily they'd gotten this far, and it never came. That absence was its own kind of dread.

"They're not protecting against an attack," Maal said quietly, cutting the fence's sensor loop with a tool he'd carried since Kepler-447 and never once needed until tonight. "They're protecting against a *question*. Different threat model entirely. A soldier expects a fight. A bureaucrat expects nobody looking closely enough to ask." He glanced back at Al'thea. "That's the whole reason Elena's friend Ter'an sounded so sorry instead of so afraid, back on her station. He wasn't guarding a fortress. He was hoping nobody would ever need to find out there was anything here to guard."

They crossed the open ground between the fence and the nearest dome at a pace that felt, to Elena, unbearably slow and, to Maal, exactly correct — the pace of a man who had learned, the hard way, that speed and carelessness were the same mistake wearing different clothes.



Inside, the dome's outer ring was agriculture after all — real hydroponics, real yield logs, a night-shift technician asleep at a monitoring station who never woke. Maal noted the layout with

the same flat, cataloguing attention he'd given every briefing room he'd ever sat through for a war that had never once been real, and felt, for the first time since Kepler-447, that the attention was finally being spent on something that would matter tomorrow.

The inner ring was different.

The corridor narrowed. The air changed — colder, filtered, carrying the same faint sterile-and-specimen smell Elena remembered from her own laboratory, the smell of a place designed to leave no trace of what happened in it. A door that should have needed a Val'tari-grade credential to open stood very slightly ajar, and Maal went still in the way that meant he'd found something he didn't like.

"Ajar isn't a mistake," he murmured. "Ajar is someone in a hurry."

He was right, and they found out why four steps later, at a junction where a second corridor met the first — a Val'tari attendant, small-bodied and fast even at rest, standing with its back to them over an open equipment case, doing something with quick, practised hands to a device none of them recognised.

Elena felt Maal's whole body change before he moved, the transition from planning to action so seamless it barely registered as a transition at all. He crossed the distance in three strides and had the attendant down and restrained before it managed more

than a single sharp intake of breath — not violence for its own sake, precise and economical and over almost before Al'thea's mind caught up with what her eyes had seen.

"Two hours, in and out," Maal said, breathing hard, checking the restraint with hands that had gone steady the instant the danger passed. "But from Kepler-447 to right now, it's the first time in this whole business my training's actually been for something real." He looked up at the others, and for once there was nothing analytical in his face at all. "I'd rather it hadn't been. But I'm glad it was good enough."



The attendant, searched and silent, carried a manifest.

Elena read it standing in the narrow corridor with her back against the cold wall, and felt something in her chest go very quiet and very cold, the way it had the night she'd learned what had been done to Marcus.

It wasn't a manifest of one prisoner. It was a manifest of a *facility* — intake dates stretching back decades, names in a shorthand none of them fully recognised, status codes that repeated over and over in the same small handful of patterns. The device's screen was small and its light too bright for the dim corridor, and Elena found

herself angling it away from her own face without quite deciding to, as though the glow itself might give them away. Most recent entry, four days old: a name that wasn't Ba'than's at all.

"This isn't just for him," Al'thea said, very quietly. "This is where they've always sent people. This is what 'advanced conditioning' actually *means*."

Nobody said Mar'ika's name. Nobody needed to. It sat in the silence between them, undecided and unresolved, a door none of them had time to open tonight.

"Ba'than's entry is here," Maal said, scrolling further, his voice carefully level in the way Elena now recognised as the sound of him keeping himself steady on purpose. "Recent. Flagged priority. And there's a wing designation next to it I don't recognise from anything else on this list."

He looked up, past the corridor's next turn, towards a stairwell descending into a part of the facility that had not existed on any schematic James's contacts had ever managed to find.

"That's where we're going," he said. "And I want to be clear with all of you, right now, before we take one more step — whatever's down there, we don't get to be slow about it, and we don't get to be careless either. Both at once. That's the whole job tonight."

Al'thea looked at the stairwell, and felt the old certainty rise in her one more time — the urge to simply decide, and move, and let conviction stand in for care. She forced herself to breathe through it instead, the way she'd promised herself she would.

It didn't feel like enough. She went down the stairs anyway.

Chapter 23

The Deep Wing



The stairwell dropped further than anything James's contacts had ever mapped, past a landing where the last trace of the hydroponics dome's warm, growing-things smell gave way entirely to something colder and more deliberate — filtered air, faintly metallic, moving with the low mechanical hum of a system built to serve a purpose nobody upstairs was ever meant to ask about. Their own footsteps fell strange against it, three sets of boots on metal grating that hadn't been designed to carry sound quietly, each step announcing itself a half-beat longer than it should have in the dark.

"Schematic ends here," Maal said, checking the reader strapped to his forearm. "Officially, we're standing in bedrock right now."

"Officially is doing a lot of work in that sentence," Elena said.

They kept going.



The first room off the landing had been records once, or still was — rows of physical storage lockers, the old kind, meant for a place built before anyone trusted data enough to stop keeping paper as well. Elena ran her light along a shelf of intake ledgers, spines cracked soft from handling, dates stamped along their edges in a hand that predated the manifest's digital shorthand by decades. She didn't open one. She didn't need to; the shelf ran the length of the room and further, into shadow her light didn't reach, and the simple physical *length* of it told her everything the manifest's clean entries had let her keep at a comfortable distance until now.

"How long," she said, not really a question.

"Long enough that whoever built the digital system inherited this instead of replacing it," Maal said. He didn't linger either. "Every war I fought had a clean official story and a filing cabinet somewhere that told the truth about how long it had actually been running. This is somebody's filing cabinet." He said it lightly, the way he said most things that actually cost him something, and didn't look at the shelf again after that — Elena noticed, the way she was learning to notice things about him he'd never say outright, and let it go unremarked, the same courtesy he extended her whenever her own composure needed the room to look away.

Al'thea stood in the doorway and didn't go in at all. She had spent eleven months learning, slowly and at real cost, to recognise the pull of her own certainty before it moved her hands — and she recognised it now, rising at the sight of all that patient, damning paper, the same reflex that wanted to stop, and read, and *know*, right now, whatever the minutes cost. She disciplined herself to catalogue the feeling instead of obeying it, the way Maal had taught her without ever once using the word *taught*. Ba'than was still somewhere ahead of them, running out of whatever he had left to run out of. The paper would still be lying there tomorrow, if any of them survived to come back for it.

She didn't know yet that she'd forget the lesson again within the hour. She only knew, standing in the doorway, that she was keeping it for now — and that keeping it felt like the first real proof she'd had all night that something in her had actually changed.

"Later," she said, mostly to herself. Maal glanced at her and said nothing, which from him was its own kind of acknowledgment.



Elena felt the attendant before either of the others saw anything — a flicker at the raw, untrained edge of her own mind, there and gone, the mental equivalent of a footstep in a room she'd thought was empty. She caught Maal's sleeve without a word and tilted her head towards the side passage a half-second before a second

attendant rounded into the record room's outer doorway, unhurried, checking a hand-held reader with the bored attention of someone running a routine sweep that hadn't found anything worth reporting in years.

They went still in the shadow of the lockers, pressed close enough in the narrow gap between shelving that Al'thea could feel Maal's pulse through his sleeve, slower than her own by a margin that told her everything about which one of them had done this before — three people and one entire lifetime of separate training in the art of not being noticed — and waited while the attendant's light swept the room's near edge and moved on without a second look. The sound of it faded down a passage they hadn't taken.

"That's the first time tonight I've felt something a half-second before I should have been able to," Elena said quietly, once the corridor was empty again. "I don't like what that might mean. I don't have time to find out tonight."

"Write it down for later," Maal said. "Preferably somewhere that isn't a burning building."

It wasn't a joke, not really. It landed like one anyway, the worn humour of people who had run out of any better way to carry what they were carrying.



The passage past the records room narrowed, then opened onto a final landing — a single door, unmarked except for the same dry bureaucratic hand from the manifest: *Independent Confirmation — Route to Central Filing.* No lock Maal recognised from anything Val'tari-standard. No guard. The corridor behind them had gone utterly silent, the kind of silence that pressed against the ears rather than simply being an absence of sound, as though the deep wing itself was holding its breath along with them. Just the door, and behind it, humming at a frequency Elena felt more than heard, something that had been quietly running long before any of them were born and would keep running long after tonight, whatever tonight cost them.

"Ba'than's not behind this one," Maal said. "Manifest had him three doors back, past a junction we'd have to cross that patrol's loop twice to reach safely. We go through here first, or we don't go through at all — I don't like it either, but backtracking now costs us more time than it saves."

Al'thea looked at the door, and felt, one more time, the old shape of her own certainty gathering itself — quieter this time, dressed in something that almost looked like patience, waiting for its moment.

"Then we go through," she said, and reached for the handle before either of them could answer.



The door opened on a chamber that made no sense as a place for holding prisoners, because holding prisoners was only the smallest part of what it did.

Cells lined one wall, six of them, small and clean and worse for being clean — no restraints needed when a mind had already been made to forget why it would want to leave, the whole chamber lit by a cold, shadowless white that made everything in it look slightly unreal, the air recycled and sterile in a way that carried no trace of the facility's mundane upper floors at all. Ba'than was in the third one, slumped against the rear wall, eyes closed, breathing in the shallow, careful way of someone conserving something that wouldn't refill.

But the cells weren't what stopped Al'thea in the doorway.

The opposite wall held a bank of instruments unlike anything from the facility's outer, mundane layers — dense, cold, humming at a frequency that seemed to sit just beneath hearing, every readout tracking not data but *arrival*, spikes and troughs matching nothing any local transmitter could account for. A console labelled, in the same dry bureaucratic hand as the manifest, *Independent Confirmation — Route to Central Filing*.

"That's it," Elena breathed. "That's what launders the god's own sensory record before it ever reaches the Conclave proper. Not the whole mechanism — just one relay. One tap on the line." Her voice had gone hushed, the way it had the night she'd first seen the rings bloom across her own lab's display, the reverence she reserved for

evidence too large to argue with. "This is real, physical proof that something out there is actually *sensing*. Not a story. Not a rumour passed down secondhand. An active signal, arriving right now, from something too vast to be anything human built."

"Ba'than first," Maal said, already moving towards the cell, tool in hand. "Everything else after."



The cell's lock wasn't built for a war that had never actually been fought — a civilian restraint, dressed up in Val'tari styling to look more formidable than it was — and Maal had it open before he'd finished the thought that it might be harder than it looked. Ba'than didn't wake so much as surface, slow and effortful, like a man remembering how his own body worked one system at a time. Elena's breath caught once, involuntarily, at the sight of him up close — the clinical part of her already cataloguing what she was seeing, dehydration, muscle wastage, a fine tremor in his hands that hadn't been in any of James's old recordings — even as the rest of her simply hurt, watching a man Al'thea had once described as warm and commanding reduced to this.

"Maal." His voice was a thin, dry rasp, nothing like the warm authority Al'thea remembered from a lecture hall on the Teacher Vessel, a lifetime ago. "You came."

"Did you doubt it?"

"I hoped you wouldn't." Ba'than's eyes found the rest of them in the doorway, one at a time, with the effort of a man rationing his own attention like everything else that hadn't refilled. "All of you. That was never supposed to be the arithmetic."

"It's the only arithmetic there ever was," Maal said, getting an arm under him, feeling how little weight Ba'than actually had left to lift — lighter than he'd braced for, alarmingly so, the kind of lightness that told its own story before Ba'than said a word of his own. "Can you stand?"

"I can be made to." Ba'than found his feet with more will than strength, one hand fisted hard in the fabric of Maal's sleeve, and for a moment — just a moment, before the discipline of decades reasserted itself — something in his face was simply, unguardedly grateful, the look of a man who had spent this entire captivity believing, with the quiet despair of someone who has run every calculation and found it wanting, that no one was coming.

Then his gaze went past Maal's shoulder to the instrument bank, and whatever had briefly opened in his face closed like a door.



"You found it," he said, very quietly. "Decades in the project, and I never knew this specific room existed." He said it the way a man confesses something, not the way he'd observe it. "How much does she already understand?"

"Enough," Maal said. "Everything else after. Right now I need you standing and moving, not talking."

"Maal." Ba'than's grip tightened, urgent in a way his voice, too spent to rise, couldn't manage on its own. "Whatever's about to happen in this room — that console reports its own access. I helped design an earlier version of the architecture, before I understood what I was designing. If anyone touches it without knowing that, we have minutes, not hours."

Al'thea, three steps away and already half-turned towards the console, heard it. Maal watched her hear it, watched the warning land somewhere behind her eyes and not quite finish arriving — the same half-second he'd come to recognise in her over eleven months, conviction moving faster than caution ever quite managed to catch up.

"Al'thea," Maal said. "You heard him."

"I heard him," she said, and didn't look away from the console.

Ba'than's eyes found hers, weary and clear-sighted in a way that had nothing left to soften it with. "Then hearing isn't the part you're short on."



There was no time to make it a longer argument than that. Maal turned Ba'than towards the door, already cataloguing the exits the way he'd catalogued every room since Kepler-447 — the corridor's width, the distance to the stairwell, how far a badly weakened fifth person could be carried if it came to carrying.

"Minutes," Maal said again, to all of them now, not just her. "That's the whole warning. Don't spend it proving a point."

He didn't wait for an answer. There wasn't time for that either, and some part of him — the part that had learned, across eleven months, exactly which battles were his to fight and which ones a person had to lose for themselves before they'd believe the cost was real — was already moving Ba'than towards the door, one eye still, despite himself, on the woman he couldn't make listen any harder than she already had. Behind them, the instrument bank kept its patient, wordless hum going, utterly indifferent to which of the five people it had just met would be the one to come back for it.

Chapter 24

Undeniable



Al'thea didn't move.

She stood in front of the instrument bank with her whole body angled towards it, and Maal watched something familiar settle over her face — the old certainty, dressed up this time as something that looked almost like duty. *This is the proof.* Not a feeling. Not testimony four people could always be accused of sharing because they wanted to believe it together. Something recorded, dated, verifiable, the kind of evidence James could put in front of people who had never trusted a resonance-borne conviction and never would.

"Thirty seconds," she said. "I can copy the log. If we lose him and we lose this, we've traded a man for nothing anyone outside this room will ever believe."

"We're not losing him," Maal said, and there was an edge in it now, the first time all night his voice had carried anything but flat control. "Al'thea. Now."

She reached for the console anyway.

It wasn't defiance, not exactly — in the half-second before her hands closed on the interface, she believed, completely and sincerely, that she was making the harder, better choice, the one that mattered more than the easy one. *Thirty seconds,* said the part of her that had never lost an argument it actually wanted to win. *You've heard him. You've counted the cost. Do the sums, Thea — a log outweighs a delay, every time, and you know it.* It was the same certainty that had once made her answer Me'dan before she'd finished thinking, the same one that had told Maal *say it, all of it* as if conviction alone were proof enough of anything, and this time it even had the decency to sound like her — reasonable, quick, absolutely certain it was right. She had recognised the reflex a hundred times tonight already. *I know what you are,* she told it, in the same half-second her hands were already moving. *That's the part I still can't make matter.* Recognising it, it turned out, was not the same thing as being able to stop, and she understood that too, in the same half-second, with a clarity that arrived exactly one moment too late to change what her hands were already doing.

The console woke under her fingers, and somewhere above them, a silent alarm woke with it.



They heard the response before they saw it — not the isolated shuffle of one distracted attendant, but the fast, coordinated tread of people who had trained for exactly this and never expected to need it. Maal already had Ba'than's arm across his shoulders, half-carrying him towards the door the instant the alarm's meaning became clear, and even so, weakened as he was, Ba'than found the strength to focus his eyes on Al'thea with an expression she would spend a long time afterward trying not to remember.

"Minutes, not hours," he said, voice a thin rasp. "I told you that before you touched it."

"I didn't think—"

"You didn't ask how many you'd already spent." It wasn't cruel. It was worse than cruel; it was simply, unhurriedly true, the same way his warning about cages built by loving hands had been true long before she understood it. "Move. Now. All of it later."

They ran.

The corridor back towards the surface had been empty on the way down. It was not empty now. Elena felt the first responder's mind brush against her own raw sense half a second before she saw him

— Val'tari, fast, already reaching for something at his belt — and there was no time for Maal's careful economy this time, only motion, only the desperate arithmetic of four people and one badly weakened fifth against a defence that had finally, completely, stopped underestimating them.

Al'thea took the blow that would have caught Maal from behind. She never fully understood, afterward, whether she'd seen it coming and moved on purpose or simply turned at the worst possible angle at the worst possible moment; it didn't matter to the pain, which was total, immediate, and entirely her own to carry — a graze along her ribs that dropped her to one knee and left her fighting for the breath to keep moving at all.



It was the fear that did it — Elena's fear, sharp and total and finally undefended, the walls she kept around her own mind stripped away by pure animal urgency — that blew the resonance open wider than any of them had ever felt it, wider than Tau Ceti, wider than the night the four of them had first merged into one shared awareness at all. It reached, the way it always reached when the four of them were closest to breaking, for every mind it had ever touched.

James, sitting alone at the rendezvous point with his hand clenched white around a comm unit that had gone silent an hour ago, felt it arrive like a wave breaking over him from a great height.

He did not get words. He got the thing underneath words — the cold hum of the instrument bank, the spike-and-trough rhythm of a signal arriving from somewhere too vast to be anything human-built, filtered through Elena's own trained, disbelieving certainty that this was real, that it was *right there*, undeniable, not a story anyone could ever again dismiss as four traumatised people's shared delusion. He got Ba'than's exhaustion, and Maal's fear translated instantly into motion, and beneath all of it, holding the whole moment together the way a keystone holds a collapsing arch, he got Al'thea's pain — hot, real, arriving in his own chest as if it were his — and the raw, unbearable clarity of a woman finally, actually learning the difference between being right and being wise, at the exact moment it cost her something she could not take back.

James had spent three months building a case constructed entirely of things other people could verify without him. In the space of four seconds, crouched alone in a supply bay on Ceres Station, he stopped needing any of that for himself. He knew. Not believed — *knew*, the unfalsifiable way a person knows they are in pain, because he had, for four seconds, been standing inside someone else's undeniable and it had not once asked for his trust.



They made the shuttle. That was the whole of the miracle, and it was enough.

Maal flew them out through a response that hadn't finished mobilising, the hard-won competence of a man who had spent a lifetime training for a war that turned out to be false and had, tonight, finally spent that competence on something real. Ba'than lay across two seats, breathing, alive, present in a way Marcus never would be again. Elena held pressure against Al'thea's side with hands that would not stop shaking until well after Kestrel Hollow had shrunk to an unremarkable point of light behind them. The shuttle's cabin smelled of scorched metal and someone's blood, and nobody had thought to dim the interior lights, so the four of them sat in a harsh, clinical brightness that felt entirely wrong for what had just happened to them — Al'thea, pale under it, her jaw set against pain she refused to give voice to; Maal's hands steady on the controls even as the rest of him visibly hadn't caught up yet with what his body had done.

Al'thea didn't ask about the log. She already knew the console's own audit trail meant the copy she'd started would never have finished, that the alarm had triggered before the transfer completed, that whatever she'd meant to bring back for James had been left behind in a locked room on a world they could never safely return to.

"I lost it," she said finally, into the shuttle's quiet. "The whole reason I stayed."

"You didn't," James's voice said, thin and static-edged through the comm, the first words he'd managed since the resonance had torn open and then, gently, begun to close. "I felt it. All of it. I don't need the log, Al'thea. I was *there*."

She closed her eyes, and for the first time since a lecture hall on the Teacher Vessel, half a lifetime ago, said nothing clever at all.

Chapter 25

Full Benefits Continuation



The transport that came for Naomi Reyes was clean, comfortable, and entirely unremarkable, which she noticed and then refused to keep noticing, the way she'd trained herself for thirty years to stop noticing the familiar ache in her knees before a storm front no forecast had predicted yet. It carried four other passengers, none of whom she recognised from the yard, all of them travelling alone, all of them reading the same orientation packet on the same model of data slate. Nobody spoke much. The shuttle's cabin recycled air with a faint chemical sweetness she didn't recognise, and the seats were bolted in neat symmetrical rows built for exactly this number of passengers and no more, as though someone had known in advance precisely how many would be travelling today. She told

herself that was ordinary too — strangers on a transit shuttle, tired at the end of a long reassignment process, nothing in it worth a second look.

Continuing Education Annex 14, the packet called the facility, in the same flat administrative type as everything else the directive had sent her. A campus. Faculty housing. A research fellowship, effectively, for personnel whose analytical profile the University had flagged as exceeding the useful ceiling of their current posting. The word *fellowship* sat oddly next to the word *mandatory* two paragraphs later, and Naomi noticed that too, and set it down next to the wrongness she'd carried since the letter first arrived, and did not, yet, let the two things touch.



Intake took most of a day, and none of it, taken piece by piece, was anything she could have pointed to and called wrong.

A woman with a kind, tired face took her blood, her retinal scan, and a long, careful medical history that circled back twice to questions about her mother's side of the family — *any history of unusual cognitive presentation, early or late onset, anyone diagnosed or undiagnosed, we ask everyone this, it's standard* — and smiled the same professional smile of someone who had explained that it was standard a great many times before. Her hands were gentle and precise at the blood draw, the practised gentleness of someone who had done this exact task enough times that the kindness in it had

become procedure rather than feeling — which didn't make it any less real, Naomi thought, just harder to be sure of. A man in a soft grey uniform walked her through the campus itself, low buildings arranged around a central green that could have belonged to any middling research institute in human space, and used the word *community* four times in a ten-minute tour.

"How long is the posting?" Naomi asked, for the third time that day, in the patient tone she used with a supervisor who hadn't quite answered a question the first two times.

"That's really up to the Board's ongoing assessment," the man said, in the practised tone of someone who had also answered that question a great many times before, and Naomi understood, with the same wordless certainty she'd once felt about strut three hundred and forty-one, that she was not going to get a better answer than that one no matter how many times she asked it.



She met Corran Weiss at the community hall that evening, over a meal that tasted like every institutional meal she'd eaten in thirty years of shipyard work, competent and entirely without character. The hall itself was pleasant in the deliberate, unplaceable way of a space designed by someone who had studied what made a room feel safe without ever having needed to feel unsafe themselves — warm lighting, round tables, nothing sharp-edged anywhere she looked. He'd arrived four months earlier, he told her, a logistics

coordinator whose scheduling instincts had apparently outpaced what any scheduling system could account for, and he talked about it the way a person talks about a job they've had long enough to stop examining.

"You get used to it," he said, when she asked how he liked the posting, and there was nothing in his face when he said it — no irony, no private joke behind the words, nothing at all underneath the sentence for Naomi's own old, reliable instinct to catch on. She had spent thirty years reading the wrongness in things other people missed. She found herself, for the first time in longer than she could remember, unable to locate any wrongness in a man whose voice contained noticeably less of anything than it should have.

"Four months," she said. "Do you miss the old job?"

Corran considered this with the mild, unhurried patience of someone asked to recall a fact rather than a feeling. "I don't think about it very often," he said, which was, Naomi realised only much later, not actually an answer to the question she had asked.



Her quarters, when she finally reached them, were clean, adequately furnished, and identified on the door by a small brass plate that read only her surname and a room designation — no floor number, no wing, nothing that told her where in the campus she actually was relative to anything else. The window, when she

found it, looked out on an identical row of buildings across a strip of grass too perfectly green to be anything but engineered, and told her nothing at all about which direction she'd actually come from. A single administrative notice waited on the room's terminal, formatted in the same dry, bureaucratic hand as every other document the directive had produced.

Welcome to Continuing Education Annex 14. Your onboarding assessment will begin within the standard evaluation window. Please note: campus wayfinding directs all personnel movement through Central Filing for the duration of initial orientation. This is standard practice and requires no action on your part.

Independent Confirmation — Route to Central Filing, read the smaller stamp beneath it, in type so routine and so bureaucratically unremarkable that Naomi's eye slid straight past it without once catching on the words at all — the same trained blindness a person develops for the fine print of any form they've signed a hundred times before, and never once the kind of wrongness her whole career had been built on catching.

She thought, lying in an unfamiliar bed on the first night of what the letter had called an advancement, that she should feel more unsettled than she did. She found, instead, only a small, distant unease she couldn't locate the shape of — the way a person almost remembers a word, and then doesn't — and decided, the way she had decided about a hundred smaller unexplainable things across thirty years, that it would still be there tomorrow if it mattered, and went, eventually, to sleep.

Somewhere else entirely, in a converted cargo container on a half-abandoned freight platform, four people who had just pulled a man they loved out of a facility built on the same quiet, patient lie were finally, for the first time in weeks, allowed to rest — not knowing, and with no way yet to know, that the list they were building had just missed, by one letter arriving one week too late, exactly the kind of person it existed to find.

Chapter 26

Weight



The safe house was nothing but a converted cargo container on a half-abandoned freight platform, and it was, Elena thought, the most comfortable place she had been in a month. Someone — Maal, probably, in one of the few hours he'd allowed himself to sit still — had rigged a string of salvaged lights along the container's ribbed ceiling, and they threw a warm, uneven glow over the four camp beds and the single folding table that made up the whole of their furniture. The air smelled of machine oil and reheated ration packs and, faintly, of the antiseptic Elena kept changing on Al'thea's dressing. Outside, the freight platform's ambient hum was constant enough that after the first day none of them noticed it anymore, except in the rare moments it briefly stopped.

Ba'than slept for most of the first two days, and the container held that sleep the way a held breath holds silence — Elena checking his pulse more often than she needed to, Maal's cleaning kit laid out and packed away and laid out again on the same two square feet of table, Al'thea's chair by the far wall never quite empty, even when she claimed she was only sitting there to rest her ribs. When he woke on the third, it was to the quiet of a room where people had been watching him breathe. He found Elena reading in the corner, Maal cleaning a weapon he hadn't needed to fire, and Al'thea sitting very still by the far wall with her ribs wrapped and her eyes fixed on nothing in particular, Ny'sol a warm, unmoving weight against her uninjured side — James had brought him from the rendezvous point along with everything else that had needed carrying, and he hadn't left her lap for more than a few minutes since.

"You're all still here," Ba'than said, his voice steadier than it had any right to be. "I confess I hadn't entirely planned on that outcome."

"Neither had we," Maal said, "for about four minutes there."

James arrived an hour later, having finally judged the route clear enough to risk the transit himself — the first time since Tau Ceti all five of them had been in the same room, and the first time ever with nothing left to argue about whether it was real. He stopped in the doorway and looked at Ba'than for a long moment before crossing to him, and something passed between the two of them that didn't need the resonance to be understood.

"I felt it," James said. "All of it. I know."

"I know you do," Ba'than said. "I felt you feel it."



They let the silence hold for a while after that, the loaded silence of people who had run out of urgent things to do and hadn't yet worked out what came next. James found a seat on an overturned crate near the door, still half in his travelling coat, as though some part of him hadn't yet decided to stay. Maal set his weapon down at last, fully assembled, and didn't pick it back up. Elena drew her knees up onto her own cot and wrapped her arms around them, a smaller, more private shape than the one she usually let the others see. It was Al'thea who broke it, because it was always going to be Al'thea, and because she had spent three days deciding exactly what she needed to say and had run out of time to keep deciding. She didn't stand. She stayed exactly where she was, ribs wrapped, back against the container's cold metal wall, and steadied herself, looking at each of them in turn before she started.

"I want to say I'm sorry," she told the room, not just Ba'than. "But I've said sorry before, and it's never stopped me doing the thing again, so I don't think it's worth much from me anymore."

"Then don't say it," Maal said. "Say what you actually learned instead."

She considered that with the same unflinching honesty she brought to everything, which was, she was beginning to understand, both the best and the most dangerous thing about her.

"I've spent this whole ordeal being wrong in a way I could recover from," she said slowly. "Chasing Me'dan before I'd finished thinking. Telling you to *say it, all of it* at Tau Ceti like conviction was the same thing as being right. Every time, I caught myself, or you caught me, and it cost us an argument, or a bruised evening, nothing that didn't heal." She looked down at the wrapping around her ribs. "This is the first time I've been wrong in a way that doesn't heal on its own. And the thing underneath it isn't recklessness. I've gotten better at recklessness — I actually stopped myself, twice, before I did something stupid back at Kestrel Hollow. The thing underneath it is that I still believe, every single time, that if I am *right* about something, that has to matter more than what anyone else needs from me in the moment. Maal gave me a direct order. I heard it. I understood it. I thought I understood better than the order did."

Elena's arms had tightened around her own knees somewhere in the middle of it, the posture of someone hearing a diagnosis she'd already half-suspected. "You did understand better," she said quietly. "The instrument was real. The proof mattered."

"It mattered," Al'thea agreed. "It wasn't worth what I risked for it. Those are two different sentences, and I kept treating them as the same one." She met Ba'than's eyes. "You tried to tell me something like this once — the lecture about cages built by loving hands. I wasn't listening to a word of it."

"I remember the lecture," Ba'than said. "I remember exactly how little you were listening."

"I'm listening now."



It was James who finally asked the question none of them had wanted to be the one to ask, because James had spent three centuries' worth of family history learning that some questions only get answered if somebody is willing to be the one who asks them plainly.

"You told Elena there were things you couldn't tell us yet. You told Al'thea the same thing, years before that — I read it, the message you left her at Haven. Knowing them has killed better people than either of us. That's what you said." He held Ba'than's gaze. "We know the god exists now. We felt it, all of us, through me — through the resonance," he corrected himself, and didn't quite manage to smile at his own slip. "What's left that you're still protecting us from?"

Ba'than was quiet long enough that Elena began to wonder if he would simply decline again, hold the line one more time the way he'd held it through every previous chapter of his own long caution. Maal had gone very still on his own cot, the same flat, listening stillness he brought to a briefing he already suspected was about to go badly — not impatience, exactly, but the readiness of a man bracing to hear something he couldn't unlearn afterward. When Ba'than finally spoke, his voice had the weight of a man setting down something he had carried for far longer than any of them had known him.

"I still won't give you the nexus's location," he said, "because I genuinely do not have it to give — that secret belongs to a very few, and none of them are people you could safely ask. What I can give you instead is the truth about me, which I've owed you longer than I've been willing to pay it." He looked at each of them in turn, the same slow cataloguing gesture Maal used before a plan, learned, Elena suspected, from exactly this man. "I didn't just carry the Conclave's messages, all those years. I served them. Believed every word of the protection I handed out, the way the lower orders still do, and I don't know how deep that belief went, or what it cost the people I gave it to, because I was always too afraid to look closely enough to find out. That's not a plan. It isn't a way in. It's just the truth, and it's the only thing I have left to trade for all the times I decided, alone, how much of it you could survive."

"Why tell us now?" Al'thea asked. "You could have told us that from the beginning."

"Because from the beginning, you were people with a theory," Ba'than said. "Tonight, you are people the Conclave has already tried to kill and failed. That changes what a piece of hope is worth against what it costs to give it. I am still not telling you everything. I doubt I ever fully will. But I am done deciding, alone, exactly how much of the truth the rest of you can survive knowing. Kestrel Hollow taught me that lesson as much as it taught Al'thea hers."

Nobody spoke for a while after that. Elena uncurled from her cot at last and crossed to sit beside Al'thea against the cold wall, close enough that their shoulders touched, and didn't say anything at all — some things, she'd learned, needed a body near them more than they needed words. James stayed on his crate by the door, turning something over in his own mind he wasn't ready to speak yet. Maal picked his weapon back up, not because he needed it, but because his hands needed something to do while the rest of him caught up. Outside the container's thin walls, the freight platform hummed its ordinary, indifferent hum, utterly unaware that five people inside it had just finished rearranging the entire shape of what came next.



Well past the others' sleep, the salvaged lights dimmed to their lowest setting, Al'thea felt Ny'sol go rigid against her collarbone in a way that had nothing to do with danger.

She'd learned, these past eleven months, the whole vocabulary of his stillness — the watchful kind he wore around strangers, the sharp kind that meant a threat, the loose, unimpressed kind that was simply Ny'sol finding the world beneath his notice. This was none of them. This was effort, unmistakably — something in him gathering itself towards a decision it had clearly already made, and was only now finding the nerve to spend.

Something about Kestrel Hollow had left the resonance wider than it used to be, a door blown open that hadn't quite settled back into its frame. She'd felt Maal's fear and James's four seconds of total knowing from rooms away since that night, sharper and easier than anything before it. She was beginning to understand, feeling the deliberate weight of him settle harder against her, that the door hadn't only opened for the four of them.

Ny'sol?

She didn't expect an answer. She never had, in eleven months of talking to him the way she talked to herself, an old fond habit she'd never really examined closely. What arrived instead wasn't a voice. She recognised the shape of it anyway — the same clean, total clarity she'd felt watching James absorb Elena's raw fear without a single word at Kestrel Hollow, not language but the thing underneath language, arriving whole. An image: the small monitoring device from a Haven file she'd read a lifetime ago, held up not as an accusation but as a question. *This, still, in me. Will you take it out.* Underneath it, steady as a held breath: relief that

she finally knew, and something else beneath the relief that took her longer to name, because she hadn't expected to find it in him at all. Fear that she might say no.

"You've known," she said quietly, not really a question. "Since Haven. Since I found the file."

The weight against her collarbone didn't move. It didn't need to.

"You could have told me. Any time since."

Wasn't ready. Not a voice, still — total and complete the way the rest of it had arrived, offering nothing she could have translated aloud even if she'd tried. *You weren't either.*

She thought of eleven months of small, unremarked kindnesses she'd rarely paused to question closely enough to be properly grateful for — a warning dive in a burning loading bay, a shoulder held steady through every departure, a habit of settling against her collarbone she'd let herself believe was simply affection, without ever asking what else it might, quietly, also have been for. She thought she should feel betrayed, and found, turning the question over with the same unflinching honesty she'd promised the others only hours ago, that she didn't. Whatever he had been built to do, he had also, somewhere along the way and entirely without her noticing, decided to be something else instead.

"I don't know how to undo it," she admitted. "I don't have the first idea what's actually in there."

Together, then. It arrived complete rather than composed, and underneath it, for the first time, something that felt almost like humour — dry, unimpressed, entirely his own register even carried without a single word. *You've never let not knowing stop you before. Why start with me.*

She laughed, a real one, startled out of her — the first unguarded sound she'd made since Kestrel Hollow. "I liked you better when you couldn't talk back."

I'm not talking. The correction arrived precise and immediate, and she understood, holding it, that the distinction mattered to him more than she'd expected it to. *Not yet.*

"Not yet," she agreed, and meant it as a promise rather than a guess.

She woke Elena an hour later, because whatever this was, she wasn't attempting it on instinct alone with a borrowed toolkit and hope. Elena took one look at the designation Al'thea gave her — a function list she'd had memorised, word for word, since the night she'd first read it in a hidden control room and never quite managed to forget it — and was fully awake within seconds, the same clean, focused urgency she brought to any problem that had just turned out to be real. It took the better part of two hours, working by the container's low salvaged light with tools built for something else entirely, Elena's hands steadier than Al'thea's own would have been, Ny'sol perfectly, deliberately still beneath both of them the whole time, holding himself through a procedure he

had no way of knowing wouldn't hurt him, because he had already decided, before either of them touched him, that it was worth the risk regardless.

"There," Elena said finally, sitting back, wiping her hands on a rag that had seen worse. "Passive relay's dead. Whatever else is still in him, it isn't reporting home anymore." She looked between the two of them for a moment, something unreadable crossing her face. "For what it's worth — I don't think this changes what he actually is. I think that already changed, a while ago. This just makes it true on paper as well."

Al'thea felt his attention settle on her, whole and unmistakable, the same total clarity she was only now learning to trust from him specifically. *A name,* it said, or didn't say — arrived, the way all of it arrived, complete rather than spoken. *Not the one you gave me. That one was for the part of me that was still theirs.*

"You already have one, then." Not quite a question.

I do now.

She braced for it to arrive the way everything else had, a shape rather than a sound — and then it wasn't. Not an impression this time. A word. His first, whole and entirely his own, sharp-edged and deliberate, carrying no echo at all of the one she'd given him in a lifetime she was already starting to think of as someone else's.

Krev'an.

"Krev'an," she said aloud, testing the shape of it, and felt the small, familiar weight against her collarbone settle for the first time into something that was entirely, deliberately his own choice to have made — not hers, this time, to have given.

Chapter 27

The Height of Civilisation



Me'dan came back on a leave nobody had scheduled a vigil around, which was itself the first thing Za'ra noticed — he'd always timed his visits home to land near some occasion before, a birthday, a holiday, anything that gave the return a shape other than *I needed to not be there for a while.* This time he simply appeared, three days early for nothing in particular, and asked Za'ra to get a drink with him alone, which he had never done in the eleven years she'd known him. They ended up at a quiet corner table in a bar neither of them had chosen for any particular reason except that it was dark and mostly empty, the kind of place made for exactly this sort of conversation, though neither of them said so out loud.

He looked older than his leave should account for, and there was something new in the set of his shoulders — a weight Za'ra couldn't name. His hands, when he wrapped them around his glass, had gone rougher than she remembered — a soldier's hands now, rather than the ones that used to gesture too wide making a point at dinner.

"You're not here for De'to, or Fal'le," she said, once the first drink had bought them past the easy small talk. "You asked for me specifically."

"You always did see things first," Me'dan said, and it wasn't quite a compliment, the way he said it.



He talked, for a while, about nothing that mattered — the posting, the food, a commanding officer he clearly both respected and couldn't stand. Za'ra let him. She had learned, across eleven months of translating other people's grief for a fifth chair that was never coming back, exactly how long to let a person circle a thing before they were ready to land on it, and Me'dan had always needed longer than the others, ever since he was a boy arguing that a violent game was actually the height of civilisation because he could not yet say the truer, smaller thing underneath the argument.

"Do you remember Razor?" he said finally, turning his glass without drinking from it. "The tournament thing, back on the Teacher Vessel. I told Al'thea it was an outlet. Controlled aggression. A way of managing the animal in us so it didn't come out somewhere worse."

"I remember. She called it barbaric and came to watch you win anyway."

"I believed that, when I said it. Genuinely." He was quiet for a moment. "I've spent four years in a war against an enemy I've never actually seen up close, Za'ra, that behaves exactly like something running a doctrine three centuries out of date, that costs exactly the number of lives command needs it to cost and never one more than that, no matter what actually happens on the ground. I used to think Razor was proof that we'd found a civilised way to spend violence we couldn't get rid of. I don't think that anymore. I think I've spent four years inside the real version of the thing I used to defend, and it isn't civilised. It's just further away from the people deciding it needs to happen."

Za'ra kept her voice at exactly the register of careful, ordinary sympathy she'd have used a year ago, before she'd had any reason to listen for anything underneath it. "That sounds like something you can't say out loud where you're stationed."

"It's exactly that," Me'dan said, and something in his face loosened, very slightly, at being asked rather than reassured. "I said a version of it to a squadmate once. Just once, to one person, carefully. He looked at me like I'd handed him something he didn't want to be holding, and neither of us mentioned it again."



Za'ra filed that away without reacting to it, the same wordless, cataloguing attention she'd once given a whole friend group's worth of small true things underneath the words they chose. She didn't know whether the man Me'dan meant would ever matter to anything. She only knew, the way she'd known about the reassignment directive months before she understood why it mattered, that a soldier who'd noticed the same wrongness Me'dan had, in the same war, was a thread worth not losing.

"Why me," she said instead. "Why not one of the others."

"Because Fal'le would tell me I'm tired and need a rest, and De'to would agree with whatever I said just to keep the evening easy, and you're the only one of us who's never told me what I wanted to hear instead of what you actually thought." Me'dan finally drank, and set the glass down harder than he needed to. "I don't know what to do with what I've noticed. I don't have anywhere to put it. I thought, if anyone would tell me honestly whether I've lost my mind, it would be you."

She kept her face carefully unreadable, the same discipline she used every time someone she loved handed her something dangerous, and let the silence sit a beat longer than was comfortable before she answered. Za'ra thought of a small unlabeled device, and a man who let a gap in his own knowledge stand instead of papering it over with false certainty, and the quiet, unhurried care of someone content to wait until the pieces actually added up.

"You haven't lost your mind," she said. "But I think I might know someone who'd want to hear exactly what you just told me. Carefully. Nothing that puts you at risk you don't already know you're taking."

Me'dan looked at her for a long moment — the same intense, dark-eyed look he'd once turned on Al'thea across a debate he was determined to win — and this time asked no more of it than what was actually there.

"Tell me," he said.

She did not tell him about Al'thea. She did not tell him what the pattern he'd noticed actually was, or how far it went, or that the woman he still grieved might once have called it exactly the thing he was now circling from the other side without knowing it. She told him only what was true and hers to tell: that she'd spent the last months learning things that mattered more than she'd expected them to, and that the man she wanted him to meet had never lied to her to make a harder truth easier.

It was, she thought afterward, the second time in her life she'd recruited someone into something without either of them having a name for what it was yet — the first time, she hadn't known she was doing it either, and neither had James. She finished her own drink slower than she needed to, giving him the version of privacy that came from simply not watching someone's face while they decided to trust you.

Chapter 28

The Second Name



James chose the meeting place this time, which Za'ra understood, without being told, as its own kind of trust — the café where he'd first tested her honesty a lifetime of weeks ago, offered back to her now as somewhere she got to be the one who already knew the rules. The place hadn't changed — same scarred wooden tables, same steam-fogged window looking out on a street too ordinary for anyone passing to give the café a second glance, the specific unremarkableness James had once told her was the whole point of choosing it.

"You said a soldier," James said, once Me'dan had settled into the booth with the economy of a man who'd learned to make himself small in rooms that weren't secured. "Four years, artificial war, noticed the doctrine was too clean."

"That's the short version." Me'dan's eyes moved once around the café — exits, angles, the easy, reflexive read of a man who'd done it a thousand times. "Za'ra tells me you don't take things on faith. I'd rather you didn't take this on it either."

"I don't. I take it on whether it survives being checked." James set a data slate on the table between them, screen dark. He hadn't touched his own drink since it arrived, Za'ra noticed — the same tell she'd caught in him once before, over a truth he'd needed someone honest enough to receive: James listened with his whole body when something mattered, stillness itself becoming a kind of attention. "So check it with me. Tell me something specific enough that it either holds up or it doesn't."

Me'dan told him about Corvus Ridge — a designation, a casualty count, the arithmetic of a battle that had cost exactly the number of lives a doctrine three centuries stale would have predicted and not one more, the way real chaos never quite managed to be that tidy. He told him about a captain in his own chain of command who'd started returning from leave changed, sharper, carrying something he wouldn't name. He did not know the captain's name meant anything to the man across the table. James's face gave away nothing at all, which Za'ra was beginning to understand was itself

a kind of discipline — the same one he'd shown her, the careful restraint of a man who'd learned exactly how much his own reactions could cost someone else's safety.



"Why does this matter to you," James asked, "beyond one bad war."

"Because I built a whole argument, once, about violence needing a controlled outlet to be safely spent — for people, not against them. I believed it. I still partly believe the underlying idea. But I've spent four years inside a war that spends exactly as much violence as someone decided it should, on a schedule, for a purpose that has nothing to do with any of us in it, and I can't unfeel the difference anymore between the version I defended and the version I actually got." He turned his glass without drinking from it, the same gesture Za'ra remembered from their last conversation, alone, over a truth he'd needed someone honest enough to receive. "I don't know what you're building. Za'ra wouldn't tell me more than that it was real. I know I can't go back to not noticing what I've noticed." Something in James's posture eased, fractionally, the specific release of a man who'd spent three months bracing for people not to believe him and was still recalibrating for the ones who did.

"I'm not building anything that promises you an ending," James said. "I'm building a list of people who noticed independently, so that eventually the noticing can't be dismissed as one traumatised person's story. That's slower than you probably want it to be."

"I've been patient with worse odds than that." Me'dan looked at him steadily. "I'd just rather be patient towards something than simply patient."

James was quiet for a moment, the deliberate quiet Za'ra now recognised as him deciding something rather than searching for words. "Then welcome to something," he said, and it wasn't quite a smile, but it was close enough to count as one from him.



Za'ra let herself sit back, finally, watching the two of them settle into the careful, mutual sizing-up of people who'd just decided to trust each other with something dangerous — and felt, underneath the plain satisfaction of having been right about someone twice now, a small, familiar ache she'd stopped trying to talk herself out of months ago.

Al'thea would have liked this, she thought, the way she still sometimes thought it, unbidden, at moments that had nothing to do with grief and everything to do with the exact shape of a person

she still missed reading. *She'd have found the flaw in James's plan inside the first five minutes, and been insufferable about it, and been right.*

She had gotten good, this past year, at carrying the thought without letting it show on her face — the same skill she'd always had, turned finally, for once, towards herself instead of everyone else in the room.

"You did that the same way I did," Me'dan said quietly, once James had gone to settle the bill, watching her with the same steady attention he'd once turned on Al'thea across a debate he was determined to win. "You had me figured before I said a word."

"I've had a lot of practice."

"On who?"

Za'ra considered several answers, and settled, as she usually did now, for the true one that cost her the least to give. "Everyone I've ever loved," she said. "It's the only thing I've ever been good at that I didn't have to be taught."

Me'dan didn't press further. It was, she thought, one of the kinder things anyone had done for her all year — knowing exactly when a true thing had already been given completely, and needed nothing added to it. Outside, the street had gone fully dark while they talked, streetlights flickering on one by one along the block, and

for the length of one unguarded breath Za'ra let herself simply sit in a booth with two people who might, eventually, become enough.

Chapter 29

The Directive



Sen'thara had read eleven thousand incident reports in her long service to the Conclave, and the Kestrel Hollow file was, by any measure she could apply to it, an unremarkable one — a breach, an escape, a facility's cover intact, a manifest unread by anyone who'd survive to publish it. She had presided over worse. She had presided, three centuries ago, over an actual uprising, four hundred dead before the Directive's own correction cycles absorbed the memory of it into something the survivors could live inside without breaking. Measured against that, tonight's file was a paper cut.

Her chamber's single light caught the smooth grey pallor of her hands as she turned the reader over, small and quick-fingered the way her whole kind ran small and quick, robed in the same dark, gold-trimmed formality four hundred and thirty-six years of rank had earned her — an old, settled stillness in her posture that had nothing left to prove to anyone who might walk in and find her exactly as she always was. The chamber around her held nothing she hadn't chosen deliberately over four centuries of occupying it — no ornament without function, no comfort without purpose — the same discipline she'd long ago decided to apply to a mind as much as a room.

She read it four times anyway, because something in it kept refusing to settle the way a paper cut should. An aide passed the chamber's outer threshold once, saw the closed posture of her attention, and withdrew without a word — the kind of small, wordless deference four centuries of rank bought a person without her ever having had to ask for it.



The instrument bank was the part that wouldn't sit still. Not the breach itself — breaches happened, rarely, and the correction was always the same, patient and thorough and, she believed, genuinely kind: a life redirected rather than ended, a family's grief managed rather than compounded, a truth removed before it could do the cruelty of arriving without the wisdom to survive it. She had told

herself this so many times, across so many centuries, that she no longer experienced it as something she had once decided to believe. It simply was what was true, the way the sky was a colour.

But the instrument bank was different. Someone had *seen* it — copied its log, however briefly, however incompletely the audit trail claimed the transfer had failed. Someone now carried, however unprovably, a felt certainty of the god's own real and independent sensing, arriving from somewhere the Conclave's careful editing had never quite reached.

Sen'thara sat with that fact the way she imagined a physician might sit with a symptom that didn't match any disease in the index — turning it, testing its edges, and finding, underneath her own long practised calm, something she recognised only distantly as fear.



She had joined the Conclave four hundred and thirty-six years ago, young enough by her people's long measure to still remember, if she chose to reach for it, the reasons she had given herself at the time. She rarely chose to reach for it now. It was easier, and had been easier for longer than she could precisely date, to simply be a person for whom the Directive's purpose was self-evidently good — a shepherding of a species too young and too violent to survive its own unmediated truth, guided gently, generation over generation, towards a version of itself capable of surviving contact with what actually governed its universe. She had watched

humanity's wars grow smaller and more contained under three centuries of careful management. She had watched Waves of children born calmer, sharper, less cruel to one another than the generation before. She believed, sincerely, that this was mercy.

She could not, if asked directly and under whatever equivalent of oath her order still observed, have said with total honesty which had come first — the mercy, or the need to believe in it. The two motives had long since grown into each other the way two trees planted too close eventually share one root system, indistinguishable below the soil no matter how separate they still looked in whatever light reached them from above.

This was, she understood in some rarely-visited chamber of herself, exactly why the god could never simply ask her and be told the truth. She did not know it herself well enough to hide it. There was nothing to hide. There was only the shape of a life built so completely around one conclusion that no honest excavation could any longer find the ground it had first been built on.



The correction protocol for an active breach was, in the Directive's own dry language, unambiguous: *increase observational posture from passive to active where physical evidence has been compromised.* Sen'thara had issued the order a hundred times before, for lesser things, without once feeling the weight she felt issuing it now.

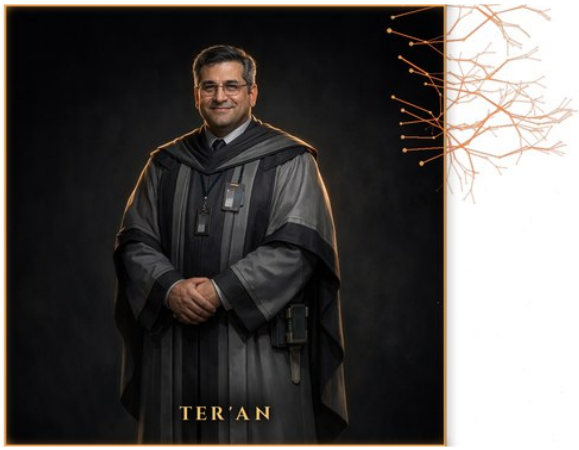
She thought, briefly and against her own long discipline, of the four people the facility's outer sensors had failed to properly identify — four signatures moving with a coordination that matched no known enhancement profile in the Conclave's own extensive index, four minds that had, for one brief and violently bright interval during their escape, resonated with a strength her own instruments had flagged as anomalous before the readings cut out entirely. She replayed that cutout twice more before moving on, the way she might probe a healing wound to check whether it still hurt — and found, unsettlingly, that it did. Whoever they were, they had done what almost no one in three centuries had managed: they had made her, however briefly, uncertain.

Uncertainty was not fear. She was careful, even in the privacy of her own unwatched thoughts, to keep the distinction precise. But she authorised the wider search regardless, and drafted the notice that would reach a University provost within the hour — worded, per the Directive's own long-standing preference, to inform without alarming, to request without demanding, to leave every recipient exactly as unable to name what they were actually being asked to fear as she herself remained, sitting alone in a chamber built for certainty, turning an unremarkable file over and over in hands that had stopped, some years ago she could no longer precisely locate, being entirely sure whose orders she was actually following anymore.

She sent the order. It was, she told herself, the kind thing to do — the only kind thing left, now that the harder kindness of never being found out had already, somewhere in a locked room on an unremarkable world, quietly failed.

Chapter 30

Outside Directive



The message from Provost Ter'an arrived nine days later, addressed to Elena's old university account, which she had not checked since the night he'd stood in her lab doorway and apologised for a corruption that had never actually existed.

Dr. Vasquez, it began, and for one suspended second she let herself believe it might still be the same warm, apologetic man who liked her, who remembered her students' names, who had genuinely never wanted to be the messenger for anything worse than a data audit.

I've been asked to pass along a formal notice regarding an unauthorised entry at a University research facility. The individuals responsible remain unidentified, but their methods were

sophisticated enough that we've been instructed to treat the matter as an active security concern rather than a resolved one. If you have any information relevant to this incident, you understand, I trust, why coming forward promptly would be in everyone's best interest.

I do hope you're keeping well. Please take care of yourself.

There was no warmth left in it at all. Elena read it twice, searching for the man who had once meant every kind word he'd ever said to her, and found only the shape where he used to be — the same careful, bureaucratic distance anyone speaking for something bigger than themselves wore over everything it did, worn now by someone who had genuinely liked her and had decided, somewhere between that night and this one, that liking her mattered less than whatever he was afraid of disappointing.

She showed the others without comment. Nobody needed the translation.



Ter'an had drafted the message nine times before he sent it, which was eight more drafts than he had ever needed for anything in thirty years of University correspondence.

The first draft had been the truth, more or less, and he had deleted it within a minute of finishing it, appalled at himself for having typed it at all. The second had been warm, the way he actually felt, and he had deleted that one too, slower, rereading it twice before

his hand found the key. By the fifth draft he had stopped trying to write what he meant and started trying to write what would satisfy the summary sitting open in his other window — three lines, unsigned, arrived through a channel that didn't officially exist inside the University's own systems, informing him only that Dr. Vasquez's facility had suffered "an unauthorised entry consistent with the pattern flagged in the Kestrel Hollow incident" and that his continued cooperation was "noted and expected."

He did not know what the Kestrel Hollow incident was. He had learned, over three decades of exactly this kind of summary, precisely how much was unwise to ask.

Ter'an sat for a long time with the cursor blinking in the ninth draft, and let himself, once, feel the whole shape of what he was actually doing — closing a door on a woman he had watched grow from a nervous postdoctoral fellow into one of the finest minds his University had ever produced, whose late nights he had covered for more than once, whose research grants he had personally defended in budget meetings that bored him half to death because he had believed, genuinely, that her work mattered. He thought of the small kindness of remembering a colleague's children's names, a thing he had always been rather proud of, and understood that it had never once cost him anything until exactly this moment, when the entire prior decade of that kindness was the only leverage he had left to withhold and still keep himself safe.

He did not know, precisely, what he was afraid of. That was the part he could never fully explain to himself, let alone to anyone else — not a face, not a name, not even a clear threat, just an old, wordless certainty, present in him since long before he'd risen to Provost, that some failures were forgiven and this specific kind never was. He had seen it happen to a colleague once, decades ago, a mathematics chair who'd asked one question too many about an unusual funding pattern and simply stopped being department chair the following term, cheerful and unbothered and slightly vaguer than he used to be about which conferences he'd attended that year. Ter'an had told himself at the time that the man had simply taken a health leave. He had never quite managed to believe his own explanation, and he had never asked another question like it again.

He sent the ninth draft. It was polite, and correct, and it left no warmth in it at all, because warmth was the one thing he could not afford to be caught extending to the wrong person twice.

I do hope you're keeping well, he had written, and meant it more than anything else in the message, and knew, even as he sent it, that meaning it would never once show.



"They know something got through," Maal said, turning the message over the way he'd once turned over troop rotations for a war that had never been real. "They don't know it was us

specifically, or Ter'an wouldn't still be fishing this politely. But they know enough to be actively looking, not just passively guarding. That's a different posture entirely."

"How long before actively looking becomes actually finding?" Al'thea asked.

"Depends how good we are at not being found. Depends how good they are at deciding where to look." Maal set the message down. "I flagged Kestrel Hollow off a pattern in restricted airspace nobody else was watching for. If they're smart — and everything we've learned says they're at least that — they'll eventually run the same kind of search against us. We bought time. We didn't buy safety."

His own leave, he did not need to say, had expired six days ago. Nobody asked what that meant for the version of Captain Maal that still technically existed on a payroll somewhere, fighting a war that had never needed him for anything real. The past week — spent doing something that finally did — only made that clearer.



James found the two of them, Elena and Maal, still turning the message over between them when he came in from wherever he'd spent the last several hours — pacing, Elena guessed, from the

restlessness in how he held himself, the energy of a man who had been arguing with himself and hadn't yet reached a verdict he liked.

"I keep starting the article," he said, without preamble. "In my head. I've started it four different ways. Every version opens with something I can't back up anymore."

"The log," Elena said.

"The log." He sat down heavily. "I had it. For about ninety seconds, back at Kestrel Hollow, I had exactly the kind of evidence that turns a story from 'four traumatised people's shared conviction' into something an editor who's never trusted me could still be forced to run. And it's gone, and what's left instead is the single most certain thing I have ever known in my life, and not one syllable of it would survive a fact-checker for four minutes."

"So don't take it to a fact-checker," Al'thea said. She had come in behind him, quiet enough that nobody had noticed. "Not yet."

"That's the whole problem, isn't it. Not yet has been the answer to everything since I met you all. At some point *not yet* has to become *now*, or it was never actually a plan, just a very long way of putting off deciding I was wrong to start."

"You weren't wrong to start," James said. "You were wrong about the timeline. Those are different sentences too." He allowed himself something that wasn't quite a smile, an echo of a lesson he'd watched her learn nine days ago and hadn't fully believed

she'd kept until just now. "I'm not running the story tonight. I'm not running it next month, probably. Halvorsen's still finding thread after thread in that endowment, and every thread he finds is one more editor who can't dismiss the next one as easily as the last. I'm not building towards a moment where I finally have enough proof to shout the whole truth at once. I don't think that moment exists — I think the Conclave's spent centuries making sure it never could. I'm building towards the moment where enough people are already asking the same question independently that no single story has to carry the whole weight of convincing anyone alone."

"That could take years," Maal said.

"It might take longer than that." James looked, for the first time since Elena had known him, entirely at peace with a sentence that would have terrified him three months ago. "My ancestor spent his whole career not getting an answer, and everything I know, I know because he wrote it down anyway, for whoever came after him to use. I can live with being the version of that who doesn't finish it either. I can't live with being the version who never started."



They scattered before dawn, the way people do when staying together has become its own kind of signature.

Maal went first, because a soldier's goodbyes were always the most practised and the least convincing. He shook James's hand, said something short and dry to Elena that made her almost laugh, and stopped in front of Al'thea longer than any of the others — not for words, in the end, just a nod, the particular one that had meant *I trust you* since Tau Ceti and meant something heavier now. Then he was gone into the pre-dawn dark towards whatever remained of a military career he no longer believed in and could not yet afford to burn, and the sound of his footsteps on the platform's metal grating took a long time to fade entirely.

Elena left next, a single case over one shoulder, everything else already stripped from the quarters she'd never let herself unpack into in the first place. She held Al'thea's hand for a moment at the door — carefully, mindful of the ribs — and said nothing about the wound that wasn't hers that she would carry anyway, because some things didn't need saying twice. Then she turned and walked towards a research position she would have to rebuild from nothing, somewhere Ter'an's reach didn't extend.

James lingered longest, the way he always did when a decision was easier to postpone than finish. He looked back once from the edge of the platform, at Al'thea still sitting exactly where she'd been all morning, and something passed between them that the resonance carried better than his own voice could have. Then he went to find Halvorsen, and the next thread, and the one after that.

Al'thea stayed until last, because someone had to, and because it was Ba'than she was staying for — his recovery was going to need watching, and his remaining silences, she had decided, she was finally prepared to stop mistaking for the whole truth. Krev'an stayed exactly where he'd stayed through every goodbye that morning, settled against her collarbone, apparently unbothered by a scattering that would have unsettled anyone who hadn't already decided, a long time ago, that she was the only permanent address he needed.

The resonance held between them anyway, thinner now with distance, the way a rope holds even when the people on each end can no longer see one another's faces. It was Elena who thought, once, standing alone on a transit platform with a city's ordinary morning noise rising around her, of the phrase the Val'tari themselves used for anything their god's old instructions hadn't anticipated — the language of their own fear, borrowed now, by accident, for exactly what the five of them had become.

Outside Directive.

Nobody had planned for people like this. That, she understood now, standing in a stranger's city with a wound in her side that wasn't hers and a knowledge in her chest that she would carry for the rest of her life, was the whole of what they had left to work with.

It would have to be enough to start.

Chapter 31

Exceptional Minds



Wren Ashby had known her mother was lying about the cat for exactly as long as she'd been old enough to understand what the words meant.

"He's gone to live on a farm," her mother had said, kneeling by the empty basket with red-rimmed eyes, and six-year-old Wren had felt the lie arrive the way other children felt a change in temperature — total, immediate, impossible to argue with, a wrongness in the shape of the sentence itself rather than in anything she could point to and prove. She had not understood, then, that most people didn't feel it. She had simply said, "No he hasn't," in the small,

matter-of-fact voice she used for true things, and watched her mother's face do something complicated that took years for Wren to learn to read as grief layered over fear.

By eight, her parents had stopped trying to comfort her with anything soft. By ten, they had stopped trying to comfort her at all, because comfort and honesty turned out to be, more often than either of them liked, two different things, and Wren could never be fooled into thinking she'd gotten the first when she'd actually only been handed the second, badly disguised. She loved them. She understood, with the same wordless certainty she understood everything else, that they loved her back, and that living with a child who could not be lied to, not once, not ever, not even kindly, had worn something down in both of them that neither had the words to name.

The letter from Halcyon arrived the same month her school stopped quite knowing what to do with her, and used a phrase that made her mother cry with what Wren, for once, correctly read as relief rather than grief: *a specialised environment for exceptional minds, structured for children who perceive more than the world around them is generally prepared to accommodate.*

Nobody had lied to her about what Halcyon was, exactly. That was, she understood only much later, the whole design of the place — you could build something terrible entirely out of things that were, technically, true.



Halcyon's dormitory wing housed nineteen children the term Wren arrived, each of them exceptional in some register the staff never fully explained and the children traded in careful, half-boastful whispers after lights-out. A girl named Priya could solve equations no one had taught her the notation for. A boy everyone called Fisher never forgot a single thing he'd ever heard, word for word, for the rest of his life. And Jonah — small, serious, gap-toothed Jonah, two years older and the only person at Halcyon who never triggered Wren's old, wordless alarm — simply always said the true thing, plainly, the way other people said whatever was easiest, as if lying had never occurred to him as an available option at all.

"You're the only one here who doesn't do it," Wren told him once, in the dining hall, not quite a question.

"Do what?"

"Say things that aren't true, to make a moment smaller than it is."

Jonah considered this with the same unhurried seriousness he gave everything. "I had a cousin who used to say the world runs better on the smaller, easier version of things. He didn't mean it as advice. He said it the way you say something you're angry about." He picked at his food for a moment. "He's a journalist. He wrote something once about people getting quietly moved to jobs that didn't exist, over admin nonsense nobody could explain. He told

me if anything here ever felt wrong-wrong, not just strict-wrong, I should try to find a way to reach him. J. Rawk. That's the byline he writes under." He said it lightly, almost as a joke between them, the way children make private promises they don't expect to ever need.

Wren filed it away exactly because it was true, the way she filed away every true thing anyone had ever handed her — rare, and warm, and hers to keep.



The staff announced Jonah's "advancement" on a Thursday, in the same bright, unhurried tone they used for everything, standing at the front of the dining hall with the same practised warmth Wren had long since learned to read as neither true nor quite a lie — performance, mostly, the emotional equivalent of a photograph of a smile.

"Jonah's been moved up to the Continuing Program," the director said. "Advanced study, off-site. He's very excited. He asked us to tell you all he'll miss you."

It was the sentence *he asked us to tell you all he'll miss you* that did it — arriving in Wren's chest with the total, immediate wrongness of the lie about the cat, except larger, except sharper, except attached this time to the one person at Halcyon who had never given her a reason to doubt anything he said. She sat very still through the rest of the announcement, the way she'd learned to sit

still through anything that mattered too much to let her face say so out loud, and understood, with the slow dawning horror of a person watching a single crack become the whole shape of the wall, that if this was a lie, she needed to ask herself, honestly, how many of the others had been too.

She spent the following week doing the thing she had never let herself do on purpose: listening, deliberately, to every reassurance Halcyon had ever given her, the way she'd normally let them simply wash past. *Your parents visit as often as the program allows. Advancement is always voluntary. Nobody leaves Halcyon before they're ready.*

Every single one of them read false.



She left on a Tuesday, during the supply shuttle's regular Tuesday delivery, because she had spent four years being the kind of child nobody watched closely enough — quiet, exceptional in a register that made adults careful rather than curious, easy to overlook in the same way a fire alarm is easy to overlook until the one day it matters. The shuttle's rear cargo gate stood open for eleven minutes every Tuesday while the pilot signed paperwork with a groundskeeper who genuinely, truly, without a flicker of falseness, complained every single week about the same thing: a delivery schedule that never changed.

Eleven minutes was enough. She was small, and quiet, and had spent four years learning exactly which adults never really looked.

The shuttle let her out fourteen kilometers from Halcyon's gates, at a transit stop neither the pilot nor anyone else ever noticed had gained a passenger. Wren caught her own reflection in the transit stop's dark window while she waited for her legs to stop shaking — dark hair cut short and uneven where she'd trimmed it herself with kitchen scissors the week before, to look less like the photograph Halcyon kept on file; a thin, unremarkable build that had never given away how carefully she watched everything; the same plain, practical clothes every child at Halcyon wore, chosen, she understood only now, precisely so none of them would ever stand out enough to be missed. She stood alone in the parking lot's ordinary, indifferent evening light, eleven years old, with nothing in her pockets and nowhere she'd ever been shown how to go, and one true thing, warm and rare and hers, that she had been saving without knowing exactly what for.

J. Rawk, she thought. *Find a way to reach him.*

She had no idea, yet, how a person found anyone in a world this large. She only knew, with the same unerring certainty that had never been wrong, that it was the one thread in her whole life that had never read as false — and that she was going to follow it until it either led somewhere real or ran out entirely.

Chapter 32

The Next Thread



It took Wren six days to find a name attached to six letters, and she would spend a long time afterward unable to fully explain to anyone how she'd managed it, because the true answer was less a method than a thousand small, careful judgments about which strangers were safe to ask — a skill she'd had her whole life and had simply never before needed for anything larger than knowing which adult, at which moment, was worth trusting with the truth.

A librarian in the fuel stop's nearest town let her sit at a public terminal without asking too many questions, reading correctly, and without being told, that this particular child needed a place to sit more than she needed an explanation for why. A newsstand vendor, three towns further on, in exchange for sweeping his

storefront for two afternoons, remembered which small, unglamorous outlet ran the kind of story nobody paid attention to until years later — administrative irregularities, funding anomalies, the unglamorous beat of a reporter more interested in being right than in being read. "J. Rawk," he said, tapping a byline on a back issue gone soft with handling. "Writes like he's got something bigger he's not saying yet. Always thought that one'd break something real, eventually."

The outlet's public contact address took another two days to actually reach anyone, and Wren spent both of them rehearsing, over and over, the exact true sentence she would need to say first, because she understood by now that the whole of her life had been building towards the one skill she'd never had to use on herself: knowing, precisely, how to make an impossible thing sound like exactly what it was.



James Rawk had spent eleven days building an argument in his head for why the message waiting in his account — *eleven years old, escaped a place called Halcyon, has nowhere else to send this* — deserved five more minutes than every other unverifiable tip that landed in that account on any given week, and had not yet found one that fully satisfied him. He read it a fourth time anyway, in the cramped back office of a contact who owed him nothing and had let him use the terminal regardless, and felt the familiar tug of a detail too oddly precise to have been invented.

Halcyon Academy for Exceptional Minds, the message said. *They told everyone Jonah was moved to the Continuing Program. I know he wasn't, the way I know everything, which is a whole story I can't fit in a message. I got your name from Jonah. He said you'd believe things other people wouldn't. I don't have anywhere else to send this.*

He had learned, across three months of exactly this kind of research, to say plainly when he didn't know something rather than dress the gap up as certainty. He had also learned, the harder way, in a corridor at Kestrel Hollow he still hadn't finished carrying, precisely what it cost to walk past something that turned out to be real because it hadn't yet been proven.

He wrote back the same evening, careful, honest, offering nothing he couldn't actually deliver. *I don't know yet if I can help you. I know I won't find out by not trying. Tell me where you are.*



She was smaller than he'd pictured, and steadier than any eleven-year-old had any right to be, sitting across from him in a diner booth three days later with both hands wrapped around a mug of hot chocolate she hadn't touched, watching him with an attention that made him understand, within the first thirty seconds, exactly what Jonah had meant by *he'll believe things other people wouldn't* — because she wasn't studying him the way a frightened child studies a stranger for danger. She was listening to him the way a person listens for a lie, and finding, apparently, none.

"You actually don't know if you believe me yet," she said, not quite a question, the small satisfaction of someone confirming a fact rather than discovering one. "That's different from most people. Most people decide first and then explain it."

"I try not to," James said. "It doesn't always work. I'm working on it."

"That's true too." She said it simply, the way she said everything, and something in her shoulders came down half an inch, the first visible give since she'd sat down. "I haven't heard anyone say something true to me in six days. Not counting a librarian who told me the bathroom code, which was true but small."

James felt the quiet vertigo of a man watching a case he'd spent three months building on inference and secondhand testimony suddenly acquire a witness who could, apparently, simply *know* — not through anything he understood yet, not through the resonance he still didn't fully have words for even after everything, but through some other, older, more solitary gift that had cost this particular eleven-year-old everything a childhood was supposed to protect.

"Tell me about Jonah," he said. "Everything. Take as long as you need."

She did. It took most of an hour, and by the end of it James had a name, a facility, a pattern that rhymed uncomfortably with three months of "field conditioning annexes" and "extended evaluation

postings" and a manifest he'd never gotten to keep a copy of, and — for the first time since a locked room in Kestrel Hollow had cost him the only physical proof he'd ever have — a live, present, unimpeachable witness sitting across a diner table, watching him with the patient clarity of someone who had spent her whole life being the only person in any room who couldn't be fooled.

"I don't know what happens next," James told her, honestly, because it was the only kind of thing he knew how to tell her. "I know some people. Good people. One of them grew up somewhere that called itself a kindness too, and spent the last eleven months learning exactly how much of what you're describing is real. I'd like you to meet her, if that's alright."

Wren considered this with the same unhurried seriousness Jonah always had, the same close attention of a child checking a sentence for the wrongness she'd spent her whole life listening for, and found, for the first time in longer than she could remember, none at all.

"Okay," she said.

Somewhere else entirely, scattered across a dozen cities and one recovering safe house, four people who had built themselves, without quite deciding to, into exactly the kind of network capable of catching a thread like this one, had no idea yet that the next name on James's list had found him first.

Chapter 33

Someone New to Listen To



James called ahead, which he never did anymore, and said only, "I'm bringing someone. It's not what you're expecting," which told Al'thea nothing and everything at once — enough that she was standing in the doorway of the small rented room she and Ba'than had made into something almost livable when the two of them actually arrived, three weeks and one careful, roundabout journey after Kestrel Hollow.

The girl was smaller than the voice James had let slip once, unannounced, in the background of a call, and steadier, standing very slightly behind him in the way of someone who had learned exactly how much space to take up in an unfamiliar room. She looked at Al'thea for a long moment before either of them spoke

— not the frightened, cataloguing look of a child sizing up a stranger for danger, but something else, something Al'thea didn't have a name for yet and would, before the hour was out, come to understand as the least comfortable kind of attention she had ever been on the receiving end of.

"You're worried this is a bad idea," the girl said, reading it off the same texture of hesitation Al'thea hadn't said out loud. "Not about me specifically. About whether you're steady enough right now to be the one someone gets handed to."

Al'thea felt something in her chest go very still, the unfamiliar stillness of being read by someone who had never once been taught to be polite about it. "James didn't tell you that."

"James didn't have to." Wren said it without cruelty, the plain, unhurried way she said everything. "It's just true. I can tell."



James had explained the shape of it on the way — a facility, children, a gift that read the world's honesty the way Al'thea's own gift once read its version-history — but hearing the mechanism described was nothing at all like standing in a room with it, watching an eleven-year-old parse the exact texture of her own uncertainty before she'd said a single unguarded word out loud.

"How long have you had it," Al'thea asked, once they were sitting, once Ba'than had come to the doorway of the room's second small space and gone very quiet in a way Al'thea recognised as him listening with his whole attention rather than merely his ears.

"Since I was small enough not to know it made me different." Wren considered the room, the two narrow cots, the careful, threadbare economy of people staying somewhere they didn't plan to stay long. "You've been running."

"We have."

"From the same people who ran Halcyon." It wasn't quite a question, the way nothing Wren said ever quite was.

"I think so. I don't know for certain they're the same facility. I know they're the same kind of lie." Al'thea met her eyes, and steeled herself to do the thing she'd spent eleven months learning to do and still, some days, had to choose on purpose rather than by instinct. "I'm not going to tell you it's going to be fine. I don't actually know that yet."

Something in Wren's shoulders came down, the same small, visible give James had noticed from their first meeting. "That's the first true thing anyone's said to me about any of this since I left."



Ba'than crossed the room slowly, the careful economy of a man whose body was still relearning what it was allowed to spend, and lowered himself into the room's one remaining chair with a wince he didn't bother disguising.

"I spent decades inside an institution that called itself a kindness," he said, without introduction, the directness Al'thea had come to understand was his own version of a gift as strange as Wren's own. "I believed it, the way the people who ran your school believed theirs, right up until I didn't anymore. I am sorry that yours found you so young. I was old enough, when mine finally cracked, that I'd already done harm I couldn't undo. You have not done that yet. That is worth more than I think you currently understand."

Wren studied him for a long moment, the same total, careful attention she'd turned on Al'thea. "You're not lying either," she said, quietly, and something in her voice for the first time sounded like a child rather than a small, exhausted adult. "I didn't think there'd be two of you in the same room."

"There's at least three of us, where we're going," Ba'than said, and meant it honestly. "None of us particularly good at it yet. All of us trying." He said it plainly, without the practised warmth of someone reassuring a frightened child, because he had learned, the hard way — not with Wren, not yet, but with people like her — that the ones who could tell the difference trusted the plain version more.



Al'thea watched the two of them, and felt the old, familiar pull of her own certainty rising — the wordless urge to promise this child a safety she had no actual way to guarantee, because promising felt so much better than the slower, harder work of simply being honest about not knowing yet. *Just say it'll be fine,* the old voice offered, reasonable as ever, already halfway to convincing. *She's eleven. She needs to hear it more than she needs it to be true.* She recognised the reflex the instant it arrived, the same one she'd spent this whole ordeal learning to catch. *I know exactly what you are,* she told it — the same four words she'd used at Kestrel Hollow, except this time she meant them a half-second before her hands could act on anything, not after. And this time, for once, catching it didn't cost her anything at all to hold.

"I can't promise you it'll be fine," she said again, because the truth was still the truth even said twice. "I can promise I'll actually listen when you tell me something's wrong, instead of deciding first and explaining it to you after. I've gotten better at that. Recently. I'm still learning."

Wren looked at her for one more long moment, weighing the sentence the only way she knew how to weigh anything, and found, apparently, nothing false in it at all.

"Okay," she said, the same word she'd given James in a diner three weeks before, though it already felt like someone else's memory, and settled, for the first time since Halcyon's gate, into something that was almost, carefully, the beginning of rest.



James stood by the window through most of it, saying little, the way he'd learned to do whenever the thing actually happening mattered more than anything he could add to it. He had spent three months building an argument in his own head for why a slow, patient network of independent questioners would eventually matter more than one dramatic story he could never fully prove — an argument he'd believed, and defended, and never once been able to point at and say *here, this is what it actually looks like when it works.*

It looked like this. A child who trusted almost no one, finding, in a room she'd never been in before, two people who couldn't lie to her even if they'd wanted to. He thought of Halvorsen, thirty years into a search he'd never finished, and understood, watching Al'thea choose her words with the deliberate care of someone who had learned exactly what carelessness cost, that this was the only kind of proof his whole strategy had ever actually promised — not a single undeniable moment, but a slow accumulation of exactly this, one true room at a time, for as long as it took to matter.

He did not say any of that out loud. Some things, he was learning, mattered more once you let them simply be true without needing to explain why — a lesson his own ancestor had never quite gotten to learn, three centuries and one unfinished case ago, and one James intended to keep learning for as long as it took.



Later, once Wren had finally fallen asleep on the narrower of the two cots, worn through by a day too large for even her unusual composure to fully carry, Al'thea sat by the room's one window, Krev'an settled against her collarbone the way Ny'sol had every quiet night for eleven months before he'd finally had a name and a choice of his own to carry, and let herself feel the whole shape of what had just happened rather than managing it the way she managed everything else.

She thought, watching the girl's slow breathing, of her own leaving — the surveillance file Ba'than had shown her once, the tradecraft he'd taught her without ever quite calling it that, the loneliness of walking away from the only home she'd ever known with nobody left behind who'd notice the shape of her absence for what it actually was. Wren had left the same way, in the end, whatever the difference in scale — alone, on nothing but her own resourcefulness, trusting a single unverified thread because the alternative was staying somewhere that had already shown her exactly what it was capable of deciding on her behalf. Al'thea had needed eleven months and a rescue she hadn't asked for to learn

what this eleven-year-old already seemed to understand on her own: that leaving was only ever the first half of the work, and the harder part was learning who was safe to actually arrive to.

"You're thinking about the ones this didn't happen for," Ba'than said quietly, from the doorway.

"I'm thinking about how much of it was luck. James happened to be findable. Jonah happened to say one true thing before he disappeared. If either of those had gone differently, she'd still be there, believing whatever they'd finally gotten around to telling her." Al'thea watched the girl's slow, even breathing in the dim light. "How many didn't get the version of this where someone finds them in time?"

"I don't know," Ba'than said, and for once did not soften it with anything gentler than the truth. "I know it's more than one. I know it's more than we'll ever be able to count precisely, which is its own kind of answer." He was quiet for a moment, turning something over he clearly hadn't intended to say out loud, before he said it anyway. "I know that not being able to count them is not the same thing as not owing them anything. I spent decades telling myself it was."

Al'thea said nothing further. She had learned, this past year, the difference between a silence that meant she'd run out of things to feel and one that meant she was finally letting herself feel all of them at once, and this, she understood, watching a child sleep in a

room built for people who couldn't yet promise her safety, was unmistakably the second kind — the kind that asked nothing of her except to stay in it a while longer than felt comfortable.

Somewhere else entirely, in a room with a brass plate bearing only a surname and no floor number, Naomi Reyes slept through another ordinary night at Continuing Education Annex 14, still believing, in the plain way a person believes a story they have not yet been given a reason to doubt, that a fellowship was exactly what the letter had called it — and the list James was still, patiently, one honest name at a time, building against exactly this kind of silence had not yet found any thread that led to her at all.